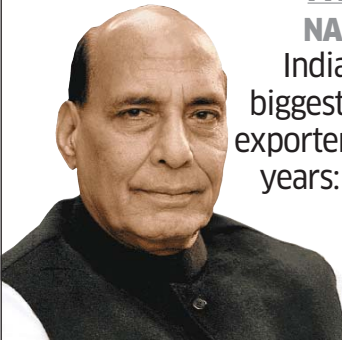


PAGE 5

NATION

India to be biggest weapon exporter in 25-30 years: Rajnath



PAGE 6

NATION

West Bengal gained infamy due to recruitment scams: CM



PAGE 9

GLOBAL

Estonia to be gateway to Europe market for India: Envoy



PAGE 11

SPORTS

More than having maturity, it's about shot selection: Ishan Kishan



AGENDA

INDIA'S NORDIC PUSH



ONWARD NORTH

# Gymkhana Club asked to vacate premises

## Centre to take over 27.3 acres of land on June 5, 2026 for public and defence infrastructure

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

In a significant move, the Centre has asked the Gymkhana Club in Lutyens' Delhi located at 2 Safdarjung Road, to hand over its premises by June 5, citing that the land was required for urgent public and securing defence infrastructure". An order to this effect has been issued by the Land and Development Office under the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry. The Land & Development Office is scheduled to take over the premises on June 5, 2026. Spread across nearly 27.3 acres on Safdarjung Road, the club building was designed by famed British

architect Robert Tor Russell — who also designed Connaught Place and Teen Murti House. Tucked beside the imposing Ashoka trees and the power corridors of the Capital, the Delhi Gymkhana Club has for over a century symbolised power, elitism, exclusivity, access, colonial influence and above all privilege. Its membership defined people's status in the Delhi high society. "The premises, situated at 2, Safdarjung Road, New Delhi, were leased to the Imperial Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd for the specific purpose of maintaining a social and sporting club," said the order. It is one of India's oldest

The entrance gate of Delhi Gymkhana Club in New Delhi PTI

and most prestigious social and sporting clubs. The club shifted to its present location in 1913 and was then known as the "Imperial Delhi Gymkhana Club", with Spencer Harcourt Butler serving as its first President. After India attained Independence in 1947, the word "Imperial" was dropped, and the institution

came to be known simply as the Delhi Gymkhana Club. The club traces its origins to July 1913. It became a prominent gathering place for civil servants, military officers, diplomats, business leaders, and members of India's elite. In its early years, the Polo Club functioned as part of the Gymkhana Club before becoming a separate entity in the 1930s after shifting to New Delhi. Historical records relating to the club's origins are limited, and systematic documentation of its history is understood to have begun only around 1927. The order further states that the entire land parcel, along with all buildings, structures, lawns and fittings standing on it, shall vest absolutely with the President of India through the Land & Development Office. "In exercise of the powers conferred under Clause 4 of the Lease Deed, the President of India, through the Land & Development Office, hereby determines the lease and orders re-entry of the afore-said premises with immediate effect," it stated. "Upon such re-entry, the entire plot of land measuring 27.3 acres, along with all buildings, standing erections, structures, lawns, and fittings thereon, shall vest absolutely in the lessor, ie, the President of India, through the Land & Development Office." RELATED REPORTS ON >> P3 CONTINUED ON >> P4

# Fuel prices hiked for third time in 10 days

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

In the third hike in 10 days, petrol prices went up by 87 paise, and diesel prices are up by 91 paise as of Saturday. The price of petrol now stands at ₹99.51 per litre, while diesel costs ₹92.49 per litre. Additionally, Compressed Natural Gas (CNG) prices were raised by ₹1 per kg, marking the third increase in recent days and taking the cumulative hike to ₹4 per kg. It now costs ₹81.09 per kilo in the National Capital. This is the third increase in rates since May 15, when State-owned oil companies started passing on the elevated energy prices arising from the Middle East conflict in a calibrated manner. With the latest hike, petrol and diesel prices have risen to nearly ₹5 a litre. As political sparring intensifies over the latest fuel price hikes, a detailed note defending the Centre's fuel pricing strategy claims that State-level taxes, and not central excise duty alone, are the biggest reason behind the sharp variation in petrol and diesel prices across India. In an informal note, the Government, in the backdrop of three consecutive fuel price revisions this month, argues that petrol and diesel remain the costliest in States such as Telangana and Kerala due to higher Value Added Tax (VAT), while rates are relatively lower in Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh, Delhi, Haryana, Goa and Assam.

| City    | Fuel Type | May 14 | May 15 | May 16 | May 17 | May 18 | May 19 | May 20 | May 21 | May 22 | May 23 |
|---------|-----------|--------|--------|--------|--------|--------|--------|--------|--------|--------|--------|
| Mumbai  | Petrol    | 94.77  | 94.77  | 95.64  | 95.51  | 96.38  | 96.38  | 97.25  | 97.25  | 98.12  | 98.99  |
|         | Diesel    | 87.51  | 87.51  | 88.38  | 88.25  | 89.12  | 89.12  | 90.00  | 90.00  | 90.87  | 91.74  |
| Kolkata | Petrol    | 105.45 | 105.45 | 106.32 | 106.19 | 107.06 | 107.06 | 107.93 | 107.93 | 108.80 | 109.67 |
|         | Diesel    | 92.02  | 92.02  | 92.89  | 92.76  | 93.63  | 93.63  | 94.50  | 94.50  | 95.37  | 96.24  |
| Chennai | Petrol    | 100.84 | 100.84 | 101.71 | 101.58 | 102.45 | 102.45 | 103.32 | 103.32 | 104.19 | 105.06 |
|         | Diesel    | 92.30  | 92.30  | 93.17  | 93.04  | 93.91  | 93.91  | 94.78  | 94.78  | 95.65  | 96.52  |

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# PIONEER IN SHORT

## COAL MINE EXPLOSION IN CHINA KILLS 90

Ninety miners were killed in a gas explosion in a coal mine in north China's Shanxi Province, while all-out rescues are underway to reach those still unaccounted for, official media in Beijing reported on Saturday. A total of 247 workers were underground when the accident occurred on Friday evening at the Liushenyu coal mine in Qinyuan County, Changzhi. Mining disasters are common in energy-hungry China, and are largely attributed to poor working conditions and a weak regulatory framework. The death toll rose to 90 following the accident, while around 123 people of those rescued are receiving treatment at hospitals, including two in critical condition and two in serious condition. Nine people remain unaccounted for as rescue operations continue to locate them, State-run media reported. Chinese President Xi Jinping has issued instructions for a comprehensive rescue operation and treatment of the injured. He has called for proper handling of the aftermath of the accident and sought a thorough investigation into its cause, with accountability pursued in accordance with the law. Xi has stressed that authorities across the country must learn from the accident, remain vigilant on workplace safety.

FULL REPORT ON P9

## ARMY OFFICERS SURVIVE CHOPPER CRASH IN LEH

A senior Indian Army commander and two pilots survived injuries after a Cheetah light helicopter crashed in the high-altitude Ladakh sector on May 20, prompting the Army to order a formal investigation into the incident. The aircraft was on a routine flight in the strategically sensitive region when it met with an accident. It was carrying three personnel, including Division Commander Major General Sachin Mehta and two pilots, all of whom sustained injuries after the helicopter went down. The Indian Army has instituted a Court of Inquiry to examine technical, mechanical and environmental factors that may have led to the crash. Officials said a detailed probe has been initiated to determine the exact cause of the incident.

# PM Modi gets White House invitation

## Rubio pushes for US energy partnership amid Iran conflict

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday held high-stakes discussions with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio on trade, regional security, and energy cooperation, as Washington sought to deepen strategic ties with New Delhi amid growing instability in West Asia following the Iran conflict. During the meeting, Rubio conveyed an invitation from US President Donald Trump for Modi to visit the White House, signalling Washington's intent to maintain close engagement with India despite recent tensions over tariffs, energy purchases, and trade negotiations under the Trump administration's second term. The three-day visit by Rubio comes at a delicate phase in India-US relations. While both countries continue to strengthen defence and strategic cooperation, economic disagreements have increasingly tested the partnership. Trade disputes, concerns over market access, and differing positions on energy imports have complicated ties in recent months, even as both Governments publicly stress the importance of the relationship. The ongoing conflict involving Iran has added a new layer of urgency to the discussions. Global energy

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Prime Minister Narendra Modi with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio during a meeting in New Delhi on Saturday PTI

markets have witnessed renewed volatility amid fears of supply disruptions and rising oil prices, placing major import-dependent economies such as India under pressure. According to officials familiar with the talks, Marco Rubio pitched the United States as a stable and long-term energy partner capable of helping India diversify its energy

# Trump tightens green card rules, applicants in limbo

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The administration of Donald Trump has announced sweeping changes to the US immigration system, requiring most green card applicants already living in the United States to leave the country and complete their permanent residency applications from their home nations. The new policy, unveiled on Friday by the US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS), marks a major shift in immigration procedures and has sparked concern among international students, temporary workers, and families awaiting residency approvals. Under the revised rules, foreign nationals seeking lawful permanent resident status — commonly known as a green card — will generally no longer be allowed to complete the

process while remaining in the United States. Instead, applicants must attend visa interviews and final processing at a US embassy or consulate abroad, unless they qualify under what officials described as "extraordinary circumstances." Previously, many immigrants residing in the US on student, tourist, or temporary work visas could apply for permanent residency through a process known as "Adjustment of Status," allowing them to remain in the country while their applications were processed. Immigration advocates say the new policy could create significant uncertainty for thousands of applicants who may now face lengthy wait times, travel restrictions, and the risk of being unable to re-enter the United States after departing. The structure has faced

# PM gives appointment letters to 51,000 youths

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday said India's international partnerships are purposefully structured to serve the country's youth and leaders of global corporations, representing dozens of nations, have talked about India's youth and its technological advancement. After virtually distributing appointment letters for Central Government jobs to more than 51,000 youths at a 'Rozgar Mela', Modi also said the youth will play a crucial role in realising the vision of a 'Viksit Bharat' (developed India) in the years to come. Sharing insights from his just-concluded five-country

tour, the Prime Minister conveyed the excitement that leaders of global corporations, representing dozens of nations, had expressed about India's youth and its technological advancement. "The world wants to be a part of India's development journey," he said. Modi made it clear that India's international partnerships are purposefully structured to serve its youth.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

# SC takes suo motu cognisance of Twisha Sharma case; to hear matter on May 25

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bhopal

The Supreme Court on Saturday took suo motu cognisance of the Twisha Sharma 'dowry' death case over alleged institutional bias and procedural discrepancies in the matter. According to the details uploaded on the apex court website, the court registered the suo moto case after taking note of media reports and other attending circumstances. A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi is scheduled to hear the matter on May 25. The suo moto case is titled "alleged institutional bias and procedural discrepancies in the unnatural death

of a young girl at her matrimonial home". Earlier in the day, the Bhopal court on Saturday sent Samarth Singh, husband of deceased actor-model Twisha Sharma, to police remand in the alleged dowry death case that has drawn nationwide attention and intensified demands for a high-level investigation. Samarth Singh, who had been absconding since registration of the case, was taken into custody in Jabalpur after appearing before a court to surrender. The Bar Council of India (BCI) has suspended the licence of advocate Samarth Singh with immediate effect. Following the court's directions, AIIMS Delhi has constituted a four-member medical board to conduct the second autopsy. Chief of Forensic Medicine at AIIMS Delhi, Dr Sudhir Gupta, said the High Court authorised the AIIMS director to form the expert panel after a request was received from the Madhya Pradesh Government.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

# Football-theme sculpture at Salt Lake stadium razed

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi/Kolkata

The West Bengal Government on Saturday morning demolished the football-themed sculpture located outside the VVIP gate of the Salt Lake Stadium, officially known as Vivekananda Yuba Bharati Krirangan (VYBK). Workers removed the Biswa Bangla logo parts first, then the rest of the structure. State Sports Minister Nisith Pramanik had announced the decision to demolish the sculpture earlier in the week. The structure has faced

sustained criticism from football fans since its installation nearly a decade ago, who called it "bizarre, meaningless, ugly and grotesque." The demolition is part of the BJP-led Government's effort to update the stadium's look and facilities. The sculpture was erected in 2017 before the FIFA U-17 World Cup, during Mamata Banerjee's tenure as chief minister. It showed a footballer's legs in shorts and socks with a football on top, often featuring the Biswa Bangla logo and the word "Joyi." The design aimed to

Left, the controversial football-themed sculpture outside the Salt Lake Stadium designed by former chief minister Mamata Banerjee. Right, the football-themed sculpture was removed by the Government in Kolkata, West Bengal on Saturday PTI

reflect Bengal's football culture and Kolkata's importance in the sport. The sculpture stood near the stadium entrance, where fans, players, and visitors could see it. Some people saw it as a tribute to football in a state famous for clubs like Mohun Bagan Super Giant and East Bengal FC. However, many criticised its proportions and design, often calling it a "headless torso with legs and a ball on top." From the start, the sculpture faced heavy criticism on social media.

CONTINUED ON >> P4



# Gymkhana eviction notice: Uncertainty looms over 600 staff

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Uncertainty loomed over nearly 600 employees of the iconic Delhi Gymkhana Club on Saturday after the Centre directed it to hand over its premises by June 5, leaving the staff anxious over their future amid a lack of clarity on job security and transition plans.

The order, issued by the Land and Development Office (L&DO) under the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry, said the 27.3-acre land in Lutyens' Delhi was required for "urgent institutional needs, governance infrastructure and public interest project", including strengthening defence-related infrastructure.

It further stated that "the premises shall be taken over by the Land and Development Office on June 5."

In its communication dated May 22, the L&DO said the premises at 2, Safdarjung Road were originally leased to the Imperial Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd (now Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd) for maintaining a social and sporting club, and are now required for broader public purpose projects linked

with the adjoining Government land.

Inside the sprawling premises located near Lok Kalyan Marg, the atmosphere on Saturday evening was marked by unease, with employees saying they had received no formal briefing from the management on the future course of action.

A staff member said workers came to know of the development only recently and were left unsettled by the abruptness of the order.

"There has been no formal meeting with employees so far. Most of us are still waiting for clarity on what happens to our jobs after June 5," the employee said.

Among those affected are also long-serving workers who have spent decades maintaining the club's facilities.

A gardener working at the tennis lawns, who has been associated with the club for 17 years, said he was carrying out his usual afternoon routine of trimming the grass and tending to the courts when he first heard about the development.

"I was in the lawn, cutting the grass and maintaining the court area as part of my



regular duty when someone told me around 4 pm that the club may be shut down by early June," he said.

He added that there had been no prior indication from the administration during the course of the day, leaving workers to process the information informally as it began circulating within staff groups.

"Nothing like this has ever happened in all these years of working here. We just heard it suddenly while doing our work. There was no notice or warning before this," he said.

A club official said internal

discussions were underway on legal and administrative options, stressing that an abrupt shutdown of such a large institution was not straightforward.

"This is a very large institution with a long history and a prominent membership base. An immediate shutdown without transition is not practically feasible," the official said.

Other workers said the absence of communication from the administration had added to anxiety, with many unsure whether salaries, employment contracts or

redeployment options would be safeguarded.

Two women working at a private cafe operating within the club premises on a lease basis said their situation was comparatively clearer as they are employed by an external company. "If the cafe shuts here, we will likely be transferred to another outlet," one of them said, adding that the uncertainty was more severe for direct club employees.

"People who are directly employed by the club have no clarity at all. There is a lot of confusion," she said.

| A LIST OF SOME OF DELHI'S PROMINENT HERITAGE CLUBS AND INSTITUTIONS, WHICH, TOGETHER, REFLECT THE CAPITAL'S LAYERED POLITICAL, ADMINISTRATIVE AND SOCIAL HISTORY                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Delhi Golf Club</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Established in the early 1930s by the British administration</li><li>Originally developed as a recreational facility for civil servants and officers.</li><li>Known for its Lodhi Course built around Mughal and Tughlaq-era monuments</li></ul> | <b>Roshanara Club</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Established on August 15, 1922, within the historic Roshanara Bagh near DU's North Campus</li><li>Closely linked to the early development of cricket administration in India</li></ul>                                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Originally conceived as a social space for the members of the Constituent Assembly</li><li>Continues to serve as an interaction and networking hub for current and ex-MPs</li></ul>                                                                                         |
| <b>Press Club of India</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Founded in 1957 by noted editor Durga Das near Parliament House in Central Delhi</li><li>Serves as one of the country's leading platforms for journalists and media professionals</li></ul>                                                  | <b>India Habitat Centre</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Established in 1993 as a multi-use cultural and intellectual hub</li><li>Designed by noted architect Joseph Allen Stein</li><li>Hosts exhibitions, cultural programmes, discussions and public events</li></ul> | <b>India Islamic Cultural Centre</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Established in the 1980s on Lodhi Road in central Delhi to promote India's composite culture and heritage</li><li>Functions as a cultural and intellectual centre hosting seminars, literary events and community programmes</li></ul> |
| <b>Chelmsford Club</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Originally founded in 1917-1918; named after then-Viceroy of India, Chelmsford</li><li>Permanently shifted to Raisina Road in 1928</li><li>One of Delhi's prominent clubs, it has hosted several</li></ul>                                       | <b>Constitution Club of India</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Established in February 1947 near Parliament House</li></ul>                                                                                                                                              | <b>Foreign Correspondents' Club of South Asia</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Established in 1958 on Mathura Road</li><li>Set up as a professional and social platform for foreign journalists reporting from South Asia</li></ul>                                                                      |

## Centre's order asking Gymkhana Club to hand over premises brings focus on Govt's legal powers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The Centre's order asking the Gymkhana Club in Lutyens' Delhi to hand over the 27.3-acre premises to it for "strengthening and securing defence infrastructure" has brought into focus the legal powers available to the Union Government and the Land and Development Office (L&DO).

In cases like the Gymkhana Club, the Centre's power flows from the terms of the lease deed.

Besides, the Centre has

constitutional powers relating to acquisition of property and there are statutory provisions governing public premises.

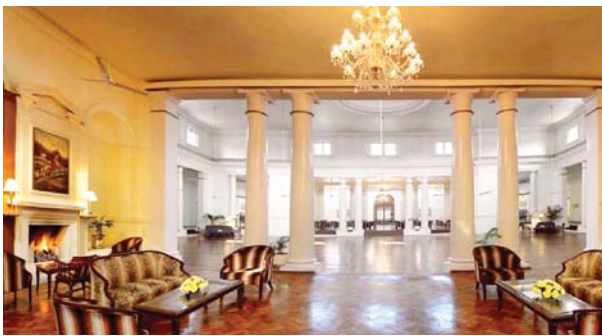
Legal experts say the government can take over a property or terminate leases, depending on the nature of ownership and the character of the land.

Where the land belongs to the government and has merely been leased to a private body, club or institution, the government can invoke the re-entry or termination clauses contained in the lease deed in cases of

breach of conditions, misuse of land, expiry of the lease tenure or overriding public purpose.

In the present case, the L&DO has issued the order saying the premises, located in a highly-sensitive and strategic area of the national capital, are critically required for the strengthening and securing of defence infrastructure and other vital public-security purposes.

The action was initiated through the invocation of Clause 4 of the original lease deed executed in favour of the then Imperial



Delhi Gymkhana Club.

In Lutyens' Delhi, areas are owned by the President of India and administered through the L&DO, and many

clubs and institutions function on leasehold land rather than freehold plots.

Legal action in such cases usually proceeds through the

termination of lease, resumption of land and eviction proceedings under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act, 1971. Under the Public Premises Act, once a lease is terminated, continued occupation may be treated as unauthorised, enabling eviction proceedings through an estate officer appointed by the Centre.

Apart from contractual powers, the Centre can also acquire private property through the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land

Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013.

However, such acquisition applies in cases of private properties and not on leased government land where compensation rights may be limited because the ownership remains vested in the government.

Article 300A of the Constitution protects property rights by providing that no person shall be deprived of property except by the authority of law.

There have been judgments from various courts, including the Supreme Court,

that held that the State cannot arbitrarily dispossess citizens and must follow due process, including notice, hearing and compensation, wherever acquisition laws apply.

Experts say there are judgments that have emphasised that the government's power to resume leased land is not absolute and the power of a judicial review is available on various grounds, such as arbitrariness, mala fides, violation of lease conditions, discrimination, lack of public purpose or a breach of the principles of natural justice.

## Heatwave triggers dehydration crisis among birds, street animals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

As the summer sun scorches rooftops and concrete lanes across Delhi, city veterinarians and animal rescuers say exhausted pigeons are dropping unconscious from the sky, dehydrated eagles are being picked up from roadsides and street animals are suffering from stomach toxicity amid the Capital's punishing heatwave.

Across the city, veterinarians and rescuers say that distress calls involving birds and stray animals suffering from dehydration, heat strokes, and infections have risen sharply over the past few weeks as prolonged dry conditions and extreme temperatures continue to batter Delhi and the NCR.

Delhi has been reeling under heatwave conditions over the past few days, with temperatures crossing the 45 degrees Celsius mark in several areas, leading to heat strokes, extremely dry conditions, and warm nights.

A veterinarian at Abhay Daanam Bird and Animal Hospital in the Delhi-NCR region said the facility is receiving nearly 20 bird cases daily linked to heat-related illnesses, marking around a 50



per cent rise in recent weeks.

"Most of the birds coming to us are pigeons. A large number of them are suffering from pigeon pox, an infection that spreads more during periods of extreme heat and poor conditions. We are also getting other kinds of birds, besides horses and cows that are being brought in with dehydration, heat strokes, and immovable conditions," he said.

Pigeon pox is a viral disease affecting pigeons and other birds and causes lesions, weakness, and feeding difficulties. Experts said extreme heat, stress, and unhygienic surroundings often aggravate the spread of such infections.

A veterinarian working in

the Shahdara and Chandni Chowk areas said he is currently receiving nearly 70 to 80 cases everyday involving birds suffering from dehydration, breathlessness, and heat-related distress.

"Most of the cases are of pigeons, black kites, and eagles. Many birds are brought to us in unconscious states because of the heatwave. We are giving them ORS and fluids to help them regain consciousness and recover," he said.

"Some birds arrive in extremely critical condition and we are unable to save them. But when we get calls in the early stages, treatment becomes easier and survival chances improve significantly," he added.

**LIGHT RAIN LASHES PARTS OF CITY**

**New Delhi:** After days of searing heat, strong winds, thunderstorms, and light rain in parts of Delhi brought much-needed respite to residents of the national capital early Saturday.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD), which had initially issued an orange alert, changed it to yellow for the day, warning of light rain and gusty winds. However, it said orange alerts remain in place from Sunday for the next five days, signalling a return of the intense heatwave.

According to IMD data till 8.30 am, the Ridge station received 0.2 mm of rain between 11.30 pm on Friday and 2.30 am on Saturday, while Pusa logged 2 mm between 5.30 am and 8.30 am on Saturday. No significant rainfall was recorded elsewhere.

IMD said temporary relief from heatwave conditions is expected over northwest India, including Delhi, Punjab, Haryana, and Chandigarh, due to thunderstorm activity over the region, but temperatures are likely to

rise again from Sunday onwards.

It said, wind speeds during the dust storm and thunderstorm activity early Saturday were recorded at up to 81 kmph at Pusa Road, 56 kmph at Palam, and 35 kmph at Pragati Maidan.

A significant reduction in visibility was also recorded at Palam airport, where visibility dropped from 3,500 metres to 1,500 metres within one hour.

However, IMD later informed that the current spell of winds and thunderstorms had moved southeastwards, away from Delhi.

"Very light to light rain, accompanied by thunderstorms, lightning, and dust storms, is expected on Saturday. Strong surface winds of speed 40-50 kmph might also continue," said an IMD official.

Meanwhile, Safdarjung, representative of the city's weather, recorded a minimum temperature of 28.4 degrees Celsius on Saturday, 1.7 degrees above the season's average and 0.9 degrees lower than the day before.

## MCD cancels Nehru Hill Park allotment for Eid celebrations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Amid the allegations of operating illegal selling of goats in Nehru Hill Park near Ramliila Maidan, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Saturday cancelled the permission to use the site allotted for Eid celebrations, an official order said.

The move comes days after the civic body's horticulture department had complained to Delhi police on May 12 and May 14 about the alleged illegal use of the park for buying and selling of goats.

In an official order issued on Saturday, the assistant director (Horticulture), City-SP Zone, said permission granted to a residents'



welfare association representative for use of the park from May 21 to May 27 stood "withdrawn/cancelled with immediate effect".

The official order stated that "activities" were being carried out at the site in violation of the conditions of the permission granted.

"You are directed to vacate

the site forthwith and remove all related activities/material from the premises immediately," the order said, while seeking assistance from the IP Estate police station to ensure compliance.

The permission had reportedly been granted after payment of around ₹1.07 lakh, Delhi BJP alleged.

## CM inspects Made-in-India air purification technologies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday inspected three state-of-the-art Made-in-India air purification technologies installed in the capital. These technologies have been specifically developed to tackle urban air pollution, including dust, smoke, PM2.5, PM10 and other harmful pollutants.

Delhi Environment Minister Sardar Manjinder Singh Sirsa was also present during the inspection. During the visit, the Chief Minister reviewed the advanced pollution-control systems and sought detailed information from officials regarding their functioning, pollution-reduction capabilities and the results achieved so far.

She also held detailed dis-

cussions on their operation, maintenance requirements, capacity and the potential for large-scale deployment across Delhi.

The Chief Minister first inspected the STR-101 filter-free air purifier system installed on Sat Guru Ram Singh Marg (Rama Road). A total of 21 units have been installed on electricity poles located along the central verge of the road.

This modern outdoor air purification system is capable of reducing smoke, dust, PM1, PM2.5, PM10, carbon particles and other pollutants present in the air. Its high-frequency chip technology also works to neutralise bacteria and viruses in the atmosphere, thereby helping improve air quality.

The Chief Minister said the system has the capacity to



purify nearly three lakh litres of air every hour. It also helps reduce harmful gases such as sulphur dioxide, nitrogen dioxide and carbon monoxide. One of its key features is that it is a completely filter-free, self-cleaning and low-maintenance system that requires no consumable materials. It is also equipped with IoT-based live monitoring and data-track-

ing facilities, allowing continuous oversight of its performance.

The Chief Minister then inspected India's first EV-based anti-smog gun operating on the Kirti Nagar-Mayapuri stretch. This is a completely zero-emission and mobile system that can be deployed in different locations as required. The system is equipped with real-time

PM sensors and an IoT-based control mechanism that automatically operates according to air quality conditions, ensuring savings in both water and energy.

The Chief Minister also inspected the PAWAN III roadside air pollution control device installed near the Kirti Nagar Fire Station.

The technology has been developed to capture pollution emitted by vehicles close to its source. Installed on roadside dividers, the system draws in polluted air through a high-capacity suction mechanism and releases clean air back into the atmosphere after passing it through a multi-stage purification process. The system is capable of controlling pollution before it spreads into the surrounding environment.

## IN FOCUS



## Bank manager arrested for ₹8.70 crore currency chest theft in Gujarat



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Ahmedabad

Ahmedabad police have arrested a bank manager accused of orchestrating a ₹8.70 crore theft from a currency chest linked to the Reserve Bank of India.

The accused was apprehended near Kadodara-Kim after evading authorities by frequently changing locations. Investigators said the suspect allegedly exploited internal system vulnerabilities to remove the large sum of cash without immediate detection. The case came to light during an internal audit, which revealed discrepancies in the currency reserves, prompting a formal complaint and a detailed probe.

## PM Modi gets White House invitation

"The United States and India share a common vision for a free, open, and stable Indo-Pacific," officials familiar with the meeting said, underscoring concerns in Washington over Beijing's growing assertiveness in the South China Sea and along critical maritime trade routes.

India has long been viewed by successive US administrations as a crucial strategic counterweight to China in the region. Defence cooperation between the two nations has expanded significantly over the past decade, with growing collaboration in military exercises, technology sharing, and intelligence coordination. However, analysts note that New Delhi has continued to maintain its strategic autonomy, balancing ties with Washington while preserving relations with countries such as Russia and Iran.

The Modi-Rubio meeting also touched on broader regional security issues, including maritime security, supply-chain resilience, and emerging technologies. Officials said both sides reiterated their commitment to strengthening cooperation through forums such as the Quad grouping, which includes India, the United States, Japan, and Australia.

Diplomatic observers believe the White House invitation extended to Modi is aimed at reinforcing political momentum in the relationship at a time when global geopolitical alignments are rapidly shifting. The invitation also comes as both governments prepare for a fresh round of trade negotiations that could shape the future direction of economic ties between the two countries.

Despite periodic disagreements, India and the United States have continued to deepen engagement across defence, technology, and strategic sectors, reflecting what both sides describe as one of the most consequential partnerships of the 21st century.

## Football-theme sculpture at Salt Lake stadium razed

Sports Minister Nisith Pramanik shared these opinions when he announced the removal. After an Indian Super League Kolkata derby, he said, "Such an ugly-looking statue, two legs cut at the torso and football above it does not make sense. It does not look aesthetically pleasing either, so we will not keep such a grotesque structure that has no meaning." He added that the demolition was not only about appearance but also a necessary step to upgrade the stadium. The venue holds 85,000 people and has a long history of hosting major matches, famous derbies, and international games.

Because the sculpture was installed under the previous Trinamool Congress (TMC) Government, its removal sparked political conflict. TMC rep-

# Nadda holds high-level meet with Suvendu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Union Health Minister JP Nadda on Saturday held a high-level review meeting with West Bengal (WB) Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari, during which discussions were held on signing an MoU for the implementation of Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB PM-JAY) in the state, enabling eligible beneficiaries to access healthcare benefits without delay.

According to a health ministry statement, Nadda said that nearly 1.45 crore families, including senior citizens, would be covered under AB PM-JAY and are expected to benefit from expanded healthcare coverage and interventions once the scheme is implemented in West Bengal.

During the virtual meeting, Adhikari requested the Centre's support and guidance for the effective implementation of the scheme in the state, aiming to ensure that affordable healthcare reaches vulnerable and underserved popula-



MoS Sukanta Majumdar, Pro-tem Speaker Tapas Roy, State Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari and others after attending the 19th edition of Rozgar Mela in Kolkata

PTI

tions. Nadda also emphasised the need for the state to expedite the rollout of HPV vaccinations.

The meeting included discussions on strengthening healthcare services, the implementation of key health programs, and the effective

utilisation of funds under the National Health Mission (NHM), PM-ABHIM, and other flagship schemes, the statement said.

Discussions were also held on achieving Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) through

## UP to launch Dream Labs in 600 Govt schools



in advanced technologies such as Artificial Intelligence (AI), Robotics, Internet of Things (IoT), 3D Printing, advanced manufacturing, battery-operated electric vehicles, electronics, agricultural science, renewable energy, drone technology and design thinking, the statement read.

This project is in line with the National Education Policy 2020, National Skills Qualification Framework (NSQF) and Skill India Mission with the objectives to develop innovation, problem-solving ability, technical efficiency and entrepreneurship skills among students, it said.

Representatives from global companies, including Yaskawa, Mastercam, 3D Systems, AjnaLens and Ace Micromatic, participated in the programme and described the initiative as a strong bridge between education and industry. They said that Dream Labs will provide students with real industrial experience and connect them with better employment and entrepreneurship opportunities, the statement added.

gain practical and employment-oriented skills along with traditional education. She laid special emphasis on the effective operation of the hub and spoke model, installation of machinery, quality of trainers, regular attendance of students and result-based monitoring. She said, "Just as a strong beginning is important, it is equally necessary to take it towards successful implementation, especially in the aspirational districts."

Under this project, a total of 600 schools across all 75

districts of the state, including 150 hub schools and 450 spoke schools, have been included, an official statement said.

In the first phase, Dream Labs will be established in 18 hubs and 54 spoke schools. In the second phase, in 36 hubs and 108 spoke schools.

In the third phase, in 96 hubs and 288 spoke schools, it added. The labs will be developed as modern innovation and skill development centres, where students from Classes 9 to 12 will receive practical training

## FROM PAGE - 1

number of members. There is no security threat or any such concern," he said. "As a member, I feel the observations made in the order should be reconsidered and such a situation should not have arisen," he added.

On being asked about the deadline given for vacating the premises, he said the club would comply if it was directed by the court.

"If it is a court order, then there will certainly be compliance. There is no doubt about that," he said. The Centre's intervention began after an enquiry ordered in March 2016 into the affairs of the club. A report submitted to the Ministry of Corporate Affairs in March 2020 allegedly pointed to multiple violations, following which the government approached the tribunal under Sections 241 and 242 of the Companies Act, 2013, dealing with oppression and mismanagement.

In June 2020, the tribunal permitted the government to appoint two members to monitor the functioning of the Delhi Gymkhana Club alongside the General Council and recommend corrective measures. The Centre was also allowed to investigate the club's affairs. In April 2022, the tribunal further permitted the government to nominate 15 individuals to the club's General Committee to oversee its management.

Senior Advocate Krishnendu Dutta and Advocate Gaurav M Liberhan, appearing for the appellants challenging the takeover, had argued that the Centre was required to establish that the club's affairs were being conducted in a manner prejudicial to public interest before intervening.

## PM gives appointment letters to 51,000 youths

"The purpose is that India's youth get employment and global exposure," he said.

Elaborating on the diplomatic and economic outcomes of his visits to the UAE, the Netherlands, Sweden, Norway and Italy, the PM outlined sector-specific agreements forged and dialogues held with each nation.

He said discussions were held on semiconductors, water, agriculture and advanced manufacturing with the Netherlands; on cooperation in the fields of Artificial Intelligence (AI) and digital innovation with Sweden; on green technology and maritime cooperation with Norway; MoUs signed on strategic energy and technology partnerships with the UAE; and agreements signed on defence, critical minerals and science and technology with Italy.

Highlighting the rapid rise of clean energy, critical minerals, green hydrogen and sustainable manufacturing as sectors of immense opportunity, the PM noted that growing collaboration with Sweden, Norway and Italy in green transition and sustainable technology would position India strongly in the clean manufacturing industries of the future.

## Two Thai nationals arrested at IGI Airport with weed worth ₹48 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Customs officials at Delhi's Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport have seized nearly 48 kilograms of suspected hydroponic weed from two Thai nationals. The suspects arrived from Bangkok. This marks one of the biggest narcotics seizures at the airport in recent times.

Officials said the two passengers arrived in Delhi on an Air India flight from Bangkok on May 22. They were intercepted after crossing the Customs Green Channel.

Acting on specific profiling inputs, customs officers stopped the passengers. Their baggage was subjected to detailed scrutiny due to suspicious travel indicators. During a thorough physical examination, officials recovered six vacuum-sealed packets suspected to contain hydroponic weed. These were concealed inside their luggage.

Of the total seizure, four packets weighing around 29



kg were recovered from one passenger's baggage. Two packets weighing approximately 19 kg were found in the second passenger's luggage.

The total weight of the suspected narcotics was 47.805 kg, officials said. Customs officials estimated the international market value at about ₹48 crore.

Officials described this as one of the highest drug seizures at IGI Airport in recent years. It underscores growing concerns over efforts to smuggle high-value narcotics through interna-

tional routes. The two passengers, both Thai nationals, were intercepted based on advanced profiling and suspicious travel patterns, officials said, adding that the exact source and intended destination of the consignment are being probed. Customs officials have launched a detailed investigation to identify possible links to international drug trafficking networks.

They want to know if the accused acted alone or as part of a larger syndicate. Further investigation into the case is underway.

## Fuel prices hiked for third time in 10 days

alleged continuous harassment, domestic violence and dowry-related pressure by her husband and in-laws.

The Madhya Pradesh government has also recommended a CBI inquiry into the case. Welcoming the move, Twisha's family demanded a speedy investigation and fast-track trial to ensure justice.

## Fuel prices hiked for third time in 10 days

The Government further said after the latest price revisions, petrol in three States — Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, and Kerala — cost over ₹112/litre, of which Telangana and Kerala are governed by parties of the INDIA bloc.

Stating that these three States levy the highest VAT rates across the country, the Centre said, "Andhra Pradesh charges 31 per cent VAT plus Rs 4 a litre plus a road development cess, taking the effective rate close to 35 per cent. Telangana takes petrol close to ₹116. Kerala adds a social security cess on top of its base VAT," it said. According to the Centre, six BJP ruled States — Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh, Delhi, Haryana, Goa, and Assam — have priced petrol at or below ₹102/litre. "The same opposition leaderships that ask the Central Government to cut excise duty for the relief of the consumer have at no point cut the VAT their own State Governments levy on the same litre of fuel," it added.

Diesel prices have increased by 95 paise, 94 paise, and 87 paise from May 23 levels to ₹97.02 in Kolkata, ₹95.02 in Mumbai, and ₹96.98 in Chennai. Together, the three State-run OMCs — Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum, and Hindustan Petroleum — control more than 90 per cent of the domestic fuel market and concurrently adjust pricing. CNG price in Delhi was increased to ₹81.09 per kg from ₹80.09, according to information posted by Indraprastha Gas Ltd on its website. This is the third increase in CNG prices, and together with the earlier hikes of ₹2 per kg on May 15 and ₹1 per kg on May 17, it takes the cumulative increase to ₹4 per kg.

According to Government's data, every major developed economy now retails petrol above ₹150 a litre and most above ₹180; the EU 27 weighted average sits at ₹179 on petrol and ₹184 on diesel. Second, India's two large neighbours — Pakistan and Nepal — have moved well past ₹135 a litre on petrol despite lower nominal incomes; Sri Lanka, Myanmar, and the Philippines have crossed ₹130. Third, the only economies retailing petrol consistently below the Indian range are direct subsidisers (the UAE and Malaysia) or the US, which has structurally low fuel taxation. India therefore prices petrol and diesel at or below most of the developing world and at roughly half the European pump, while still raising less than any non-subsidising peer through the present disruption.



# Kharge attacks Union Govt after third fuel price hike

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

After the third fuel price hike in eight days, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Saturday alleged that the Government was “looting” the public’s earnings in instalments.

In a post in Hindi on X, Kharge claimed that there was a leadership crisis in the Government , saying that while other countries are providing relief to their people, the BJP Government here continues to “loot” them.

“Petrol has now crossed ₹100, this time around... Looting the public’s earnings in instalments!

“The BJP’s appetite isn’t satisfied even after slapping a central tax of ₹1,000 crore daily on petrol-diesel... When international prices were low, they didn’t pass on the benefits to the people — instead, they looted them relentlessly,” he said in his post.

Kharge claimed that when



the crisis hit, the BJP leadership got involved in elections, and after the elections, they preached sacrifice. “Then, in just 8 days, they hiked petrol-diesel prices three times,” he said. “We were told that prices in India are the lowest compared to foreign countries.”

“When the war in West Asia broke out, and PM Modi was busy feeding us Indians the ‘everything’s fine’ sedative, other countries were providing relief to their citizens,” he claimed.

The Congress chief cited the example of Italy, saying it cut excise on fuel, giving their people some relief, while Australia reduced excise duty, slashing petrol prices by about ₹17 per litre for citizens.

He also said that Germany lowered taxes on oil, reducing fuel prices by ₹17-19 per litre, while the UK provided 100 pounds in oil aid to households and cut taxes on fuel and electricity.

Ireland’s 250 million euro relief package brought petrol

prices down by about 0.15 euro/litre and diesel by 0.20 euro/litre, he said.

“Narendra Modi ji, tell us — Who all are getting a share of this instalment-based loot? Why are you so compromised?

“The real crisis in this Government is one of leadership — 140 crore Indians have now figured that out,” Kharge alleged.

Petrol and diesel prices were raised by 87-91 paise per litre on Saturday, taking the cumulative increase in retail fuel rates to nearly ₹5 a litre in under 10 days as State-owned firms passed on soaring international oil prices. The latest revision pushed petrol prices higher by 87 paise per litre and diesel by up to 91 paise across the country, according to industry sources. The back-to-back increases follow a prolonged freeze in retail fuel prices and come amid elevated crude oil prices in the global market.

## Centre publishes draft rules for VB-G RAM G

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Saturday published draft rules under the Viksit Bharat – Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025 (VB-G RAM G) for public consultation, following the notification of the law’s implementation across all states and Union Territories from July 1.

Framed under Section 33 and other relevant provisions of the Act, the draft rules have been placed in the public domain to facilitate wider stakeholder consultation before they are finalised.

The proposed rules cover transitional provisions, the National Level Steering Committee, the Central Gramin Rozgar Guarantee

Council, administrative expenses, grievance redressal, payment of wages and unemployment allowance, and expenditure incurred in excess of normative allocations, including expenses for Union Territories without legislatures.

Officials in the Ministry of Rural Development said the rules are aimed at establishing the institutional, administrative, financial, and governance framework for implementation of the Act across the country.

They said the consultation process seeks to ensure participatory governance and enable constructive feedback from States, institutions, experts, civil society organisations, and the public.



## India to be biggest weapon exporter in 25-30 years: Rajnath



Rajnath Singh, CDS Anil Chauhan, Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnis, and others during the inauguration of Missile Complex & Artillery Shell Production Line at Sawali Vihir, Ahmednagar district, Maharashtra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Shirdi (Maharashtra)

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday said no power can stop India, once considered an importer of weapons, from becoming the biggest exporter in 25-30 years.

After inaugurating an ammunition manufacturing unit in Shirdi, Singh said a nation that makes its weapons writes its own destiny.

He said the role of private players in defence manufacturing was negligible a few years back, which now stands at 25-30 per cent, while the government aims to increase it further to 50 per cent.

“The private sector is not just a supplier of nuts and bolts in defence, but also a producer of state-of-the-art weapons systems,” he added.

Singh said India was considered a weapons importer, but no power can now stop it from being the biggest exporter in 25-30 years.

He said that when the Government’s vision and

the private sector’s innovation align, then the country reaches new heights.

During the rule of the British East India Company, potassium nitrate was used as raw material to make gunpowder, and the company strengthened its military capability, Singh said.

He said India has come a long way as far as its defence industry is concerned.

Singh said that while ordnance factories existed even before Independence and the defence industry is deeply rooted in the country, after Independence, there was no balance between the country’s old capabilities and modern requirements.

This was because private players did not get the opportunities as the sector was restricted to PSUs and ordnance factories, Singh said.

He listed steps undertaken by the Union Government to increase private participation in the defence sector, including policy-related reforms and FDI liberalisation.

## Karnataka hikes minimum wages for labourers by 60%

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Bengaluru

The Karnataka Government has increased the minimum wages by 60 per cent, which will ensure labourers in Bengaluru get a minimum of ₹23,376 per month, according to a State Government notification.

The notification said that the skilled workers would be entitled to ₹31,114 per month in the State Capital.

Sharing the information, Labour Minister Santosh Lad on Saturday described the move as the fulfilment of a long-pending demand of the labour community across Karnataka.



The revised rates in other parts of Karnataka would be between ₹19,300 and ₹21,251 per month.

The minister said the revised wage notification would provide economic security to workers in the unorganised sector as well as

employees in specified sectors across the State, while also bringing lakhs of workers under a unified framework for the first time.

“Our Government has issued a notification increasing the minimum wages of workers by 60 per cent.

Through this, our Government has fulfilled a long-pending demand of the labouring community in the State,” Lad said in a post on ‘X’.

He said the wage revision had been carried out in accordance with directions issued by the Supreme Court and marked a significant structural reform in the State’s labour framework.

“This notification will provide economic security to workers in the unorganised sector and other specified sectors across the State. While determining the minimum wages, the directions of the Hon’ble Supreme Court Bench have been followed in carrying out this revision,” he said.

# Ladakh deadlock ends as Centre agrees to elected body

MOHIT KANDHARI  
■ Jammu

Ending the political deadlock in the cold desert region of Ladakh, the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has finally arrived at an in-principle understanding with representatives of the Leh Apex Body (LAB) and Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) to establish a Union Territory-level legislative body with substantial legislative, executive, and financial powers.

With this, the joint leadership, spearheading a campaign to achieve statehood status for the Union Territory of Ladakh, has come one step closer to realising their dream, leaving behind squabbling leadership in Jammu and Kashmir.

The ice was broken late Friday evening when both sides resumed talks in a cordial atmosphere after a gap of three long months in the Union Capital.

The Sub-Committee meeting convened by the Ministry of Home Affairs was attended by senior officers of MHA and UT administration of Ladakh; Thupstan Chhewang, Haji Hanifa Jan, MP, Dr Mohd Jaffer Akhoun, chairman-cum-CEC of Ladakh Hill Council, Tashi Gyalson, BJP leader and former CEC Leh Council; Chering Dorjay Lakrook, climate activist Sonam Wangchuk and Dorje Stanzin; all from LAB; Asgar Ali Karbalai, Sajjad Kargili and Ghulam Rasool Nagvi from KDA.

During the meeting, deliberations focused on the future administrative and political framework of Ladakh.

The representatives of Leh Apex Body (LAB) and Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) reiterated the longstanding aspirations of the people of Ladakh regarding the restoration of democracy, constitutional safeguards and the



demand for statehood and sixth schedule protections, reflecting the shared commitment of all stakeholders towards an inclusive and sustainable governance framework for the region.

A statement issued after the meeting by Chering Dorjay Lakrook and Asgar Ali Karbalai, co-chairpersons of LAB and KDA, respectively, said that following detailed and constructive delibera-

tions, both sides have arrived at an in-principle understanding on several critical points.

“In this model, the legislative, executive and financial powers will rest with elected representatives through a Union Territory-level legislative body. All bureaucrats of the UT, including the Chief Secretary, will come under the executive head of the UT-level elected body (proposed to be the Chief

Minister)”, the joint statement said.

“The LAB and KDA have reached an in-principle understanding with the Government of India on restoring democracy in Ladakh and providing Constitutional safeguards on the lines of Article 371 A, F, and G (as applied to Nagaland, Sikkim and Mizoram)”, the joint statement said adding the KDA and LAB look forward to closely working out the finer operational details with the MHA in consultations with legal and Constitutional experts.

The LAB and KDA joint statement said the MHA authorities explained that the only reason why Ladakh cannot be made a state at the moment is that it currently lacks adequate revenue generation to meet the revenue expenditures, like salaries of employees.

However, it added, this setup will lead Ladakh

towards full Statehood as and when it meets the revenue criteria.

In the coming weeks, the MHA is expected to prepare a draft for the UT level legislative body with suggestions from LAB and KDA before its implementation. So far, the MHA hasn’t given any timeline for implementation of the proposals. However, the Ministry officials assured that it will be done as early as possible.

After the meeting ended, former Ladakh MP Thupstan Chhewang said, “The meeting was highly anticipated, and discussions covered Ladakh’s long-standing issues. For five to six years, dialogue with the Home Ministry had brought partial consensus and implementation at the ground level, but the key demands — statehood and UT with legislature, along with constitutional safeguards — had remained unresolved. Today, however, a historic consensus was reached.”

## Gujarat CM meets cochlear implant recipients in Ahmedabad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Ahmedabad

Bhupendra Patel interacted with children benefiting from the State’s cochlear implant support programme during a visit to Science City, creating a warm and engaging atmosphere.

The Chief Minister met 20 children who have received external speech processors under the initiative, which aims to support hearing-impaired children. The devices, provided free of cost by the State Government, are typically expensive and beyond the reach of many families.

During the visit, Patel accompanied the children to the aquatic gallery, where

he encouraged them and engaged in friendly conversation. Parents expressed gratitude for the programme, describing it as life-changing for their children.

Launched under the school health initiative, the scheme has enabled cochlear implant procedures for over 3,500 children since 2014. In addition, a recent policy allows for free replacement of external speech processors for eligible beneficiaries.

Officials said the programme continues to expand with the support of medical specialists and government hospitals, aiming to improve speech and hearing outcomes for children across the State.



## Public consultations on UCC kick off in Madhya Pradesh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Indore



live-in relationships and inheritance.

“The committee will hear views from all sections of society. It will then study the existing legal framework and submit recommendations to the State Government on implementing a UCC. We will try to finalise our recommendations by July,” Singh said.

He said the State Government had also launched an online portal to seek suggestions from citizens, and people could submit their views till June 15.

“Young people in particular should actively share

their opinions on the portal,” he said.

Participants supporting the UCC said it would ensure a uniform legal system for all citizens.

However, a representative of the Muslim community said implementing the UCC would violate Sharia law and could affect the community’s religious rights. Indore Mayor Pushyamitra Bhargav, local MLAs Malini Laxman Singh Gaur and Madhu Verma, along with several other public representatives, also attended the meeting and shared their suggestions.

## AIESL strike: CPI(M) writes to PM Modi, raises safety concerns

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The CPI(M) wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday, seeking urgent intervention in the ongoing agitation by the workers of Air India Engineering Services Limited (AIESL), alleging labour exploitation and raising concerns over passenger safety.

In a letter dated May 23, Communist Party of India (Marxist) general secretary MA Baby said the AIESL workers have been holding sit-ins for the last eight days outside maintenance facilities in Delhi, Chennai, Mumbai, Kolkata and Nagpur against what he described as “brazen anti-worker policies” of the management.

Baby said AIESL, a former Air India subsidiary now functioning as a public sector undertaking (PSU) under the civil aviation ministry, operates major maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO) facilities servicing narrow-



CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby

body and wide-body aircraft, including Airbus A320 and Boeing 737, 747, 777 and 787 used in domestic and international operations.

Referring to a recent emergency landing of an Air India aircraft from Bengaluru at the Delhi airport following a reported engine fire, the Left leader said the incident underlined the critical role of technical personnel and the need to address concerns relating to aircraft maintenance and safety.

The letter alleged that fixed-term employees in AIESL are being paid less than one-third of the salary, benefits received by permanent workers performing similar jobs, despite provisions in the

draft model standing orders issued by the Government on May 8, stating that fixed-term workers should receive wages and allowances comparable to permanent employees doing similar work.

Baby further claimed that engineers and technicians maintaining aircraft safety are being compelled to work 12 to 14 hours a day, while receiving overtime compensation at rates as low as Rs 85 per hour, which he said violates recently-notified labour code provisions mandating overtime payment at double the ordinary wage rate.

The CPI(M) also accused the management of intimidation and victimisation of workers. The letter said four union representatives were served termination notices after raising issues related to equal pay, working conditions and overtime compensation, and claimed that the ongoing protest is partly directed against these dismissals.



States Focus



BASTAR DOCTOR COUPLE TO BE CONFERRED WITH PADMA SHRI

Husband-wife duo Dr Ramchandra Godbole and Suneeta Godbole, who have spent more than three decades providing healthcare and social support to tribal communities in the remote Bastar region of Chhattisgarh, will be conferred the Padma Shri by President Droupadi Murmu on May 25.

The couple moved to Bastar soon after their marriage in 1990 and have since devoted their lives to serving tribal populations in inaccessible and Naxal-affected areas where healthcare facilities were either limited or non-existent. Dr Ramchandra Godbole, a BAMS graduate from Maharashtra's Satara district, initially worked among tribal communities in Nashik through the Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram before moving to Bastar.



BIHAR GOVT TO ROLL OUT AI POLICY SOON: CM CHOUDHARY

Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Saturday said his Government would soon roll out an artificial intelligence (AI) policy as part of its plan to develop Bihar as a major AI hub. Speaking at the inauguration of the 'Bihar AI Summit 2026' at Urja Auditorium in Patna, Choudhary said AI would play a key role in transforming governance, improving transparency and accelerating Bihar's development trajectory.

"Bihar will continue to work towards becoming an AI hub, and the Government will soon bring an AI policy. Through AI, Bihar will emerge among the country's leading developed States," he said.

Choudhary urged all Government departments to maximise the use of AI to ensure transparency in welfare schemes and improve public service delivery.

BJP, CPI(M) hit out at poll officer's appointment as Kerala CM's secretary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Thiruvananthapuram

The BJP and CPI(M) on Saturday criticised the Kerala Government over the appointment of State CEO Rathan U Kelkar as secretary to Chief Minister VD Satheesan, alleging a contradiction in the Congress party's stand on similar appointments made in BJP-ruled States.

Kelkar, a 2003-batch IAS officer, had supervised the recent Kerala Assembly election process as the State's CEO. According to a Government order, "Rathan U Kelkar IAS (KL 2003), Chief Electoral Officer, Kerala and Secretary, Election Department, is transferred and posted as Secretary to the Chief Minister."

Reacting to the development, senior BJP leader K Surendran accused the Congress of double standards in matters concerning appointments involving election officials.

"In West Bengal, when the BJP did the same, it was described as a reward for vote theft. But in Kerala, when VD Satheesan does this, it



Kerala CM VD Satheesan



State CEO Rathan U Kelkar

becomes the beauty of democracy. Rahul Gandhi and company are the biggest hypocrites," Surendran said in a social media post.

Senior CPI(M) leader and former minister P Rajeev also criticised the appointment and sought clarification from the Congress leadership at the national level.

He said the Congress leadership should explain its stand on appointing the Chief Electoral Officer as the Chief Minister's secretary in Kerala, while Gandhi had strongly opposed a similar appointment in West Bengal.

Rajeev said the appointment in Kerala was made even as Gandhi had raised

allegations regarding the appointment of a former election official in West Bengal and termed the issue a "very serious matter".

He further alleged that Kelkar's appointment was made without even observing a "cooling period", which, according to him, was generally expected in such cases.

"The same party led by Gandhi has now appointed an officer who handled election responsibilities as the chief minister's secretary," Rajeev told reporters.

He said the Congress national leadership and Gandhi should clarify their stand, especially at a time when questions were being raised in society

over the credibility of the election process and the Election Commission.

The criticism by the BJP and the CPI(M) comes in the backdrop of Gandhi attacking the BJP Government in West Bengal earlier over the appointment of former State Chief Electoral Officer Manoj Kumar Agarwal as chief secretary after the change in Government there.

Gandhi had then alleged collusion between the BJP and the Election Commission and remarked that "the bigger the theft, the bigger the reward".

Responding to the criticism, Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala defended the appointment and said the Government was fully empowered to appoint capable officers to key administrative posts.

"The appointment of Rathan Kelkar as the chief minister's secretary is the prerogative of the Government. He is a competent officer, and the Government has the authority to recall and appoint him. There is nothing unusual in it," Chennithala told reporters.

West Bengal gained infamy due to recruitment scams: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

Maintaining that West Bengal gained infamy due to various recruitment scams during the previous regime, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Saturday said his Government will introduce a new recruitment policy in the next Budget session of the Assembly.

Noting that the Calcutta High Court and the Supreme Court had to intervene in these illegalities during the previous Trinamool Congress Government, leading to the cancellation of 26,000 school jobs, he said West Bengal's image suffered a dent and that there was a need to bring the State out of the situation.

"The chief minister said the Government wants to give OMR answer sheet carbon copies of the written tests for recruitment to the examinees following the examination. Stating that he has learnt that till now, carbon copies of the OMR sheets were not given to the examinees of the State's recruitment examinations, Adhikari said, "It's a very bad practice with mala fide intention. Such practices were resorted to for encouraging nepotism and corruption."

Addressing a Rozgar Mela organised by the Central Government to hand over appointment letters to the recruited persons as part of a nationwide programme, Adhikari said that West Bengal, which was known for its high standards of education and intellect, has gained "infamy" owing to the school jobs and municipal body recruitment



MoS Sukanta Majumdar, West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, State BJP MLA Ritesh Tiwari and others after attending the 19th edition of Rozgar Mela, in Kolkata on Saturday

scams. "We have to bring our dear West Bengal out of this situation," the chief minister said.

"Even the examination centres were tainted in such a manner that Eastern Railway, South Eastern Railway and Northeast Frontier Railway were not holding their recruitment examinations in the State," he said.

He said that the youths of West Bengal were sitting for the examinations in the neighbouring States of Bihar, Assam and Odisha. The chief minister said that the existing recruitment system in the West Bengal Government, under which maximum marks are allocated to the viva examination, is "not good".

He maintained that the viva part should have a minimum mark allocation. The chief minister said the previous TMC Government did not adhere to the constitutional obligations of the 100-point roster of reservation for OBC, SC/ST, physically challenged, and economically weaker sections (EWS) in State recruitments.

Singrauli coal mining needs court scrutiny: Jairam Ramesh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Congress leader and former environment minister Jairam Ramesh on Saturday highlighted that coal mining has been allowed in the dense forests of Madhya Pradesh's Singrauli and hoped that the matter receives sensitivity, scrutiny and urgency from the courts.

In a post on X, Ramesh said in May 2025, the Union Ministry of Environment, Forests and Climate Change "predictably cleared" a proposal from the "Modani empire" to mine coal in the



very dense forests of Singrauli district in Madhya Pradesh.

"The area involved is about 7,000 acres and is very much part of the 'no go' area for mining identified in 2011 because of the richness of

the forests and also because of the presence of elephant corridors. More than six lakh trees will be felled.

"The clearance had been challenged by environmental activists in the National Green Tribunal. In April 2026, the NGT ruled that the challenge was late and that the petitioners should have approached the NGT earlier. As a result of this delay, the NGT declined to hear the challenge on substantive grounds," the Congress leader claimed.

He said the NGT order was then challenged in the Supreme Court. On May 21, the Supreme Court, after hearing

arguments on the question of delay in filing the challenge, allowed the petitioners to withdraw the challenge and pursue other appropriate remedies available under the law, Ramesh pointed out.

"This means that the issue remains open to challenge. It is hoped that such a matter, involving significant ecological and public interest concerns, continues to receive the sensitivity, scrutiny, and urgency it deserves from the High Court — and of course, the Supreme Court, which distinguished itself on the Aravalli issue recently," the Congress leader said in his post.

Maharashtra CM assures diesel supply for farmers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Shirdi

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Saturday said that while fuel is not readily available in the rural areas, he has instructed authorities to ensure an uninterrupted supply of diesel to farmers.

Talking to reporters, Fadnavis issued a stern warning against black-marketing of fuel in the name of farmers, noting that some parts of the State had witnessed a sudden 20 to 30 per cent spike in sales.

The chief minister arrived in the city to participate in the inauguration of a defence and aerospace complex.

He said that the district administrations have been instructed to ensure diesel availability for farmers amid reports of fuel shortages in rural areas.

"Petrol and diesel are not available in rural areas right now. In this regard, I have issued instructions to all district collectors and divisional commissioners that wherever necessary, diesel should be made available to farmers," he said.



Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis waves as he arrives in Shirdi, Ahilyanagar district, Maharashtra

Maharashtra has recorded around a 20 per cent rise in petrol and diesel sales in the first fortnight of May amid panic buying triggered by fears of a possible disruption in fuel supplies due to the West Asia crisis.

Fadnavis, who travelled to the city on a Vande Bharat train, said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi had given the country a "unique gift" through this train service, which is comparable to developed nations across the world.

"I enjoyed the experience very much. During the

journey, I cleared files and met many people. It was a completely different and very good experience," he said.

Speaking about the defence complex in Shirdi, Fadnavis said the temple town had emerged as a symbol of both devotion and strength.

"Shirdi has now emerged as a centre of strength. It is a matter of great happiness. Devotion and strength are integrated in Indian spirituality. Only those who are powerful can establish peace. The weak can never establish peace," he said.

Security tightened at West Bengal Jhalmuri stall

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

Security has been stepped up at the 'jhalmuri' stall, which Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited during his campaign for the West Bengal election last month, after its owner allegedly received death threats, police said on Saturday.

Bikram Kumar Sau, who runs the jhalmuri stall near Raj College More in Jhargram town, hogged the limelight after the PM stopped at his shop and ate the popular snack while returning from a public rally on April 19.



Sau lodged a written complaint at the Jhargram police station, alleging that he had been receiving threatening phone calls and messages from people claiming to be from Pakistan and Bangladesh since May 17.

The callers allegedly threatened to kill him and blow up his stall with bombs, according to the complaint.

Sau also claimed that in a WhatsApp video call, some persons brandished firearms and issued threats.



16 die in Telangana amid heatwave

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Hyderabad

Telangana Revenue Minister Ponguleti Srinivasa Reddy on Saturday said 16 people died due to heatwave conditions prevailing in the State during the current summer.

Reddy, who held a meeting with officials on the situation arising out of the heatwave, said the 16 deaths took place in seven districts of the State.

Quoting reports received from district Collectors, he said four persons died in Jayashankar Bhupalpally district, followed by three each in Warangal Urban, Karimnagar and Nizamabad and one each in Jogulamba Gadwal, Ranga Reddy and Suryapet.

The Government would provide an ex gratia of Rs 4 lakh each to the kin of the deceased persons, he said, according to an official release.

The revenue minister directed officials to identify villages recording very high temperatures and send alerts about the heat through

media, social media and other means to those villages.

He said drinking water, butter milk, ORS packets should be made available at bus stations, markets, major roads and places where workers work in large numbers. Steps should be taken to prevent loss of life due to the heat, he said.

The minister urged that senior citizens, pregnant women, children and unhealthy people should not venture out of their homes between 11 am and 4 pm.

He instructed district Collectors to specially monitor heatwave conditions, and Government employees from mandal to village level should be in the field as part of heat-relief measures.

Citing reports from the Met department, Reddy said Karimnagar, Peddapally, Bhupalpally, Mulugu, Khammam, Nalgonda, Suryapet, Mahabubnagar, Hyderabad and Ranga Reddy districts would witness severe heat conditions till May 26.

J&K Govt imposes spending curbs, restricts official events

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Srinagar

The Jammu and Kashmir Government has announced a series of expenditure-control measures aimed at ensuring fiscal discipline, imposing restrictions on official functions, foreign travel, vehicle purchases, creation of new posts, and hiring of office spaces.

In an order issued by the Finance Department, all departments have been directed to implement the measures with immediate effect.

"Utmost economy shall be observed in organising conferences, seminars, workshops, training programmes, and similar events. Such activities shall be undertaken only where necessary

and after exploring virtual alternatives," the order said.

It said holding exhibitions, fairs, seminars, conferences, and workshops outside the Union Territory is strongly discouraged, while meetings and conferences in private hotels and commercial venues have been completely banned.

Government buildings, conference halls, and other available Government infrastructure must invariably be used for such purposes, it added.

The Government also strongly discouraged the purchase of new vehicles, stating that exceptional cases involving critical operational requirements may be considered only with the concurrence of the Finance Department and subject to



replacement against condemned vehicles with a 20 per cent reduction in fleet strength.

"Departments shall ensure that condemned vehicles are auctioned and the auction proceeds deposited as Miscellaneous Revenue before submission of any

proposal for replacement vehicles," the order said.

Departments have also been directed to ensure optimal utilisation and pooling of available Government vehicles and avoid deployment beyond functional necessity to promote economy in fuel

CJI urges students to stay humble, uphold ethical values in digital era

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bathinda

Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Saturday emphasised the importance of constitutional values, ethical conduct, integrity, and compassion in today's rapidly evolving technological world.

In his virtual address during the 11th convocation of the Central University of Punjab, CJI Kant encouraged



graduates to uphold kindness, empathy, and human values while contributing meaningfully towards

building an inclusive and progressive society.

While acknowledging the opportunities created by digital advancement, he also cautioned against emerging ethical challenges in the rapidly evolving digital era.

Urging students to remain humble and socially responsible, he stated that a degree marks the beginning of greater responsibilities towards society and the nation.

Kerala launches anti-drug drive, targets schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala on Saturday announced a comprehensive Statewide anti-narcotics campaign titled "Operation Toofan: The Narco Hunt", aimed at cracking down on drug syndicates.

The minister announced the initiative after chairing his first high-level meeting of senior police officers at the Police Headquarters in Thiruvananthapuram.

Chennithala said the



special drive would begin from June 1, coinciding with the reopening of schools after the summer vacation, and would focus on eliminating drug distribution networks, especially around

educational institutions.

"The aim is to uproot gangs that are trapping children in narcotics. Those who use drugs, sell them, spread them, and those behind their supply chains will all come under strict police surveillance. A special project has been prepared for this campaign," he said.

Describing narcotics, especially synthetic drugs, as a growing threat in Kerala, the minister said the police would launch intensified operations in the coming days to eradicate the menace.

PROSPECT

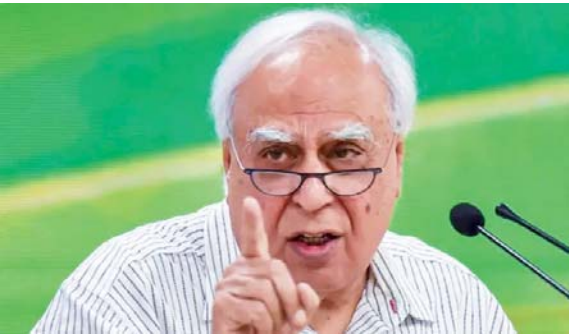
## MHA warns of phishing scam targeting iPhone users



The National Cybercrime Threat Analytics Unit (NCTAU) of I4C under the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has identified a sophisticated phishing campaign targeting Apple iPhone users whose devices have been lost or stolen and are in the possession of perpetrators.

According to the advisory, attackers impersonate Apple Support and exploit victims' urgency to locate or secure their missing devices by sending fraudulent SMS messages containing phishing links. The messages closely resemble legitimate "Find My iPhone" or Apple Support notifications and are typically sent from numeric SMS headers. They often claim the lost device has been temporarily switched off or that urgent action is required to erase contacts, media, and other data. When victims click the phishing link, they are redirected to counterfeit websites designed to closely resemble the official Apple Support or iCloud login page. These phishing domains frequently use deceptive naming conventions to appear legitimate. Users are then prompted to enter their Apple ID credentials, followed by the One-Time Password or two-factor authentication code sent by Apple.

## Sibal raises objections to Govt increasing number of judges through ordinance



Former law minister Kapil Sibal on Saturday raised objections to the manner in which the Centre has increased the strength of judges through an ordinance and not through legislation debated in Parliament. Addressing a press conference, the independent Rajya Sabha MP said this shows the Bharatiya Janata Party-led Government's lack of transparency and interest in consultation, which is anti-democratic in nature. In 1950, Sibal said, there were only seven judges in the Supreme Court. The number was gradually increased over the years and has now reached 37, besides the chief justice, he pointed out. "The question is where do we go as an institution. The reason why I am worried is that the rationale given to increase the strength of judges is worrying. "It is really the government that is responsible for the increase in litigation because it is a major litigant. The majority of litigation emanates from the government," he said.

## ICMAI organises 13th convocation

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

The Institute of Cost Accountants of India (ICMAI) organised its 13th Convocation at the C Subramaniam Convention Centre, reaffirming the Institute's pivotal role in shaping India's future-ready financial and management professionals aligned with the national vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.

The convocation brought together more than 1,200 participants from across the country, including newly qualified Cost and Management Accountants (CMAs), rank holders, policy-makers, academicians, industry leaders, members of the profession and proud family members.

The convocation was graced by Taranjit Singh Sandhu, LG of Delhi, as the chief guest and Sukanta Majumdar, Union Minister of State for Education and Development of North Eastern Region, Government of India, along with



Satyanarayan Jatiya, Former Minister of Social Justice and Empowerment of India as guests of honour.

Addressing the gathering, Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu said the nature of business, governance and economic systems is changing rapidly, making the role of institutions like ICMAI increasingly significant in strengthening the country's economic backbone.

He said cost and management accountants today are no longer limited to maintaining records or preparing balance sheets but are becoming part of the

# Centre invites applications for 50 industrial parks

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Saturday said it has opened a four-month window for States to submit applications for setting up 50 industrial parks under the ₹33,660 crore Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojna (BHAVYA) scheme.

On March 18, the Union Cabinet approved the scheme for developing 100 plug-and-play industrial parks across the country over a period of six years from 2026-27 to 2031-32.

In the first phase, up to 50 industrial parks will be taken up through a challenge-based competitive selection process, he said.

It aims to develop world-class industrial infrastructure, unlock manufacturing potential and drive the country's economic growth.

Briefing the media on the detailed operational guidelines for the implementation of the scheme, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said applications from states are being invited for 20 parks in the first two months and for another 30 in the sub-

sequent two months.

These 50 parks will be approved in the first phase, and the remaining 50 in the next phase. The scheme will be implemented in partnership with states and private sector players.

Under the scheme, industrial parks ranging from 100 to 1,000 acres will be taken up for development, he said, adding that the financial support of up to ₹one crore per acre will be provided for infrastructure development.

For hilly states, a park can also be approved on 25 acres of land. The selection process will be through a "challenge method", and states that provide better facilities, such as land, water and power, are likely to attract investors, Goyal said, adding that states like Rajasthan, Maharashtra, West Bengal and Haryana are showing keen interest.

"I invite all states and Union territories to participate in this. From today, we are inviting applications from the states/UTs in the next four months. We are looking for applications for 50 industrial parks so that we can quickly start rolling out the



scheme across the country," he said.

There is also a provision under the scheme for states to partner with private players and submit proposals, under which the Centre will provide assistance of ₹50 lakh per acre, Goyal said.

States should set up a special purpose vehicle (SPV), notify a planning authority and establish a single-window clearance mechanism to ensure faster

approval of their applications.

"We expect that in three years, these 50 parks will be operationalised," Goyal said.

By fostering cluster-based development and enabling co-location of industries, suppliers, and service providers, BHAVYA will strengthen domestic supply chains, promote regional industrialisation, and create new opportunities for millions of people.

The scheme will benefit

manufacturing units, MSMEs, startups, and global investors seeking ready-to-use industrial infrastructure.

The guidelines lay down a comprehensive framework covering eligibility criteria, project selection methodology, funding structure, governance architecture, monitoring systems, and implementation modalities for industrial parks under the scheme.

It also provides for the development of both green-

field and eligible brownfield industrial parks.

Under the challenge-based selection framework, proposals will be evaluated on objective parameters, including multimodal connectivity, site suitability, quality of infrastructure, industrial ecosystem strength, policy facilitation, digital governance readiness, and long-term sustainability.

The guidelines provide for evaluation on the quality of infrastructure for components, such as underground utility systems, water and waste management, common effluent treatment systems, renewable energy, worker housing, testing laboratories, and a digital single-window system.

Implementation of projects under BHAVYA will be undertaken through Special Purpose Vehicles (SPVs) incorporated under the Companies Act, 2013. The SPVs will be responsible for project planning, development, operation, management, investor facilitation, and long-term maintenance of assets created under the scheme.

## CM Himanta calls on FM Sitharaman, discusses roadmap for Assam's growth



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma called upon Nirmala Sitharaman in New Delhi

PIONEER PHOTO

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Saturday called on Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in the national Capital, during which they discussed the roadmap for accelerating the State's economic growth.

Sarma thanked the Union Finance Minister for the support extended to Assam over the past five years.

"Called upon Hon'ble Union Finance Minister Smt. @nsitharaman Ji in New Delhi today. I thanked her for the constant support extended to Assam over the last five years and discussed the roadmap for Assam's growth

and development journey in the coming years," Sarma said in a post on X.

The Chief Minister's Office, in a separate post on the social media platform, said the two leaders discussed the Assam government's roadmap for accelerating economic growth and transforming the state into a major growth engine of Northeast India.

## Indian Army organises project NAVBHARAT to motivate youth

**TONY DAS**  
■ Guwahati

The Indian Army's Spearhead Division of the Spear Corps conducted a vibrant and inspiring programme under Project NAVBHARAT at Likabali on Saturday, marked by patriotic zeal and enthusiastic public participation.

The initiative reflected the Indian Army's continuous efforts to connect with the youth and strengthen the spirit of national unity and service. Students from Likabali and nearby Silapathar actively participated in various educational and motivational activities organised during the event.

Special lectures and short films based on Operation Sindoor were presented to motivate the younger generation by showcasing stories of bravery, determination and selfless service towards the nation.

The sessions created a strong sense of pride and



encouraged students to contribute positively towards society and the country.

The gathering included an engaging operational briefing that offered participants an insight into the preparedness, discipline and operational capabilities of the Indian Army. Visitors were also given the opportunity to witness an impressive static display of weapons and military equipment, which generated great interest and admiration among the atten-

dees. Further enriching the occasion, a detailed lecture on the success of Operation Sindoor, highlighting the Army's professionalism and unwavering commitment to national security and nation-building, was conducted in Commerce College, Silapathar. The programme successfully promoted strong civil-military relations and left the audience inspired by the values of courage, patriotism, and dedication displayed by the Indian Army.

## Army conducts yoga session in Arunachal

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ Itanagar

As part of the month-long celebrations leading up to International Yoga Day 2026, Spearhead Division, under the aegis of Spear Corps, conducted a special yoga session at Aalo in West Siang district, Arunachal Pradesh.

The session witnessed enthusiastic participation from troops, students and young players taking part in the Hangpan Dada Memorial Football and Volleyball Tournament. The programme focused on simple yoga practices, correct body alignment,

breathing discipline and mental well-being, with an aim to promote a healthy and balanced lifestyle among the participants.

The event also highlighted the importance of yoga in building physical fitness, inner balance, discipline and positivity in daily life. It provided a meaningful platform for youth engagement and interaction between Army personnel and local students.

The initiative reflected the Indian Army's continued commitment towards health awareness, youth empowerment and military-civil synergy in frontier areas.



## NTPC announces robust financial performance in FY26

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

NTPC Ltd, India's largest integrated power utility, has announced its audited financial results for the fourth quarter and financial year ended March 31, 2026, reporting a strong all-round performance driven by operational gains and strategic growth.

On a standalone basis, NTPC reported a total income of ₹44030 crore for Q4 FY26, registering a 6 per cent growth compared to Q3 FY26. Profit After Tax (PAT) for Q4 FY26 rose to ₹8747 crore up from ₹4987 crore for Q3 FY26. For the full fiscal year PAT increased by 18 per cent to ₹23162 crore from ₹19649 crore for FY25. The PAT growth was primarily driven by gains from capacity additions, operational efficiencies, reduction in finance costs, and revision in the deferred tax and regulatory deferred account balances.



On a consolidated basis, NTPC Group's PAT for FY26 rose by 15 per cent to ₹27546 crore from ₹23953 for FY25.

The strong performance was bolstered by a 29 per cent increase in the share of joint venture profits, which reached ₹2864 crore. Subsidiaries also earned a profit of ₹3312 crore for FY26. Group PAT for Q4 FY26 has increased to ₹10615 crore from ₹5597 crore in Q3 FY26. NTPC's coal power sta-

tions continue to set industry benchmarks in operational efficiency.

NTPC's coal plants achieved a plant load factor of 72.04 per cent during FY26, significantly outperforming the rest of India's coal PLF of 63.20 per cent.

The results reinforce NTPC's leadership position in India's power sector, backed by sustained operational excellence and a diversified growth strategy.

## Government does not interfere in exchange rates: Goyal

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Saturday said the Government does not interfere in exchange rates as these are determined by market forces and influenced by several global factors.

However, he said, the Government is always conscious of taking steps to promote exports, reduce import dependence and promote a greater degree of investment into India.

"The Government does not interfere in the exchange rate. It is a matter of market forces, and it is

also dependent on several global factors. In fact, if I read correctly, in the last two or three days, again the rupee has appreciated pretty significantly. So, these are market-driven factors," he told reporters here when asked about his views on rupee outlook.

The rupee rose for the second consecutive session on Friday (May 22) to close sharply higher at 95.60 against the US dollar on softening of crude oil prices and supposed intervention by the Reserve Bank.

The rupee's sharp decline has emerged as one of the biggest economic warning signs for policymakers, investors and businesses.



Once considered among Asia's more stable currencies, the rupee has now become one of the worst-performing emerging market currencies this year, pressured by a toxic mix of expensive oil, capital outflows, widening trade deficits and a surging US dollar.

Goyal added that steps such as finalisation of nine free trade agreements in recent years, encouragement for import substitution of goods where India has a critical requirement in its supply chains, promoting ease of doing business, and decriminalisation of minor offences will certainly support India's industrialisation.

**GOVIND BALLABH PANT UNIVERSITY OF AGRICULTURE & TECHNOLOGY****PANTNAGAR- 263145,**  
DISTRICT-UDHAM SINGH NAGAR (UTTARAKHAND)  
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF PERSONNEL OFFICER

**EMPLOYMENT NOTICE NO. A-29/2026**  
Applications are invited from all over the country for the posts of Dean, College of Veterinary & Animal Sciences/ Dean, College of Fisheries/ Dean, College of Agribusiness Management/Dean, College of Agriculture/ Dean, College of Community Science/ Dean, College of Basic Sciences & Humanities/ Dean, College of Technology/ Dean, College of Post Graduate Studies/Director Research & Director Extension Education. Last date for the receipt of the complete application direct and through proper channel is 25.6.2026 Full details regarding Application Form, Fees, Academic Qualification and Score Card will be available at university website [www.gbpuat.ac.in](http://www.gbpuat.ac.in) on 22.5.2026  
**CHIEF PERSONNEL OFFICER**

FROM THE  
WORLD

USA

Tulsi Gabbard  
resigns as DNI

Tulsi Gabbard resigned as President Donald Trump's director of National Intelligence (DNI) on Friday, saying she needed to step away as her husband battles cancer. She is the fourth Cabinet official to depart during Trump's second term. In her resignation letter, which she posted on social media.

# Ukraine drone hits Russian oil terminal

**ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv**

A Ukrainian drone attack caused a fire at another Russian oil terminal overnight, local officials in Russia's Krasnodar region said on Saturday, in what appeared to be the latest attack on Moscow's vital oil industry.

Authorities in the city of Novorossiysk said falling drone debris sparked a fire at an oil terminal, injuring two people, without naming the facility. Russia's Astra news outlet said Ukrainian drones

struck the Sheskharis oil terminal and depot, the terminus for Russian state-controlled pipeline company Transneft's main oil pipelines in the region.

Images posted by Astra appeared to show smoke rising above the oil terminal, but they could not be verified. Ukraine did not immediately comment on the attack. Ukraine has expanded its mid- and long-range strike capabilities, deploying drone and missile technology that it has developed domestically to battle Russia's 4-year-old



Rescuers working at the side of a college dormitory building damaged by drones in Ukraine

## Major Abhilasha to receive UN military gender advocate award

**YOSHITA SINGH ■ United Nations**



Indian peacekeeper serving with the UN mission in Lebanon, Major Abhilasha Barak, has been named the recipient of a prestigious military gender advocate award by the world body.

Barak has been honoured with the 2025 United Nations Military Gender Advocate of the Year Award for her outreach efforts with women and girls during her deployment in the West Asian nation. "Proud to announce that Major Abhilasha Barak has been awarded the 2025 @UN Military Gender Advocate of the Year Award. She is being recognised for her outreach and community engagement activities for women and adolescent girls and gender sensitisation training for peacekeepers," the Permanent Mission of India to the UN said in a post on X Friday.

Barak is serving with the Indian Battalion as the Commander of the Female Engagement Team (FET) in UN Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL). She is also the first woman combat helicopter pilot of the Indian Army. She will be honoured at the UN headquarters when the world body commemorates the International Day of UN Peacekeepers that is marked annually on May 29.

In a moment of pride for India, Barak is the third recipient of the award from the country, following Major Suman Gawani and Major Radhika Sen, who were honoured for their commendable work while serving in UN Peacekeeping missions.

Gawani had served with the UN Mission in South Sudan (UNMISS) and received the 2019 United Nations Military Gender Advocate of the Year Award. She was a co-recipient of the 2019 recognition along with Commander Carla Monteiro de Castro Araujo, a Brazilian Naval officer working in the United Nations Multidimensional Integrated Stabilization Mission in the Central African Republic (MINUSCA).

Major Radhika Sen, who served with the United Nations Organization Stabilisation Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO), received the prestigious 2023 United Nations Military Gender Advocate of the Year Award. (PTI)

कार्यालय पुलिस उप महानिरीक्षक सह सम्पदा अधिकारी, ग्रुप केन्द्र कैरियुबल, ग्रेटर नोएडा, गौतम बुद्ध नगर ( उप्र )-201306

संख्या : एम.पॉच-01( अस्थायी दुकान )/2026-27-ग्रुप06ग्रेटर नोएडा-भवन

दिनांक २० मई, 2026

विज्ञापन सूचना

सर्वासाधारण को यह सूचित किया जाता है कि ग्रुप केन्द्र, केन्द्रीय रिजर्व पुलिस, ग्रेटर नोएडा, गौतम बुद्ध नगर (उत्तर प्रदेश) में रहने वाले कर्मियों एवं उनके परिवारजनों को सुविधा हेतु कैम्पस के अर्न्तगत निम्नलिखित अस्थायी दुकानों (Temporary Shops) को निर्धारित स्थानों पर संचालित करने के लिए इच्छुक एवं योग्य व्यक्तियों/विक्रेताओं से आवेदन आमंत्रित किए जाते हैं। प्रस्तावित दुकानें व मासिक किराया का विवरण इस प्रकार है :-

| S/No . | Name of Shop (Semi-permanent structure)   | Area of shop (In Sqft) | Approx. rent per sqft per month | Minimum Rent per month (In Rs.) | Location of Semi-permanent structure | Electricity Charge per Month                        | Remark                             |
|--------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| 1      | Momos/Bakery Shop/Tikki Chat Shop         | 171                    | 12                              | 2,052.00                        | Children Park Children Park          | According to the consumed electricity meter reading | केवल एक विक्रेता ( Vendor ) के लिए |
|        |                                           | 171                    | 12                              | 2,052.00                        | Children Park                        | ---do---                                            |                                    |
|        |                                           | 171                    | 12                              | 2,052.00                        | Children Park                        | ---do---                                            |                                    |
|        |                                           | Total Rs.              |                                 | 6,156.00                        |                                      |                                                     |                                    |
| 2      | Juice Shop/ Ice-Cream Parlor/ Milk Parlor | 171                    | 12                              | 2,052.00                        | Children Park Children Park          | ---do---                                            | केवल एक विक्रेता ( Vendor ) के लिए |
|        |                                           | 171                    | 12                              | 2,052.00                        | Children Park                        | ---do---                                            |                                    |
|        |                                           | 522                    | 12                              | 6,264.00                        | Children Park                        | ---do---                                            |                                    |
|        |                                           | Total Rs.              |                                 | 10,368.00                       |                                      |                                                     |                                    |
| 3      | Fruit/Vegetable Shop                      | 608                    | 12                              | 7,296.00                        | Children Park                        | ---do---                                            | केवल एक विक्रेता ( Vendor ) के लिए |
| 4      | Chicken Shop                              | 171                    | 12                              | 2,052.00                        | Behind Firing Range                  | ---do---                                            | केवल एक विक्रेता ( Vendor ) के लिए |

**आवेदन की शर्तें :** 1) आवेदक भारतीय नागरिक होना अनिवार्य है, 2) वैध पहचान पत्र (आधार/वोटर आई.डी.) संलग्न करना होगा, 3) आवेदक का चरित्र प्रमाण पत्र (Police Verification) अनिवार्य होगा, 4) स्वच्छता एवं स्वास्थ्य मानकों का पालन करना होगा, 5) कैम्पस के सुरक्षा नियमों एवं समय-सीमा को पूर्णतः पालन करना होगा, 6) दुकान केवल निर्धारित स्थान एवं समय में ही संचालित की जाएगी, 7) किसी भी प्रकार के प्रतिबंधित/अवैध वस्तु की बिक्री पूर्णतः वर्जित होगी, 8) इच्छुक एवं योग्य व्यक्ति/विक्रेता किसी एक दुकान के लिए ही आवेदन कर सकता है, 9) जिस आवेदक के आवेदन में अस्थायी दुकान/रेहडू के लिए दिए हुए न्यूनतम मासिक किराया से सबसे अधिक मासिक किराया देने के लिए वर्णित होगा उसी आवेदक को वह दुकान दी जाएगी, 10) यह अनुबंध 11 माह के लिए होगा, 11) संपदा अधिकारी द्वारा प्रशासनिक कारणों से अनुबंध को बिना कोई कारण बताये किसी भी समय निरस्त किया जा सकता है, 12) वापसी योग्य सुरक्षा जमा (Refundable security deposit) के रूप में 02 माह का देय मासिक किराया मात्र का DIGP GC CRPF Greater Noida, payable at SBI COLLECTORATE COMPOUND GREATER NOIDA (Branch Code : 005106) के पक्ष में देय डिमांड ड्राफ्ट। आवेदन जमा करने का तरीका : उपरोक्त अस्थायी दुकानें खोलने के लिए इच्छुक एवं योग्य व्यक्ति/विक्रेता अपना आवेदन निर्धारित प्रारूप में वांछित दस्तावेजों ( जैसे : 03 पासपोर्ट साइज रंगीन फोटो, पहचान पत्र की स्वयं सत्यापित प्रति, एवं अन्य दस्तावेज )वांछित पुलिस उप महानिरीक्षक सह संपदा अधिकारी, ग्रुप केन्द्र, केन्द्रीय रिजर्व पुलिस बल, ग्रेटर नोएडा, गौतमबुद्ध नगर ( उप्र0)-201306 के पता पर पंजीकृत डाक द्वारा या सीलबंद लिफाफा हाथों-हाथ दिनांक 25/05/2026 से प्रेषित/जमा कर सकते हैं। आवेदन प्राप्त की अंतिम तिथि दिनांक 10/06/2026 को 1600 बजे तक है। अन्यथा इसके बाद प्राप्त आवेदनों पर कोई विचार नहीं किया जायेगा। इस दिये हुए समयावधि में प्राप्त सभी आवेदन पत्रों को माफदण्डों के अनुसार जाँचोपरांत चयनित आवेदक/दुकानदारों को ही अस्थायी दुकानें आवंटित किये जायेंगे, जिसकी सूचना उसके पत्राचार पता पर/दुरभाष के माध्यम से दे दी जायेगी। नोट: विस्तृत विज्ञापन के0100युबल की वेबसाईट [www.crpfgov.in](http://www.crpfgov.in) पर उपलब्ध है।

पुलिस उप महानिरीक्षक  
ग्रुप केन्द्र, कैरियुबल, ग्रेटर नोएडा

### अस्थायी / अर्द्धस्थायी दुकान आवंटन हेतु आवेदन पत्र का प्रारूप

सेवा में,  
पुलिस उप महानिरीक्षक सह सम्पदा अधिकारी,  
ग्रुप केन्द्र, केन्द्रीय रिजर्व पुलिस बल, ग्रेटर नोएडा।  
गौतमबुद्ध नगर (उप्र) -201306.

विषय **अस्थायी / अर्द्धस्थायी दुकान आवंटन हेतु आवेदन पत्र**

महोदय,  
सविनय निवेदन है कि मैं समूह केन्द्र, केन्द्रीय रिजर्व पुलिस बल, ग्रेटर नोएडा परिसर में अस्थायी / अर्द्धअस्थायी दुकान संचालित करने हेतु आवेदन प्रस्तुत कर रहा / रही हूँ। मेरा विवरण इस प्रकार है : -

| क्र.सं0                                               | विवरण                                    |
|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| 1.                                                    | आवेदक का नाम .....                       |
| 2.                                                    | पिता / पति का नाम .....                  |
| 3.                                                    | पत्राचार का पूर्ण पता पिन कोड सहित ..... |
| 4.                                                    | स्थायी पता पिन कोड सहित .....            |
| 5.                                                    | मोबाइल नंबर .....                        |
| 6.                                                    | आधार संख्या .....                        |
| 7.                                                    | पैन कार्ड संख्या .....                   |
| 8.                                                    | व्यवसाय / कार्य अनुभव .....              |
| 9.                                                    | जिस दुकान हेतु आवेदन किया .....          |
| जा रहा है।                                            |                                          |
| 10.                                                   | प्रस्तावित मासिक किराया ( ₹0में) .....   |
| 11.                                                   | पूर्व में दुकान संचालन का अनुभव .....    |
| हाँ / नहीं, यदि हाँ तो ..... वर्ष ..... महीना         |                                          |
| 12.                                                   | एस0एस0एस0एस0आई0 रजिस्ट्रेशन संख्या ..... |
| 13.                                                   | पुलिस सत्यापन प्रमाण पत्र सलग .....      |
| हाँ / नहीं                                            |                                          |
| 14.                                                   | करना अनिवार्य है।                        |
| वापसी योग्य सुरक्षा जमा (Refundable security deposit) |                                          |
| के रूप में 02 माह का देय मासिक किराया मात्र का        |                                          |
| DIGP GC CRPF Greater Noida payable at                 |                                          |
| SBI Collectorate Compound Greater Noida               |                                          |
| (Branch Code : 005106) के पक्ष में देय डिमांड ड्राफ्ट |                                          |
| 15.                                                   | अन्य विवरण .....                         |

#### ‘घोषणा’

मैं मेरे द्वारा प्रस्तावित मासिक किराया राशि को स्वीकार करता / करती हूँ तथा यह सहमत करता / करती हूँ कि चयन प्रक्रिया में सर्वाधिक मासिक किराया प्रस्तावित करने वाले पात्र आवेदन को प्राथमिकता प्रदान की जायेगी।

सलगन दस्तावेज स्वरूपमांगित:

- |                                   |                                 |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| 1. आधार कार्ड / पहचान पत्र ।      | 2. पुलिस सत्यापन प्रमाण पत्र ।  |
| 3. पासपोर्ट आकार के 03 रंगीन फोटो | 4. अनुभव प्रमाण पत्र (यदि हो) । |
| 5. अन्य आवश्यक दस्तावेज।          | 6. देय डिमांड ड्राफ्ट           |

मैं यह घोषणा करता / करती हूँ कि मेरे द्वारा दी गई समस्त जानकारी सत्य एवं सही है। यदि कोई जानकारी असत्य पाई जाती है तो मेरा आवेदन निरस्त किया जा सकता है। मैं परिसर के सभी नियमों एवं शर्तों का पालन करने हेतु बाध्य रहूँगा / रहूँगी।

दिनांक  
स्थान

आवेदन का हस्ताक्षर  
नाम :

#### केवल कार्यालय उपयोग हेतु

आवेदन क्रमांक  
प्रस्तावित मासिक किराया : ₹0.....  
दस्तावेज सत्यापन : पूर्ण / अपूर्ण  
टिप्पणी :  
हस्ताक्षर

Dr. Inspector General of Police  
ग्रुप केन्द्र, केन्द्रीय रिजर्व पुलिस बल (उप्र)  
DIGP GC CRPF Greater Noida (U.P.)

at the request of Russia, Ukrainian Ambassador Melnyk Andrii denied his Russian counterpart's accusations of war crimes, calling

## Iran, US near understanding to end war: Officials

**SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad**

The United States and Iran are close to agreeing on a memorandum of understanding aimed at ending the war, two regional officials and a diplomat said Saturday, as the United States has weighed a new round of attacks on the Islamic Republic.

Iran signalled “narrowing differences” in negotiations with the US after Pakistan's army chief held more talks in Tehran, and US Secretary of State Marco Rubio told journalists in India that “there’s been

some progress made” and “there may be news later today.” The officials and diplomats expressed hope that a final decision on the Pakistan-prepared draft could come within 48 hours as both sides review it.

They spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to brief the media.

They said Vice President JD Vance and envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner played significant roles in helping bridge remaining gaps, and that Qatar played a key role by sending a senior official to Tehran to support Pakistan's

mediation efforts.

Still, both Iran and the US emphasised their key positions and have warned of the risks of resuming attacks. Iran state TV quoted Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei as describing the draft as a “framework agreement” and adding: “We want this to include the main issues required for ending the imposed war and other issues of essential importance to us. Then, over a reasonable time span, between 30 and 60 days, details are discussed, and ultimately a final agreement is reached.”

## Attackers burn Ebola treatment tent in Congo; 18 suspected cases escape

**JUSTIN KABUMBA/WILSON MCMAKIN ■ Bunia**

A tent used for treatment of the Ebola outbreak in eastern Congo was set on fire for the second time this week, and 18 people suspected of infection escaped into the general population, the local hospital director said on Saturday.

Unidentified people arrived at the clinic in Mongbwalu, a town at the centre of the outbreak of the Bundibugyo virus, a rare type of Ebola, on Friday night and set fire to a tent set up by the Doctors Without Borders charity for suspected and confirmed Ebola cases, Dr Richard Lokudi, director of the Mongbwalu General Reference Hospital said.

“We strongly condemn this act, as it caused panic among the staff of the Mongbwalu Referral Hospital and also resulted in the escape of 18 suspected cases into the community,” he said.

On Thursday, another treatment centre in the town of Rwampara was burned down after family members were prohibited from retrieving the body of a local man.

The bodies of those who died of Ebola can be highly contagious and lead to further spread when people prepare them for burial and gather for funerals. The dangerous work of burying suspected victims is being managed wherever possible by authorities, which can be met by protests from families and friends.

A burial for Ebola patients in Bunia, another town within the outbreak zone, took place on Saturday under high security as tensions between health workers and the local community ran high. Authorities in northeastern Congo on Friday banned funeral wakes and gatherings of more than 50 people in an effort to curb the spread of the virus. The World Health Organisation said that the outbreak



now poses a “very high” risk for Congo - up from a previous categorisation of “high” - but that the risk of the disease spreading globally remains low.

WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus said Friday that 82 cases and seven deaths have been confirmed in Congo, but that the outbreak is believed to be “much larger.” There is no available vaccine for the Bundibugyo virus, which spread undetected for weeks in Congo's Ituri

province following the first known death, while authorities tested for another, more common, Ebola virus and came up negative. There are now 750 suspected cases and 177 suspected deaths, though more are expected as surveillance expands. Dr Jean Kaseya, director-general of the Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention, said a response to the outbreak must include building trust with communities. (AP)

## Two traffic accidents in Cambodia kill 14 garment factory workers

**ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Phnom Penh**

Two separate traffic accidents in Cambodia on Saturday killed at least 14 garment factory workers and injured 93 others, mostly women.

The garment sector is Cambodia's main export earner, with low labour costs being its competitive advantage. Salaries, including overtime, generally amount to \$200-300 a month.

The first incident occurred in the province of Kampong Chhnang, approximately 60 kilometres north of the capital, Phnom Penh, when a heavy cargo truck crashed into an open-top truck transporting workers to their factory. Nine people were killed and 53 injured, according to a state-



ment issued by the Labour Ministry.

The second crash occurred in the southeastern province

of Svay Rieng, one of Cambodia's main garment-factory hubs. Flatbed trucks are the usual method of trans-

portation available for workers. They often lack seats or benches, forcing passengers to stand, significantly

increasing the risk of injury or death. The Labour Ministry stated it was “deeply shocked by two horrific traffic accidents that occurred simultaneously” and appealed for strict compliance with traffic laws to prevent accidents.

A Transport Ministry report notes that 1,467 people were killed in traffic accidents in 2025, making it by far the leading cause of deaths by accident in the Southeast Asian nation. Cambodia's garment sector, comprising clothing, footwear, and travel items, employs an estimated 8,00,000 to 1 million people in approximately 1,900 factories, with production accounting for more than \$15.5 billion in exports last year, according to the country's Ministry of Commerce.

## France bans Ben-Gvir abuse of Gaza flotilla activists

**ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris**

France on Saturday banned Israel's far-right national security minister, Itamar Ben-Gvir, citing his “unspeakable” behaviour targeting activists from a flotilla to Gaza who were detained by his police force.

“As of today, Itamar Ben-Gvir is banned from entering French territory.

This decision follows his unspeakable actions toward French and European citizens who were passengers on the Global Sumud Flotilla,” the French foreign minister, Jean-Noel Barrot, announced in a post on X. “We cannot tolerate

that French nationals can be threatened, intimidated or brutalised in this way - all the more so by a public official,” Barrot posted, calling on the European Union to also sanction Ben-Gvir.

The Associated Press has sought comment from Ben-Gvir's spokesperson and the office of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

This week, Ben-Gvir sparked global outrage after promoting a video of himself taunting detained flotilla activists. In one clip, Ben-Gvir is seen waving a large Israeli flag over hunched-over detainees whose hands appear to be bound.

## Chang’e-7 will conduct moon south pole environment resource surveys

**PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Beijing**

China's lunar exploration mission Chang'e-7, which is scheduled for launch later this year, will conduct environmental and resource surveys of the Moon's south pole, the China Manned Space Agency said on Saturday.

The mission will employ a comprehensive exploration approach encompassing orbiting, landing, roving and hopping, Chinese official media quoted Zhang Jingbo, the agency's spokesperson, as saying. The robotic mission, targeting the Moon's south pole, aims to search for water ice and assess the region for a future resource base.

In April, the Chang'e-7 lunar probe was delivered to the launch site in the southern island province of Hainan, where it is



undergoing pre-launch preparations. All related work is progressing steadily as planned, Zhang said. In 2023, India became the first country to land near the little-explored lunar south pole region when its Chandrayaan-3's lander, carrying the Pragyaan rover, successfully landed there.

# Coal mine gas explosion in north China kills 90

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Beijing

Ninety miners were killed in a gas explosion in a coal mine in north China, official media in Beijing reported on Saturday, adding that 201 miners have so far been rescued. The gas explosion occurred at the Liushenyu coal mine. Rescue efforts are ongoing.

The death toll rose to 90 following a coal mine accident in Qinyuan County in north China's Shanxi Province, state-run China Daily reported. Chinese President Xi Jinping has issued instructions for a comprehensive rescue operation and treatment of the injured. He has called for proper han-



Medical staff attending to an injured worker at a hospital in the aftermath of an explosion at Changzhi city's Liushenyu coal mine in Qinyuan county, northern China's Shanxi Province on Saturday

AP

dling of the aftermath of the accident and sought a thorough investigation into its cause, with accountability pursued in accordance with the law. Xi has stressed that authorities across the country must learn from the accident, remain vigilant on workplace safety, and intensify efforts to identify and eliminate potential risks to prevent major accidents.

As China enters its flood season, Xi also called for strengthened emergency preparedness and solid flood control and disaster relief measures to safeguard people's lives and property.

Vice Premier Zhang Guoqing has led a team to the site to oversee the rescue efforts. Shanxi province is

known as China's main coal mining province. With a size larger than Greece and a population of around 34 million, the province's hundreds of thousands of miners dug 1.3 billion tons (1.17 billion metric tons) of coal last year, nearly a third of China's total. Mining disasters are common in China, where rapid industrialisation came with intense resource exploitation, poor working conditions and a weak regulatory framework.

Mine owners and local officials are frequently blamed for putting profits ahead of safety. Underground explosions often are blamed on a lack of ventilation equipment to clear gas that seeps from the coal bed.

## Buddhist monk accused of child sexual abuse is released on bail in Sri Lanka

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Colombo

A Sri Lankan court released on bail a senior Buddhist monk who was arrested on suspicion of sexually abusing a minor, in a case that has stirred heated debate in a country where Buddhism is the main religion.

Pallegama Hemarathana, 71, was arrested earlier this month on allegations of abusing a 14-year-old girl. A court ordered him to be kept in custody for questioning, but he spent his time in a hospital, citing health issues.

He was arrested along with the girl's mother, who was accused of aiding the monk in his actions.

A court in the historic city of Anuradhapura on Friday ordered both released on bail, police said.

Hemarathana is a high profile monk in Sri Lanka, the custodian of eight major ancient Buddhist sites in Anuradhapura that are venerated by Buddhists around the world. He has denied any wrongdoing. More than 70 per cent of Sri Lanka's 22 million people are Buddhists, and monks have a strong influence in the country's political and social life.



# Estonia to be gateway to Europe market for India: Envoy

ASIM KAMAL ■ Tallinn

Estonia can be the gateway to northern European markets for India once the FTA with the European Union comes into effect, Indian Ambassador Ashish Sinha has said, asserting that the bilateral relationship is on an upswing.

In an interview with PTI, Sinha said there is a robust base of existing trade to be used as a "springboard" for further engagement between India and Estonia when the India-EU free trade agreement comes into force.

The Indian Ambassador to Estonia asserted that the overall bilateral relationship is going from strength to strength and getting



Ashish Sinha

stronger. "Going forward, with the India-EU FTA, there will be far more engagement of the small and medium-sized industries, and the dairy and agriculture products from Estonia will find their market

in India. For India, we will have Estonia as a gateway to northern Europe," Sinha said. Noting that Estonia also offers e-residency, Sinha said many of the Indian businessmen and high-value industrialists have taken Estonia's e-residency, and about 5,000 Indians are part of the Estonian initiative.

"About over 1,000 Indians have their companies registered under the e-residency programme of Estonia," he added.

"So, there are elements which provide a basis to use as a springboard when the India-EU FTA comes into force for further engagement. I must tell you that Indian exports to Estonia

not only grew but it has overshot their target in the last financial year," the Indian envoy said. The new and emerging technologies are going to form a major part of the business, he said.

"Digital technologies, IT, AI-enabled technologies, software as a service, all these areas have great potential. Estonia is the world leader, and so is India.

"Our digital public infrastructure and our capacity to roll out digital innovations at the population scale, and Estonia's proven capacity to use digital transformation of its citizen services, both have great capacity to learn from each

other and grow," Sinha said. Asked about India's perspective on regional security in the context of the Ukraine-Russia conflict, he said India and Estonia are both democracies, have democratic, plural values, respect for international law and want to grow, and for that "we support international peace and security".

"In that context, Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited Moscow and Kyiv both in 2024 and was one of the first leaders to assert that this is not the era of war, this is the era of dialogue and diplomacy. I am sure Estonia also wants peace in its neighbourhood, and we both have similar objectives there," Sinha said.

(PTI)

# 13 terrorists from TTP arrested in Pakistan



M ZULQERNAIN ■ Lahore

A major terror attack have been foiled by police in Pakistan's Punjab province and 13 terrorists, mostly belonging to the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), have been arrested, a spokesperson for the Counter Terrorism Department (CTD) said on Saturday.

"The CTD conducted 58 intelligence-based operations in different cities of the province during the last week and arrested 13 terrorists along with weapons, explosives and other prohibited materials," the spokesperson said.

"The terrorists wanted to target the offices of law enforcement agencies in Punjab; thus, thwarting a major terror attack," the spokesperson said and added that "dangerous terrorist" Mukhtar Ahmad of TTP was arrested from Lahore with a large quantity of explosives.

Explosive material 2,010 grams, eight detonators, four

IED bombs and banned literature were recovered from their possession.

Thirteen cases have been registered against the arrested terrorists in the CTD police stations, and further investigation is being carried out against them, he said.

According to the police, several militant hideouts were reportedly targeted during the operation.

Security officials said the militants were allegedly planning subversive activities in the area. Following the gunfight, police and CTD teams launched search operations in the area to trace the remaining militants.

The Khyber Pakhtunkhwa region in northwest Pakistan has faced recurring unrest over the years, driven by militant violence, cross-border movement of fighters from Afghanistan and repeated military operations. Its mountainous terrain and porous frontier add to the challenges for security forces.

(PTI)

# Remains of four Italian divers killed in Maldives cave dive repatriated

KRISHAN FRANCIS ■ Colombo

The remains of four Italian divers who died deep inside an underwater cave earlier this month while diving in the Maldives were repatriated early on Saturday, a Maldivian Government spokesperson said.

Five Italian divers went missing on May 14 while exploring the cave about 50 metres (160 feet) in Vaavu Atoll. The body of their Italian diving instructor was recovered outside the cave at the time and returned home. A high-risk operation to recover the bodies faced hurdles and was initially suspended after Mohamed Mahudhee, Madlivan, a military diver who was part of the recovery team, was killed. Three Finnish expert deep and cave divers joined the mission and located the four bodies last week in the innermost chamber of the cave at a depth of around



60 metres (200 feet). The recreational diving limit in the Maldives is 30 metres (98 feet). Maldives President's Spokesman Mohamed Hussain Shareef said Saturday two investigations were initiated; one into the death of the five divers and the other probing how Mahudheea died while on duty. Shareef also said Italy agreed to share any findings if autopsies were performed on the repatriated bodies.

(AP)

# One dead, 36 injured after fire at New York City shipyard

ASSOCIATED PRESS  
■ New York

One person has died after a fire and two explosions Friday at a New York City shipyard, officials say.

Officials said 36 people were injured, most of them firefighters and other first responders, and one civilian died at the scene.

A firefighter and a fire marshal were inside the structure when a second explosion happened, and both were seriously injured by the shock wave from the blast. "This was a complex, fast-developing emergency situation," New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani said during a news conference Friday evening. Multiple



people called the fire department around 3:30 pm, reporting smoke and two workers trapped in the basement of a 150-foot by 150-foot metal structure at the back of the shipyard, Fire Commissioner Lillian Bonsignore said.

Firefighting and EMS crews were on the scene within six minutes. But shortly after they arrived, an explosion occurred, causing serious injuries to multiple fire department members and a couple of civilians, Bonsignore said -- including

one who died at the scene.

Five firefighters and rescue paramedics were searching for the trapped workers inside, on top of and next to the structure when the second blast occurred, said Chief of Department John Esposito, causing more injuries.

The most serious injuries happened to a fire marshal and a firefighter who were inside and hit by the energy wave from the blast.

"Confined spaces are very dangerous operations for any rescuers," Esposito said.

The fire marshal is in critical but stable condition with a fractured skull and a small brain bleed, said the fire department's chief medical officer Dr David

# East China Indian Cricket Tournament begins in Shanghai



KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

Consul General of India in Shanghai, Pratik Mathur, inaugurated the annual East China Indian Diaspora Cricket Tournament and the curtain-raiser event for the International Day of Yoga (IDY) 2026 in Shanghai on Saturday. The event was jointly organised by the Indian Association Shanghai and Nord Anglia International School Shanghai Pudong, and witnessed enthusiastic participation from members of the Indian diaspora, the international community, yoga practitioners, and cricket enthusiasts from across the East China region, according to a Shanghai Consulate statement. Mathur said the large-scale participation in the IDY 2026 curtain raiser

activities highlighted the growing global commitment towards yoga as a means of promoting wellness, harmony, and peace.

The strong cross-cultural appeal of cricket, with players and participants from diverse nationalities and communities joining the tournament, reflected the spirit of friendship, community engagement, and people-to-people connections fostered through sports and wellness initiatives, he said.

The combined celebration of cricket and yoga once again demonstrated the strong support and respect enjoyed by the Indian community, India's cultural traditions, and its global outreach initiatives in East China, the statement said.

(PTI)

# Elizabeth II zardozi gown from India tour shines in UK



ADITI KHANNA ■ London

An evening gown with *zardozi* work depicting India's national flower, the lotus, is among the prized fashion items on display at one of the UK's largest royal exhibitions in memory of the late Queen Elizabeth II. The gown was designed by Norman Hartnell, Dressmaker to the Queen, for a state dinner hosted by then President Dr Rajendra Prasad in Delhi in January 1961. It forms the centrepiece of the 'Diplomatic Dressing' section of the 'Queen Elizabeth II: Her Life in Style' exhibition. The display recently opened to the public at the King's Gallery in London's Buckingham Palace

to the mark the birth centenary year of Britain's longest reigning monarch, mother of King Charles III.

"For a state dinner given in the Queen's honour in Delhi, the Hartnell gown with its *zardozi*-type (metal thread) embellishment in the form of India's national flower, the lotus, was highly appropriate," reads the curator's note. The silk dress embellished with lace, pearl beads, crystals and sequins originally had a train falling from the Queen's shoulders, which was later removed for the dress to be adapted to include a short bolero jacket allowing for later understated use.

(PTI)

# Heat wave conditions in southern, western Nepal districts

SHIRISH B PRADHAN  
■ Kathmandu

Several districts in south-west Nepal may face extremely high temperatures apart from a heat wave in western Terai areas starting from Saturday till Monday, disaster management officials said.

Some areas in southern districts of Lumbini and Sudur Paschim Provinces may witness extremely high temperatures crossing 40 degree Celsius, warned a National Disaster Risk Reduction Management Authority (NDRRMA) notice.

Moderate heat waves are expected to affect some parts of the two provinces, the notice said, adding, six districts, namely, Banke, Dang, Bardia, Doti, Kailali and Kanchanpur are listed under districts where people are cautioned against high temperature and heat waves.

Sudur Paschim and Lumbini normally experience temperatures around 40 degree Celsius or more during summer, meteorological officials said.

(PTI)

# Pope visits Italy's Land of Fires as families seek justice for kids lost to toxic waste

SILVIA STELLACCI ■ Acerra

Families living in a toxic-waste polluted area around Naples were preparing to meet Pope Leo XIV during his pastoral visit on Saturday, carrying with them years of grief, anger and hopes for justice after losing children to cancer linked to a multi-billion mafia racket of dumping toxic waste.

The visit to the so-called Terra dei Fuochi, or Land of Fires, comes on the eve of the 11th anniversary of Pope Francis' big ecological encyclical Laudato Si (Praised Be), and indicates Leo's interest in carrying on his predecessor's environmental agenda. The European Court of Human Rights last year val-



Pope Leo XIV arriving in Calipari Square in Acerra near Naples, Italy

AP

idated a generation of residents' complaints that mafia dumping, burial and burning of toxic waste led to an increased rate of cancer and other ailments in the area of 90 municipalities around Caserta and Naples, encompassing a population of 2.9 million people.

The court found Italian authorities had known since 1988 about the toxic pollution, blamed on the Camorra crime syndicate that controls waste disposal, but failed to take necessary steps to protect residents' lives.

The binding ruling gave Italy two years to set up a database about the toxic waste and verified health risks associated with living there. The pope will visit the

city of Acerra to meet families who lost young relatives to cancer, the human cost of environmental pollution. Bishop Antonio Di Donna estimated 150 young people died in the city of some 58,000 over the past three decades. "We very much wanted the pope to meet with them because these children and young people who have died are, to all intents and purposes, victims of environmental pollution. There is a link, a correlation between pollution and the incidence of cancer," Di Donna said.

The victims include Maria Venturato, who died of cancer in 2016 at the age of 25. Her father Angelo said he hopes to speak with the pope to explain

their reality, "not for me... for the next generation."

"I'd like to give these young people a future, so I'm asking for the pope's help with this. That is, I'm making a strong appeal to him to go to those in power and say, Look, let's heal this land of fires," he said. Filomena Carolla plans to present the pope with a book containing memories from the life of her daughter, Tina De Angelis, who died of cancer at the age of 24.

"I'm just angry at the people who poisoned the soil, because what did our children have to do with it? What did they have to do with it, so young," Carolla said. Francis' plans to visit the area in 2020 were cancelled by the pandemic.

(AP)



BRIEFLY

## North Korean club wins Asian Women’s Champions League



North Korea's Naegohyang FC defeated Tokyo Verdy Beleza 1-0 to win soccer's Asian Women's Champions League on Saturday in the South Korean city of Suwon. Kim Kyong Yong scored the only goal of the game, her fourth of the tournament, just before halftime.

The North Korean international forward, who also scored the winning goal in the semifinal win over South Korea's Suwon FC on Wednesday, shot home from inside the area after receiving the ball from Kim Jung who broke free of the Japanese defense. Watched by a sparse crowd at Suwon Sports Complex, just south of Seoul, the team from Pyongyang had more chances than Tokyo in what was a tight game and deserved to win just the second edition of the 12-team continental tournament, following Wuhan Jiangda's triumph a year earlier. The triumph continues unprecedented success for North Korea in women's soccer. In 2024, the national team won both the U-20 and U-17 World Cups, and successfully defended the latter in 2025.

## Nadal, Gauff and Pegula pay tributes to Howard Fendrich



Rafael Nadal, Coco Gauff and Jessica Pegula were among those paying tribute to Associated Press tennis writer Howard Fendrich as players gathered at Roland Garros for a French Open that's now missing one of the sport's most-respected journalists. Fendrich, a regular at Roland Garros and all the tennis majors since 2002, died Thursday, less than three months after being diagnosed with cancer.

The news elicited a social media outpouring that included a Friday morning post from Nadal, whose record 14 French Open victories were chronicled in rich and colorful detail by Fendrich. "Tennis loses one of its great journalists," Nadal said. Gauff, whose title last year at Roland Garros was her second major singles championship, opened her pre-tournament news conference with a shout-out to Fendrich, the award-winning writer who spent 24 of his 33 years with AP on the tennis beat.

"I just wanted to start this off just recognizing a deep loss that I think we all have experienced as a community with Howard," Gauff said. "He was someone I always enjoyed having conversations with. One of my favorite faces to see in the room." Fendrich died Thursday at Johns Hopkins Hospital in Baltimore. He was diagnosed with cancer in February shortly after returning from Milan, where he covered his 11th Olympics. He was 55. The Women's Tennis Association wrote a tribute to Fendrich, recalling that "His classic opening before a question, soooo, I'm curious ..." always set a comfortable tone of kindness in interviews.

## Talwar hangs inside Top-20 in Denmark

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Odense (Denmark)

Indian golfer Saptak Talwar showed signs of taking his good form at home to Europe as he carded 67-70 to easily make the cut at the Danish Challenge Open on the Hotel Planner Tour here.

Talwar, who won one event on the domestic DP World PGTI Tour and leads the Order of Merit, had six birdies against one bogey in his first round and sizzled with six birdies against one bogey on the front nine in the second round.

At that point he was in line to be inside Top-5. He slipped with a double bogey on Par-4 16th and a bogey on the 17th to drop to T-16.

The 27-year-old Talwar



played in the afternoon sessions when the wind was much demanding than in the morning wave. Yet he did superbly on the front nine. Talwar has been focussing on dividing his time between home tour, where he has finished inside

# Si Woo Kim just misses history at Byron Nelson

SCHUYLER DIXON  
■ McKinney (USA)

Si Woo Kim just missed out on a 59 at the CJ Cup Byron Nelson, bogeying the final hole when a par would have given him the 16th sub-60 round in PGA Tour history.

The 30-year-old South Korean put himself in position to break 60 with a curling 17-foot birdie putt from the fringe on the par-3 17th hole at TPC Craig Ranch on Friday. It was his 12th birdie of the day, putting him at 12 under on the par-71 layout.

Kim was in the fairway on the 18th, but blasted his second shot over the green. His chip coming back stopped about 19 feet short of the hole, and his putt for par

lacked pace and broke to the right for his only bogey of the day. Kim shot 11-under 60 for a five-shot lead at 18-under 124 after two rounds.

The 18th hole at Craig Ranch - about 30 miles north of Dallas - is a par 4 for the first time in the six Nelson tournaments it has hosted. A \$25 million overhaul designed by Lanny Wadkins changed it from a par 5, and it has played as the hardest hole on the course through two rounds.

Most of the rest of the holes are as easy as they've been in the past — despite more bunkers along the fairways and contours on the greens. Part of the the reason is soft conditions from a rainy opening day and calm winds



that aren't supposed to pick up on the weekend, either. Because of the rain on Thursday, players were still allowed to lift, clean and place their golf balls in the fairway. Kim, playing with world number 1 Scottie

Scheffler and five-time major winner Brooks Koepka, took full advantage.

The four-time PGA Tour winner who lives in Dallas already had seven birdies through 10 holes when he put his 166-yard approach shot at

## Soudal Open: Sandhu makes cut; Sharma misses out

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Antwerp

Indians had mixed luck as Yuvraj Sandhu (70-68) made the cut, while Shubhankar Sharma (70-72) missed the weekend at the Soudal Open at Rinkven International Golf Club near Antwerp here in Belgium.

Sandhu, playing his first season on the DP World Tour, had four birdies against three bogeys on the first day and was T-72, but his second round of 68 with five birdies against two bogeys saw him rise to T-51 and make the cut.

After a rather slow start to the season when he missed six cuts on the DPWT, Sandhu made the weekend at Turkish Airlines Open and the Estrella



Damm Catalunya Championship. Both Sandhu and Sharma missed out on the US Open qualifiers, but this week Sandhu has against made the cut showing signs that he is adjusting to Europe.

Sharma in 13 starts this season has made six cuts and missed seven with a best of T-32 in Mauritius.



South Africa's Zander Lombard produced a great finish while France's Tom Vaillant continued his remarkable consistency as the two players shared the halfway lead after the second round. The 31-year-old, Lombard, who held a one stroke lead after the opening round in Belgium, holed a

long-range birdie putt from 31 feet at the last to join the Frenchman at the top of the leaderboard after 36 holes.

It came after Vaillant produced a second consecutive bogeyà free round to set the early target, following up an opening 65 with a superb seven-under-par 64.

The pair sit three strokes clear of a group of five players, made up of Jacob Skov Olesen, Casey Jarvis, Richard Sterne, Jorge Campillo and Ben Schmidt.

Elsewhere, Belgium's Nicolas Colsaerts said an emotional farewell in front of friends and family on the 18th green, missing the cut in his final start by two strokes but ending his career grateful.

## Lens lift French Cup for first time

ASSOCIATED PRESS  
■ Paris

Lens capped a spectacular season by winning the French Cup for the first time, with star striker Florian Thauvin scoring and making another in a 3-1 win over Nice in the final.

Lens matched Paris Saint-Germain in Ligue 1 for large parts of the season but struggled to match its resources during the latter weeks of the campaign and finished second, six points behind.

Friday's win at the Stade de France was a merited triumph for a side that under coach Pierre Sage mixed young prospects with experienced journeymen to great effect. Thauvin scored the

opener after 25 minutes — meaning he scored in the quarterfinal, semifinal, and final — and Odsbonne Edouard doubled Lens' lead when he headed home Thauvin's corner from the left three minutes before halftime.

Djibril Coulibaly pulled one back almost immediately for Nice but Abdallah Sima made sure the trophy was heading to the north of France when he muscled his way past Nice defenders to poke home for 3-1 with 12 minutes remaining.

The result was tough on Nice, which hit the woodwork twice, but perhaps no surprise after a woeful last few weeks of the season. Nice has not won in Ligue 1 since mid-March and ended



the year in third-to-last place. Its Ligue 1 status will be decided next week in a home-and-away promotion/relegation playoff against Saint-Etienne.

Referee wears number 84The final was notable for the numbered shirts worn by

referee Jerome Brisard as part of a campaign designed to foster respect for match officials. Brisard wore number 84 on his back, in reference to a poll that showed 84 per cent of French respondents believe that "valuing referees means protecting sport."

## Russell aims to recapture F1 momentum in Canada, stop Antonelli’s streak

JAMES ELLINGWORTH  
■ Montreal

An upgraded car and a "painful" reminder not to lose sight of the Formula 1 fundamentals could be George Russell's path back to the front of the field at the Canadian Grand Prix.

Russell's fourth place at the last race in Miami gave his Mercedes teammate Kimi Antonelli a yawning 20-point lead in the standings after four races. The 19-year-old Italian has won three in a row. Russell said one reason he lost ground was focusing too much on the standout feature of the 2026 cars, their massive electrical power output, and neglecting the basics.

"Dealing with the tires, dealing with the setup, just



fundamentals of racing, has kind of been put on the back-burner because we're all so focused on energy management," he said.

"We missed some key things because we were focused elsewhere and that was a good little reminder. As painful as it was, it was a very

much-needed weekend because I think it's going to prove very beneficial."

Antonelli's lead grew in Miami because McLaren, Ferrari and Red Bull brought upgrades that helped them fight for the podium places. Now it's Mercedes' turn to bring upgraded parts for the

car that's won all four Grand Prix races in 2026 so far.

On Friday in qualifying for the sprint race Saturday, Russell edged Antonelli for the pole. "This is an amazing circuit here," Russell said. "High grip, feels like you're driving a proper Formula 1 car around here, which is how it should be and I'm glad today it came together." Antonelli's place in historyCanada offers the chance of a big points swing. It's hosting a sprint race Saturday for the first time, putting another maximum eight points on offer.

The threat of rain in Montreal on Sunday would shake things up, too. After storms predicted for Miami never materialized, the 2026 cars have yet to race in wet weather. It's early to talk of

the title at just the fifth round of the season but a fourth win in a row would put the 19-year-old Antonelli into an exclusive club. Every driver who's won four or more consecutive Grand Prix has been an F1 champion at some point in their career.

History does offer a little encouragement to Russell, though. The one time in F1 history that a driver won four consecutive races in a season but not the title came in 2016 when Lewis Hamilton was beaten by his then-Mercedes teammate Nico Rosberg. More recently, Oscar Piastri won three in a row for McLaren last year and still lost to teammate Lando Norris. Another wave of engine changesIt's a busy time to be an F1 engine manufacturer.

## Fiorentina draws with Atalanta

ASSOCIATED PRESS  
■ Florence

Fiorentina drew with Atalanta 1-1 and the clubs rounded out disappointing Serie A campaigns.

Roberto Piccoli put Fiorentina ahead just before halftime on Friday but an own goal from Pietro Comuzzo eight minutes from time gave Atalanta a share of the points and ensured Fiorentina's worst league placing since 2019.

The Florence club started the season horrendously and had to wait until the 16th round to record its first league win. A recovery



in the new year boosted its league position and it was in 14th place although it could fall further if Genoa or Cagliari, the two teams immediately below it, win this weekend.

## Not quite SNL’s ‘All-Drug Olympics’, but the enhanced games are no joke

EDDIE PELLIS  
■ Las Vegas

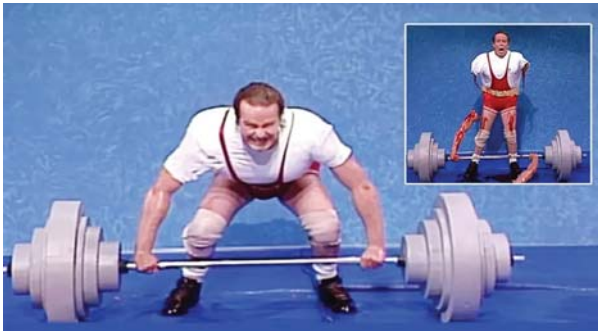
The first, best and most hilarious rendition of the "All Drug Olympics" came courtesy of "Saturday Night Live." It was 1988 when Soviet weightlifter "Sergei Akmudov," geeked up on anabolic steroids, Nyquil and "some sort of fish paralyzer," tried to clean and jerk 1,500 pounds — three times the existing world record — only to have his arms snap off at the shoulders.

Blood and gore gushed from where his arms used to be. Laughter cascaded as the on-site reporter, Kevin Nealon, threw it back to Dennis Miller in the studio.

It took almost 40 years, but finally, the event that tackles

that age-old bar question, "What would happen if we just let them all take drugs?" has arrived.

"The Enhanced Games," featuring 50 athletes who have been free to use performance enhancers of their choice and will compete in track, swimming and, yes, weightlifting, is set for Sunday in Las Vegas. Is it just a bad joke? Depends on who you ask. "A big success for us would be the athletes being healthy, safe, better paid and happier than they've ever been before," said Max Martin, the CEO and co-founder of Enhanced. Mainstream sports ignoring Enhanced - they're not the only onesThe Associated Press spoke with a handful of



leaders in the Olympic and anti-doping world, most of whom would not agree to speak on the record, even to denigrate the Enhanced Games, lest they lend oxygen to an idea they largely portrayed as a cynical money grab for washed-up athletes. Benjamin Cohen, director

general of the International Testing Agency that spearheads testing for the Olympics along with dozens of individual sports, was among those who would comment.

"I've heard some people calling it the Doping Olympics, but even using the word Olympics (is a stretch),"

Cohen said. "At the end of the day, it's a one-day event, it's 2,000 people eating popcorn and there's a music concert. It's (50) athletes. It's not right to put it on the same level."

The germ of the idea for the Enhanced Games formed in 2022. Then, the event was largely seen as a disruptive, potentially paradigm-shifting sports event meant to poke at the mainstream anti-doping world's troubled enforcement efforts and Olympic sports' inability to pay a living wage to a disturbingly large percentage of their athletes. It has since evolved into a new-age online pharmaceutical company, which describes itself as a "global movement that develops scientific insights, medical discoveries

and record-breaking sports events to unite humanity and inspire innovation."

Enhanced, which became a publicly traded company May 8 and has seen its initial stock price drop by around half to \$5.24 as of Friday afternoon, made some of its biggest headlines early by touting its \$250,000 first prizes and bonuses of up to \$1 million for those who break world records in top events like the 100-metre sprint.

Those marks, of course, would not count in any real sports record book. They have to come in events sanctioned by, say, World Athletics or World Aquatics, both of which require athletes to pass drug tests for any result to count.

# Shreyas' maiden IPL hundred keeps PBKS in play-offs race

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Lucknow

Punjab Kings rediscovered their winning touch after six defeats in a row through skipper Shreyas Iyer's majestic unbeaten 101 as they handed Lucknow Super Giants a seven-wicket towelling to stay alive in the IPL playoffs race here on Saturday.

Shreyas, whose maiden IPL hundred came off 51 balls, and Prabhsimran Singh (69, 39 balls) added 140 runs for the third wicket as Punjab scaled down LSG's 196 for two in 18 overs. PBKS made 200 for three. The victory helped Punjab to reach 15 points from their all 14 league engagements to reclaim the No. 4 position on the table.

But now, they will have to go

through an excruciating wait to know their fate as Rajasthan Royals (14) are taking on Mumbai Indians on Sunday at Mumbai.

If RR win the match then, Punjab will enter the playoffs as the fourth placed team with 16 points.

The Kolkata Knight Riders (13 points), who are up against Delhi Capitals in the weekend's second clash, too have an outside chance should RR fail to go past MI.

In that case, it will be a battle of net run rate between KKR and PBKS, with both tied on 15 points. Royal Challengers Bengaluru, Sunrisers Hyderabad and Gujarat Titans are already in the knock-outs. But the equation worries are for another time, as Shreyas showed his steely nerves while chasing yet again with a fabulous knock. Opener Priyansh Arya fell



to a first-ball duck to Mohammad Shami (2/45) and the veteran India pacer uprooted Cooper Connolly's off-stump as PBKS plunged into turmoil. But Shreyas was least bothered about those early impediments, and as expected, lorded over spinners Digvesh Rathee, scorching him for a flurry of onside boundaries, and Prabhsimran, who got reprieves on 20 and 62, backed his leader with aplomb.

Prabhsimran reached his sixth fifty of the season off 26 balls while his senior partner reached that mark in 33 balls.

Once crossed fifty, Shreyas wore the cape of an enforcer, and the next 51 runs came off just 18 balls.

The dismissal of Prabhsimran, who fell leg before to left-arm pacer Arjun Tendulkar, was a minor aberration as Punjab reached him with ease.

Shreyas, who reached his hundred with a six off Mohsin Khan that also signalled PBKS' win, also pummelled Shami for three sixes in an over to speed his side to victory march. Earlier, Josh Inglis made a typically punishing 72, guiding LSG to a handy 196 for six. Inglis and Pant (26, 21b) added 65 runs for the fourth wicket as the already-eliminated Super Giants recovered from a shaky 69 for three in the seventh over.

Inglis' 42-ball innings had two phases in it. The first part contained an opening over assault on Arshdeep Singh, four fours fetching the Aussie 16 runs.

But then he left the stage for Ayush Badoni, who came to the crease after the early dismissal of Arshin Kulkarni, who opened in the place of Mitchell Marsh, and Nicholas Pooran.

Badoni took the centre stage in some style, making an 18-ball 43 and added 49 runs for the third wicket with Inglis.

He creamed Azmatullah Omarzai, the No.1 all rounder as per ICC rankings, for 24 runs in the fifth over, and the run glut included a sequence of 4,6,6,4.

It helped LSG recover from the early departures of two top-order batters and end the power play at a rather fine 66 for two. But Badoni's daredevilry ended soon as Prabhsimran effected a smart stumping off Yuzvendra Chahal, and DRS upheld its validity.

However, Inglis woke up from his stupor with a slew of sparkling shots around the ground, and he started the second segment of his innings smashing a six, four and four in a row of Arshdeep.

In all, Inglis milked Arshdeep for six fours and two sixes, extending the India left-arm pacer's lean season. It brought Pant and Inglis together. Pant, who was dropped on 18 by Shreyas at covers off Chahal, was not at his fluent best, but stayed there to give some valuable company to Inglis.

The Aussie right-hander reached his fifty in 28 balls but lost the company of Pant, who fell to Chahal (2/25). Inglis eventually fell to part-timer Shahshank Singh, giving an easy catch to Shreyas, who had stationed himself at a more straight long-on position.

## More than having maturity, it's about shot selection: Ishan Kishan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Hyderabad

Sunrisers Hyderabad's Ishan Kishan on Friday credited his shot selection to his maturity as a player, as the India wicketkeeper-batter smashed his sixth half-century in the Indian Premier League.

Kishan hit 79 off 46 balls with eight fours and three sixes to power SRH to 255 for four, after which Royal Challengers Bengaluru responded with 200 for four to go down by 55 runs.

"Just happy about it, taking one match at a time, not making it complicated for myself, just keeping it simple like I spoke earlier before the tournament. It's just about watching the ball and playing your game," Kishan told the broadcaster after the match.

"More than maturity, it's about shot selection. You (should) know when to play which shot, (and) who to target. I'm just trying to take one ball at a time, know the situation, understand the pitch and just play your shots," he said.

Kishan continued, "I just take one match at a time, but I don't know why but I do feel confident when I'm playing against them and (at the) end of the day, fortune favours the brave and I just try to do my thing and it works in my way."

Kishan, who also brought up his 500 runs in this IPL on Friday, said keeping it simple was also crucial for SRH who have finished third in the



points table after their 14 matches in the group stage.

"Pat (Cummins) coming in, one of the best bowlers, it's very good to have him. Credit goes to everyone for keeping us in the zone. you just keep it simple, it's about enjoying in the middle. I need to give the credit to the support staff and Pat Cummins," he said.

SRH skipper Cummins expressed his delight in having a strong bowling attack after Eshan Malinga (2/33) and Sakib Hussain (1/31) stifled the RCB batters.

"The boys batted fantastically. Pretty good wicket, knew a lot of things had to go our way. We threw a few things at them, it's still a big win," he said.

"The way Eshan has bowled all through the tournament, Sakib there as well, captain's dream. We'll rest for a couple of days. We'll know who we're playing in a couple of days," RCB captain Rajat Patidar said the priority of his team, which finished on the first spot followed by Gujarat Titans on second, was to remain at the top of the points table.

## Rajasthan Royals look to seal last IPL playoffs spot

DEVARCHIT VARMA  
■ Mumbai

Rajasthan Royals would look to go full throttle in their bid to seal the last Indian Premier League playoffs spot when they take on a struggling Mumbai Indians here on Sunday. It will be a test of resilience and fitness for both the teams on a potentially hot and humid Sunday afternoon here, as Mumbai Indians would be determined to sign off with a consolation win, while Rajasthan Royals would be aware that a defeat would take their fate out of their hands.

The Royals — currently placed fourth with 14 points — need to win against

Mumbai Indians, which will take them to 16 points, at least one point clear of both Punjab Kings and Kolkata Knight Riders, who are still in the fray.

But if RR lose on Sunday, they will hope for both Punjab and Knight Riders to also suffer defeats in their final matches for the Jaipur-based side to have any chance of making the play-offs.

The Royals have lost more than they have won in their last five outings, but they will fancy their chances of a win against MI, knowing the conditions of the venue which has small dimensions. More than Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's fireworks at the top, it is Yashasvi Jaiswal who poses the biggest threat to the

Mumbai Indians. The India opener, also a local boy, went hammer and tongs against Jasprit Bumrah and Co. in Guwahati, scoring a 32-ball 77, which sealed the fate of the game in the first half itself.

Jaiswal returns to the venue where he had smacked his maiden IPL century three years ago, having scored his second ton the following year against the same opponent.

But RR will still need more consistency from their skipper Riyan Parag and Dhruv Jurel, who both occupy crucial spots in the batting order but have not necessarily provided the impetus in the middle overs. If Jurel has lacked the punch at times, Parag is searching



for consistency.

On current form, RR come across a more dangerous team which will have its tails

up knowing they have more players in form, primed to deliver at the time of need. If it is any consolation, MI's

record in the last five matches is similar to the Royals with three losses and two wins, but then the hosts will be determined to play for pride and the badge.

The contest will provide MI's struggling Indian stars Suryakumar Yadav, Hardik Pandya and Tilak Varma the chance to have one final crack with an impactful performance which would help their team sign off on a positive note.

For Bumrah in particular, the end of the campaign will also bring a much-needed break as the Indian pace attack spearhead would want to put his feet up after an exhausting six months of white ball cricket. (PTI)

## Punjab village academy leads way in keeping children on football fields, away from streets

HIMANK NEGI  
■ Rurka Kalan (Punjab)

At a Punjab village known as much for its fight against drugs as for its growing football culture, a grassroots academy has quietly emerged with focus on one simple idea — keeping children on football fields and away from the streets.

Youth Football Club (YFC) in Rurka Kalan, Jalandhar district, believes in developing players from the ground up, hoping to make a contribution, however small it may be, in the growth of Indian football which is currently grappling with myriad problems like uncertainty over domestic league structure, lack of commercial partners, salary delays, etc.

The academy, which recently bagged India's



runners-up finish at the Street Child World Cup 2026, currently trains nearly 250 children free of cost during the season while also taking care of hostel, food and dietary requirements for several youngsters.

The academy now oper-

ates 14-15 centers across Punjab, reaching to 4,000 to 6,000 children.

Former India defender Anwar Ali, who coached the side at the Street Child World Cup, believes Indian football's biggest problem continues to be the neglect of

grassroots development despite the financial rise brought by the Indian Super League (ISL).

"There is quantity but not quality because we don't work properly at the grassroots level," Anwar Ali told PTI Videos. "Countries like Uzbekistan used to play with us and now they have reached the World Cup. We only think about the top level reaching I-League, ISL and playing for India."

Anwar, who represented India during one of the country's brighter phases between 2008 and 2011, said Indian football had gradually drifted into a comfort zone despite improved professionalism and finances.

"Players are getting good money and we have come into a comfort zone. Nobody tries to go outside," said

Anwar who had rubbed shoulders with the likes of Bhaichung Bhutia and Sunil Chhetri in the national team during his playing days.

Anwar also weighed in on the ongoing debate surrounding OCI (Overseas Citizen of India) players after Ryan Williams became one of the few overseas-born players to represent India after acquiring Indian citizenship. "If we want OCI players to keep developing in other countries and then come here if things don't work out there, then where are we developing our own players?" Anwar said.

"Maybe it can help for the next two to five years with 10-15 players, but it is not a long-term solution."

The former India international also highlighted the lack of opportunities for

Indian forwards in domestic football while explaining the overdependence on Sunil Chhetri over the years.

"We are not getting number 9 or number 11 players because where are Indian number 9s playing in ISL or I-League? Nobody gets a proper chance," he said. "When Chhetri and we were playing, there were players like Sushil, Balwant, Robin Singh and JJ as number 9s. Where are such players now?" Anwar also candidly addressed the issue of age fraud, which according to him remains one of the major reasons why India's youth-level success often fails to translate at senior level. "I will answer this straight forward. I don't want to target any team or anyone. But the question is: is the under-15 or under-17 team actually under-15 or under-17? (PTI)

## We will keep an eye on under-tested middle-order: Vettori

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Hyderabad

Sunrisers Hyderabad head coach Daniel Vettori said the team will continue to monitor its under-tested middle-order ahead of the IPL playoffs even as he credited the side's explosive top-order and disciplined bowling attack for their impressive campaign this season.

SRH registered a massive 55-run win over Royal Challengers Bengaluru here on Friday to grab the third place in the points table and qualify for the play-offs.

"We played really well. You can't have everything. It was a magnificent game, I thought the guys were incredible. Season's not over yet. Top of



the table, missed out a little bit on run rate, but nine wins is a fantastic tournament," Vettori said during the post-match press conference. The former champions will next compete in the Eliminator on Wednesday. "We've got a middle order who probably

hasn't batted that much during the season, so that's something that we always keep an eye on in the build-up towards these big matches. But the team's been amazing," Vettori continued.

"That top four has been brilliant, and that triumvirate

of Ishan, Pat and Shakib in the later half of the season has probably been the real difference for us," Vettori said managing the fifth and sixth bowling options remained one of the team's biggest tactical challenges. "It's always about juggling our fifth and sixth bowler. That's a big one for us and we went with Harshal Patel tonight because of the nature of the surface, but we know we've got (Prafull) Hinge and Harsh Dubey."

He praised the bowling attack for complementing the explosive batting unit after SRH recovered from a poor start to the season.

"Those three fast bowlers have been exceptional and we've had contributions from Harsh Dubey, from Shivang,

from Nitesh, from Hinge that have allowed us to come back from losing three of our first four games," he said.

"To win eight out of the next 12 is a real credit to them. I think we anticipated our batting unit doing what they did and then for the bowlers to complement them was the reason we're in the position we are now."

Despite the loss, RCB head coach Andy Flower expressed satisfaction over his side finishing at the top of the points table, while admitting that a barrage of slower deliveries from Sunrisers Hyderabad and sloppy fielding proved costly. SRH posted a daunting 255 for 4 after opting to bat first before restricting RCB to 200 for 4 in 20 overs.

## Vinesh Phogat to participate in Asian Games selection trials: Delhi HC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has given its nod to the participation of celebrated grappler Vinesh Phogat in the upcoming trials for the Asian Games, saying the Wrestling Federation of India's (WFI) selection policy is exclusionary for the lack of discretion to consider an iconic player like her, who is returning from a maternity break.

A bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia ordered that the selection trials, to be held on May 30-31, shall be video-record-



ed by the WFI and an independent observer from the Sports Authority of India (SAI) and the Indian Olympic

Association (IOA) each shall also remain present.

"The appellant shall be permitted to participate in the selection trials for the Asian Games, 2026, which are scheduled for 30.05.2026 and 31.05.2026," the court said in its order passed on May 22 and uploaded on its website on Saturday.

"The policy and the circular are clearly exclusionary in nature as it does not give any discretion to Respondent number 1 (WFI) to consider iconic players like the appellant in view of the sabbatical taken on account of her maternity leave," it stated.

## KKR, DC look for nothing less than a win amid fading playoff hopes

TAPAN MOHANTA  
■ Kolkata

Kolkata Knight Riders and Delhi Capitals would look for nothing less than a win when they square off in the season's final league match of the IPL here on Sunday.

As things stand, sixth-placed KKR and eighth-placed DC are still mathematically alive in the race for the last available berth in the playoffs, but Sunday's contest could well turn out to be a dead rubber by the time it begins.

Punjab Kings, currently ahead in the race for the last playoff berth, take on already-eliminated Lucknow



Super Giants on Saturday. A PBKS win would take them to 15 points and officially end Delhi's hopes as they can only reach up to a maximum of 14 points.

KKR, who are on 13 points, can still get to 15 with a win

over DC, but Punjab hold a significant net run-rate advantage. For perspective, even if PBKS beat LSG by just one run, KKR would need to defeat DC by at least 52 runs to overhaul them on NRR. (PTI)

## Kohli enjoys aggressive intensity on field: Pathan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Former India all-rounder Irfan Pathan downplayed the heated on-field exchange between Virat Kohli and Travis Head during Royal Challengers Bengaluru's IPL clash against Sunrisers Hyderabad, saying such confrontations are a natural by-product of the intensity and competitiveness of top-level cricket.

Kohli and Head were involved in an on-field exchange with the former appearing to mock the Australian batter's frequent use by his team as an Impact Substitute by gesturing and telling him to bowl a few deliveries instead of staying



off the field.

Kohli, however, was dismissed soon after for 15 off 11 balls, prompting Head to fire back with a sledge of his own. The tension appeared to linger after SRH's commanding 55-run win as Head tried to shake hands during the



customary post-match greetings, but Kohli walked past him without acknowledging the gesture.

"Virat Kohli has always enjoyed playing cricket with that aggressive Australian-style intensity, a bit of banter, competitiveness, and

emotion on the field," JioStar expert Pathan said.

"During that moment, he was asking Travis Head to come on and bowl a few deliveries instead of remaining off the field as an impact substitute. These kinds of exchanges are quite natural in high-pressure games, especially when both teams are competing for crucial positions on the points table.

"In the end, it was simply part of the intensity and competitive spirit that comes with top-level cricket."

**Sehwag backs Venkatesh to open for RCB, wants Salt in for Jitesh:** Venkatesh Iyer has given Royal Challengers Bengaluru a welcome selection dilemma ahead of the playoffs, said former India

batter Virender Sehwag, who wants the left-hander to continue opening while suggesting that a fit-again Phil Salt should replace the out-of-form Jitesh Sharma in the playing XI.

Iyer struck 73 and 44 in the last two games while batting at number four and opening the innings respectively after spending most of the ongoing season on the sidelines. "Venkatesh Iyer is at his best when batting in the top order. He played his best knocks for KKR in that position. For RCB, he hasn't had many chances at his preferred spot," JioStar expert Sehwag, an explosive opener in his playing days, said on Star Sports' 'Amul Cricket Live'.



# The Doors of Naughara

Walk into Naughara gali and the roaring city disappears behind fading mansions, carved teak doors and the living memory of Old Delhi's forgotten

SAKSHI PRIYA

Cities usually devour their own history, burying old stones under new ambitions. Yet, if you navigate the blinding glitter of Kinari Bazaar and take a sudden turn, the deafening noise drops away entirely. You step into Naughara, a pedestrian corridor flanked by faded pastel facades that feels entirely detached from our current era.

You feel the age of this lane immediately in the timber and stone. True to its nameNine Houses this unbroken row of mansions relies heavily on solid Burma teak. Just look at the doorways. Those massive slabs of wood are covered in floral carvings and thick brass studs that have been worn completely smooth by generations of hands. Back in the 1700s, the merchants who built these *havelis* added high stone steps at the door for a pretty basic reason: just to keep the street dirt from blowing inside. Now, those same steps force you to slow down before you walk inside. The families who originally paid for these homes knew exactly who was carving their doors, and they wanted work that would last. Touch the wood grain today, and you can feel just how well those carpenters did their job.

If a door happens to be open, look into the inner courtyards. The front walls are covered in mirror work and cut glass that flashes in the afternoon sun. Craftsmen had to work incred-



ibly fast to set those glass pieces perfectly before the plaster dried. It was a way to show off money, sure, but it also proved they built things to stick around, not just for convenience. "People wander in and treat this alley

like a film set, but we still live inside these walls," an older resident said, leaning against his veranda. His family has been in one of the nine houses for decades. "We polish the brass and sweep the stone thresholds every morning. The market outside changes daily. Our doors stay exactly the same."

There is a sharp irony playing out across the wider city today. Out in the sprawling new suburbs, wealthy homeowners are spending fortunes commissioning replica arches and artificially aged wooden doors. They are trying desperately to manufacture a heritage their modern constructions lack. They buy the aesthetic, but cannot copy the authentic history. Back in Naughara, the weekends bring a steady stream of young photographers. They frame the ornate brackets and peeling stucco, capturing a tangible connection to an era they never knew. Naughara has survived the relentless drive of the neighbourhood to turn every square yard into a commercial storefront, standing as a quiet act of defiance.

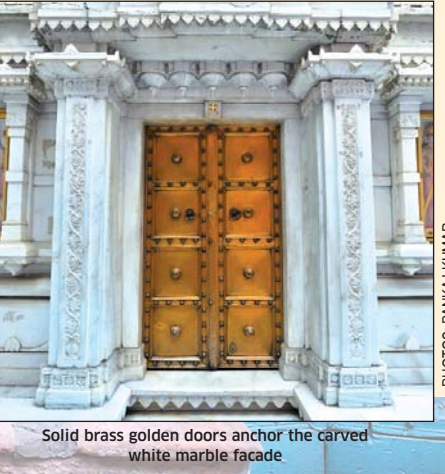
Why are we so desperate to document the fading shadows of our past while building a completely generic future? We wander down these narrow lanes to remember the city before it became a spread of glass and steel, wondering if anything built today will leave behind such a lasting and unyielding footprint.

## ELEMENTS OF NAUGHARA ART

- Massive Burma teak doors feature heavy brass studs and carvings.
- Intricate glass pieces pressed rapidly into wet plaster courtyard walls.
- Scalloped stone archways blend Persian, Mughal, and Rajasthani building styles.
- Painted sacred lotuses, ceremonial elephants, and vines decorate hidden corners.
- Fading murals recall gifted masters with zero stage left today.

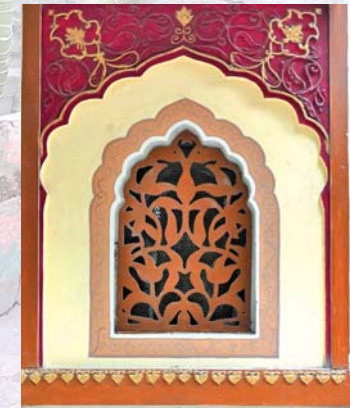
## THE MARBLE HEART

Walk the narrow path until you can go no further. Naughara opens into a striking two storey white marble courtyard. This is the Svetambara Jain Temple. Stepping inside provides a sudden drop in volume, cutting off the walled city's heavy claustrophobia. Thousands of glass pieces coat the interior walls. Master artisans raced against the clock to press every single shard into wet plaster before the mixture hardened. When afternoon light hits those walls, the space scatters a brilliant web of reflections. Compare that to expensive gated communities springing up today. Homeowners write massive cheques, trying to bolt a sense of legacy onto brand new houses. But true heritage cannot be ordered from a showroom.



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

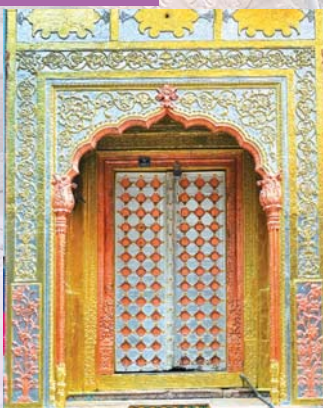
## ANCIENT DETAIL



A heavy, weathered timber design anchors the peeling stone archway



Vibrant green and pink floral vases decorate framed wooden panels



Gilded silver and gold panels frame an intricate scalloped doorway



Heavy, weathered wooden doors sit inside a peeling stone archway



Solid brass golden doors anchor the carved white marble facade

## ART CORNER

### Inside Shanaka Kulathunga's Silent Stories

The canvases that followed every single viewer straight back home

SAKSHI PRIYA

To stand before a Shanaka Kulathunga canvas is to confront an absolute reckoning. A specific, raw fear and deeply rooted pain drips from the earthy ochres and heavy slashes of pigment. These paintings capture the precise geometry of the hole left behind when someone turns away. Looking at *The Harmonizer*, the anchor piece of the Sri Lankan figurative painter's first Indian solo exhibition titled *Silent Stories*, you realise immediately you are being asked to bear witness to lives society systematically ignores.

Brought to New Delhi by Vikram Mayor, Director of Gallery Silver Scapes, and housed within the CCA Gallery at Bikaner House, this expansive collection functions as an urgent documentary of the unseen. Kulathunga abandons the safety of traditional portraiture. He digs his brush into labourers, the elderly, the forgotten, and drags their quiet endurance into harsh gallery



Throne of the Wild plunges you into a dense landscape where raw nature silently reigns

light. Spending time with *Throne of the Wild* reveals a human figure anchored so heavily into the landscape they feel almost captive. The surrounding erratic brushwork mirrors a mind actively wrestling with the trauma of memory and the brutal realities of rural displacement. The natural world in Kulathunga's

vision never serves as a passive backdrop. Creeping vines and oppressive shadows aggressively encroach on his subjects, illustrating how completely our environments can consume us. This same tension fractures the surface in *Son of the Wind* (Vayuputhra), where lofty cultural mythology slams directly into the gritty struggle of daily survival.

For the artist, bringing this intensely personal work across the border was an exercise in trusting that the specific moments that bruised his life might resonate on foreign soil. He holds a quiet faith that the unspoken weight of memory goes beyond geographic lines. That conviction was validated as New Delhi audiences found their own painful histories staring back at them. Kulathunga's subjects refuse to remain confined to their wooden frames.

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

## splash of Summers

TEAM VIVA

Open your wardrobe honestly and tell us what you find. The same rotation you have been pulling from since last spring, safe colours that photograph fine and offend nobody. Summer 2026 is not interesting. When the heat strips away our thick coats and heavy sweaters, we lose our usual styling armor. We are left with very little fabric and a desperate need for expression. That is exactly why the shades we wear during



Turquoise and lime green

the hottest months matter so deeply. Pure pigment becomes our only language. This year the streets are vibrating with a loud palette that pulls us out of safe neutrals and forces a visual awakening. People crave the thrill of feeling entirely alive.

Cobalt blue anchors the season as a rich shade commanding every room. The absolute obsession right now involves forcing at piercing blue directly against a scorching burnt orange. Wearing cobalt blue and burnt orange together creates an electric tension. It looks incredibly sharp under a heavy July sun. Burnt orange alone is the colour of afternoon light hitting old stone, warm and deeply generous on every skin tone summer has to offer.

Then we enter the acidic end of the spectrum. Tart lime green dominates lightweight tailoring and sweeping silk dresses. The styling secret of the year relies on pairing that loud lime green directly with butter yellow, an all time favorite that always grounds a chaotic outfit with pure elegance. Against lime green it finds a new energy entirely, the sharpness of one colour cutting beautifully against the honey of the other.



Butter yellow

Throwing a sudden punch of citrus yellow into the mix perfectly mimics a soaring heatwave. Turquoise is back and it never should have left. Everyone is asking what works with it. Burnt orange clicks right into place beside it. Cobalt deepens the whole thing beautifully. Even citrus yellow nearby and suddenly your summer has a vibration.

These brilliant shades practically beg you to abandon cautious wardrobe choices. You will soon catch yourself throwing these vivid tones over a simple tank top to feel the breeze.



Burnt orange

## PAINT THEM BRIGHT

Your clothes are not the only thing getting a bold update this season. Trade your predictable manicures for something that actually matches the heat. Whether you want a quiet wash of creamy colour or a loud tropical pattern, these styles capture the exact feeling of a hot may afternoon.



TROPICAL PLAY



BABY BLUE



OCEAN VIBES



SUNSET OMBRE

PHOTOS FOR REPRESENTATIVE PURPOSES ONLY

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# The Pioneer AGENDA

In geopolitics,  
a nation has no  
permanent allies or  
permanent enemies, only  
permanent interests.  
— George Friedman



## ONWARD NORTH INDIA'S NORDIC PUSH

At a time when global geopolitics is being reshaped by climate crises, technological competition and shifting economic alliances, India's growing engagement with the Nordic countries marks a significant strategic evolution in its foreign policy. The 3rd India-Nordic Summit in Oslo underlined this transformation, signalling that nations once considered peripheral to India's diplomatic priorities are now central to its global ambitions

### Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Nordic outreach and new European strategy



Prime Minister Narendra Modi's May 2026 swing through Sweden and Norway, capped by the third India-Nordic Summit in Oslo, was not a routine European stopover. It marked a clear political decision to move the Nordic region from the margins of Indian diplomacy to a more central place in New Delhi's strategic thinking. In the span of a few months, India elevated relations with Finland to a Strategic Partnership in Digitalization and Sustainability during President Alexander Stubb's state visit in March 2026, with Sweden to a broader Strategic Partnership in Gothenburg in May 2026, and with Norway to a Green Strategic Partnership in Oslo a day later. Alongside this, Prime Minister Modi also held bilateral meetings with the leaders of Denmark, Finland and Iceland on the sidelines of the India-Nordic Summit. The message was unmistakable: India now sees the Nordic arc not as a peripheral cluster of small economies, but as a set of high-value partners in technology, climate action, maritime affairs and strategic diversification.

That outreach did not begin overnight. In April 2025, Prime Minister Modi and Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen reviewed the expanding India-Denmark Green Strategic Partnership over a phone call. In February 2026, Prime Minister Modi met Finnish Prime Minister Petteri Orpo in New Delhi on the margins of the AI Impact Summit, and both sides pushed cooperation in quantum, 6G, renewables and defence. By May 2026, the diplomacy had become institutional: the India-Nordic relationship itself was elevated to a Green Technology and Innovation Strategic Partnership, with Finland set to host the next summit. This is what gives Prime Minister Modi's recent Nordic outreach its significance: it is no longer episodic; it is now structured, sequenced and tied to concrete sectoral roadmaps.

#### Why the Nordics matter now

The immediate reason is simple enough. The Nordics may be modest in population, but they punch well above their weight in capital, innovation, standards and institutional credibility. The combined Nordic economy is now

worth more than USD 2 trillion; trade with the Nordic countries touched about USD 19 billion in 2024; more than 700 Nordic companies operate in India; and around 150 Indian companies have a presence in the region. That is already a serious economic footprint.

But the deeper attraction lies in quality, not just volume. WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2025 ranked Sweden second, Finland seventh, Denmark ninth and Norway twentieth, with Norway also leading the world on the infrastructure pillar. The European Commission's European Innovation Scoreboard 2025 placed Sweden back as the EU's most innovative member state, ahead of Denmark.

For India, which is trying to marry manufacturing scale with cleaner growth and better technology, that mix is rare and valuable. In a world shaped by supply-chain anxieties, tighter technology controls and the search for trusted partners, the Nordics offer exactly the kind of competence India needs: high-end engineering, green industrial know-how, digital capability and policy stability.

The timing also matters. The India-EU Free Trade Agreement was declared concluded at the January 2026 India-EU Summit, while the India-EFTA Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement entered into force on 1 October 2025. The Oslo summit explicitly linked India-Nordic ties to both these trade frameworks and underscored that TEPA carries a shared objective of USD 100 billion in investment and one million direct jobs in India over 15 years. In other words, the Nordic region is becoming one of the most practical bridges between India's growth story and Europe's capital, markets and advanced supply chains.

#### Green growth and advanced technology

This is where the relationship gets particularly consequential. Sweden has emerged as India's most rounded Nordic technology partner. The new India-Sweden Strategic Partnership commits both sides to a shared goal of doubling bilateral economic exchange within five years and sets out cooperation in AI, 6G, quantum computing, critical minerals, sustainable mining, space and defence innovation. It also launches a Sweden-India Technology and Artificial Intelligence Corridor, upgrades the Joint Innovation Partnership, and creates a new joint science and technology centre. For India, Sweden is useful not only because it brings ideas, but because it brings industrial depth: telecom, advanced manufacturing, clean industry and defence production. India-Sweden trade in goods rose to USD 7.75 billion in 2025, and Swedish companies have already established a significant production presence in India, including Saab's Carl-Gustaf facility in Haryana.

Denmark remains India's most mature green partner in the region. Since the launch of



the Green Strategic Partnership in 2020, the relationship has steadily moved from symbolism to implementable projects. Prime Minister Modi and Frederiksen reviewed that progress again in Oslo in May 2026, with an emphasis on climate, new technologies, AI, defence, start-ups and academic exchanges. The two sides also highlighted the Smart Laboratory on Clean Rivers in Varanasi as a practical model of technology-led environmental cooperation. On the Danish side, the newly created Green Transition Alliance India, formed in 2025, builds on earlier initiatives like the Wind Alliance India and the Green Fuels Alliance India to position Danish firms in India's energy transition. This is precisely the sort of partnership India needs if it wants to move from climate ambition to industrial decarbonization.

#### The country strengths India can tap

Norway brings a different set of advantages. Prime Minister Modi's May 2026 visit to Oslo was the first prime ministerial visit from India to Norway in 43 years, and the outcomes were substantial: a Green Strategic Partnership, Norway's entry into the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative, agreements in space, health and digital development, and a sharper focus on green shipping, ports, ocean energy, carbon capture, circular economy and polar research. India and Norway also agreed to work together in third countries on Digital Public Infrastructure for the Sustainable Development Goals. Add to that the fact that Norway's Government Pension Fund Global had invested close to USD 28 billion in Indian capital markets by December 2025, and Norway starts to look less like a niche partner and more

THE REAL VALUE OF THE NORDIC RELATIONSHIP IS THAT IT BROADENS INDIA'S ROOM FOR MANOEUVRE. THESE COUNTRIES STRENGTHEN INDIA'S GLOBAL OUTREACH NOT BY REPLACING LARGER POWERS, BUT BY GIVING INDIA ADDITIONAL CHANNELS INTO EUROPEAN MARKETS

like a serious source of capital, maritime knowledge and global development leverage.

Finland, meanwhile, is becoming India's go-to Nordic partner on frontier digitalisation. The March 2026 strategic partnership with Helsinki prioritised 5G, 6G, AI, high-performance computing, quantum technologies, semiconductors, sustainability and start-up collaboration. The two sides agreed to create a Joint

Working Group on Digitalization, a Joint Task Force on 6G with the University of Oulu and the Bharat 6G Alliance, and to co-host the World Circular Economy Forum in India in 2026. Iceland's role is smaller but still distinctive: Prime Minister Modi's Oslo meeting with Prime Minister Kristrún Frostadóttir focused on geothermal energy, fisheries, innovative technologies, culture and Arctic research, while the India-Iceland brief continues to identify renewable energy, biotech, fisheries and Arctic issues as core areas of cooperation. India would be wise to see these countries as complementary pieces of the same puzzle, not as separate files.

#### The security, Arctic and geopolitical dividend

There is also a harder strategic edge to this relationship, and it should not be understated. The entire Nordic region now sits within NATO: Finland joined in April 2023 and Sweden in March 2024, adding fresh weight to a region that already mattered to European and transatlantic security. India is not entering alliance politics, nor should it. But it is engaging a set of partners whose importance in maritime security, cyber

resilience, supply-chain security and defence industry has risen sharply after the Ukraine war. The Oslo summit reflected that shift: India and the Nordics agreed to deepen cooperation on maritime security, illegal maritime activity, sea-farer safety, blue economy, defence industrial collaboration and the supply of essential defence components. Sweden's bilateral action plan separately calls for stronger cyber dialogue, defence innovation and more Swedish investment in India's defence corridors.

The Arctic adds another layer. India has maintained the Himadri research station in Svalbard, Norway, since 2008, has held observer status in the Arctic Council since 2013, and framed its Arctic policy in 2022 around science, climate, maritime cooperation, connectivity and governance. Nordic leaders in Oslo explicitly welcomed India's continued engagement in Arctic Council working groups and supported deeper cooperation on polar research, climate and environmental issues. This is not a vanity project. Indian officials have repeatedly linked changes in the Arctic to monsoon behaviour and wider climate consequences for India. In strategic terms, then, the Nordics help India in three theatres at once: Europe, the Arctic and the Indo-Pacific. Few other partner-sets offer that kind of overlap.

#### A partnership that widens India's strategic options

The real value of the Nordic relationship is that it broadens India's room for manoeuvre. These countries strengthen India's global outreach not by replacing larger powers, but by giving India additional channels into European markets, Arctic governance, clean technology coalitions and standards-setting conversations. They have also backed India's claim for permanent membership of a reformed UN Security Council, supported its NSG application, and shown a growing willingness to work with India on third-country development and multilateral problem-solving. Taken together, this suggests that the Nordic region is becoming one of the quiet force multipliers of Indian foreign policy: low on drama, high on strategic value.

That is why Prime Minister Modi's recent outreach matters. The Nordics are not important because they are large; they are important because they sit at the crossroads of tomorrow's strategic economy - green industry, clean shipping, advanced digital systems, trusted supply chains, polar research and resilient institutions. India brings the scale, the market, the talent and the development imperative. The Nordics bring technology, capital, climate competence and strategic trust.

As New Delhi converts that complementarity into faster execution, the northern flank of Europe can well become one of the most productive extensions of India's foreign policy in the second half of this decade.

### India's Nordic Turn: PM Modi at Oslo Summit and the need for Green Strategic Partnership



In the fast-changing global political landscape, India's strategic outreach to Nordic countries signifies the complementarity in India - Europe relations and, more specifically, to the Nordic countries, as was witnessed in the 3rd India-Nordic Summit. The summit

marked a new milestone in India's foreign policy. It signals an obvious and strategically calibrated turn by India towards a region long regarded as peripheral to its foreign policy calculus, and Nordic countries' foreign policy calculus is seen now as increasingly core to its ambitions as an emerging global player.

Why does this region matter now? The Nordic countries, comprising Norway, Sweden, Denmark, Finland and Iceland with a population of 27 million, are pioneers in many new and unique areas and carry considerable weight. As global leaders in clean energy, digital governance, maritime economy, Arctic research and sustainable innovation, they are a force to reckon with in terms of non-traditional security. In a world that is still trying to come to terms with climate disruption,



tion, technological localisation and precarious supply chains, Nordic prowess holds a premium.

India's outreach with the countries in the region has been increasing in the past 15 years but with the new tem-

plate of India- Nordic Summits, they have over further found a deep foundational relationship which might be

expanded with each other depending on the requirements.

PM underlined the fact that trade between India and the region has increased four times and the region's investments in India have doubled over the last decade. Two landmark trade agreements - India's Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA) with European Free Trade Agreement countries (comprising of four Non EU members Liechtenstein, Switzerland, including Norway and Iceland which are part of Nordic Summit), and the India-EU Free Trade Agreement involving Denmark, Finland and Sweden - are set to usher in what PM Modi called a "new golden era" in these relations. EFTA signed a historic Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA) with India.

# I will return to Bangladesh: Sheikh Hasina

In an exclusive and wide-ranging interview with *The Pioneer*, exiled former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina delivers a firm and unambiguous message about her political future and the direction of Bangladesh's ongoing crisis. Addressing questions on her possible return, the state of democracy, the future of the Awami League, and the country's mounting economic and political challenges, she asserts that her connection with Bangladesh remains unbroken despite her absence.



ASHOKE RAJ

Responding to speculation over timelines, Hasina emphasises that her return is not a matter of personal scheduling but of restoring democratic order, constitutional rights, and political stability in the country. Recalling her long political journey, exile, and survival through repeated violence, she reiterates her commitment to what she describes as the unfinished mission of Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman.

From the future of opposition politics to concerns over governance, health systems, foreign policy shifts, and allegations of repression, the interview presents Hasina's perspective on a deeply polarised Bangladesh—while underscoring her central claim: that she remains politically active, globally engaged, and determined to return when conditions allow.

**May 17 marks your Homecoming Day. Even if not in 2026, how possible is your return to Bangladesh by 2027?**

**Sheikh Hasina:** May 17 remains one of the most emotional days of my life. In 1981, after six years in exile and after losing most of my family in the 1975 assassination, I returned to Bangladesh with the support and affection of the people. Despite threats, political cases, and repeated conspiracies, I believed I had a duty to continue the unfinished work of Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman.

As for returning by 2027, I do not see it as a matter tied to a specific timeline. The larger issue is the restoration of democracy, political rights, freedom of expression, and the rule of law in Bangladesh. Those conditions are essential not only for my return, but for the future of the country itself.

Even while outside Bangladesh, I remain politically engaged. We are working through diplomatic channels, legal forums, and international advocacy to present what we believe was the unconstitutional removal of a democratically elected government. International awareness of the situation is gradually increasing.

I have survived numerous assassination attempts during my political career, including the grenade attack of August 21, 2004. I believe my responsibility to the people of Bangladesh is not over, and I remain committed to returning and continuing that struggle.

**Your supporters continue to express concern for your health. But if the Awami League faces restrictions. Can you still return to Bangladesh?**

**Sheikh Hasina:** The Awami League is not a party created by military power or administrative authority. It is a party built through mass movements and the support of ordinary people. Throughout history, the party has faced bans and repression, including during the Ayub Khan era



and under the Pakistani regime in 1971. Yet it survived because of its connection with the people.

No political party rooted in popular support can be permanently eliminated through administrative measures alone. The Awami League continues to have millions of supporters and activists across Bangladesh despite arrests, intimidation, and political pressure.

Political bans often reflect fear rather than strength. Those in power understand that a politically organised Awami League remains a major force in Bangladesh's politics. History suggests that suppression alone cannot erase that reality.

**There is growing concern about reform and restructuring within the Awami League. Are these concerns worthwhile?**

**Sheikh Hasina:** Every major democratic party undergoes periods of reflection and reform. The Awami League is no exception. As the country's largest political organisation, allegations or criticisms involving individuals can emerge, and those issues must be addressed responsibly.

However, attempts to weaken political opponents under the banner of “reform” are also common in politics. The Awami League has its

own internal democratic mechanisms and organisational structure capable of addressing its challenges.

Difficult periods also reveal who remains committed to the party's ideals. Many activists continue to stand by the Awami League despite political pressure and personal risk. I believe these experiences will ultimately strengthen the party's organisational discipline and ideological clarity.

**Will Awami League leaders who left the country eventually return?**

**Sheikh Hasina:** I would not describe them as leaders who “left voluntarily.” Many left because they feared for their safety amid the political situation following August 2024.

A large number of leaders and activists have faced arrests, legal cases, harassment, and attacks on their homes or businesses. Under such circumstances, some sought temporary refuge abroad while continuing political and advocacy work internationally.

At the same time, many leaders and activists remain inside Bangladesh despite immense pressure. Their resilience and commitment should

be recognised. I believe that once democratic conditions and the rule of law are restored, many who left will return to continue political activities openly.

**Bangladesh is facing significant economic challenges. Many citizens still benefit from infrastructure projects completed during your administration. How would you have handled the current crisis?**

**Sheikh Hasina:** Economic development and public welfare have always been central to the Awami League's political philosophy. During our years in office, Bangladesh experienced significant economic growth alongside major infrastructure development, including the Padma Bridge, Metro Rail, Rooppur Nuclear Power Plant, and Matarbari Deep Sea Port.

The country's economic indicators improved substantially during that period. Per capita income rose, electricity access expanded nationwide, and Bangladesh gained recognition internationally as one of South Asia's fastest-growing economies.

Every government faces economic challenges. During our tenure, we dealt with both the COVID-19 pandemic and the global economic impact of the Russia-Ukraine conflict. We focused on maintaining economic stability while protecting vulnerable citizens.

I believe the current crisis is closely linked to political instability, weakened institutional confidence, and uncertainty in governance. Sustainable recovery requires long-term planning, investor confidence, and political stability.

**There are concerns over outbreaks of preventable diseases, including measles. Do you believe that the current administration has failed to manage the healthcare systems?**

**Sheikh Hasina:** The death of children from preventable diseases is deeply painful. During our administration, healthcare expansion and immunisation programs were national priorities. Through community clinics and vaccination campaigns carried out in cooperation with international partners, Bangladesh made major progress in reducing child mortality and controlling infectious diseases.

Our immunisation programs were internationally recognised, and we invested heavily in public health infrastructure, including ICU facilities established during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Public health systems require continuity and effective administration. Any disruption in vaccination programs or shortages in medical supplies can quickly create serious public health consequences.

Healthcare should never become politicised. Protecting children and ensuring public health must remain above political conflict.

**What steps is the Awami League taking regarding imprisoned leaders, journalists, and intellectuals?**

**Sheikh Hasina:** We are pursuing both legal and diplomatic efforts.

Our representatives remain in communication with international organisations, human rights groups, and democratic institutions to raise concerns about arrests, due process, and political freedoms in Bangladesh.

The independence of the judiciary and equal protection under the law are fundamental to democracy. We believe everyone, regardless of political affiliation, deserves fair legal treatment.

This issue goes beyond party politics. The condition of democratic institutions affects the future stability and credibility of the state itself.



**“AS FOR RETURNING BY 2027, I DO NOT SEE IT AS A MATTER TIED TO A SPECIFIC TIMELINE. THE LARGER ISSUE IS THE RESTORATION OF DEMOCRACY, POLITICAL RIGHTS, FREEDOM OF EXPRESSION, AND THE RULE OF LAW IN BANGLADESH. THOSE CONDITIONS ARE ESSENTIAL NOT ONLY FOR MY RETURN, BUT FOR THE FUTURE OF THE COUNTRY ITSELF”**

**The current government is strengthening ties with China and Pakistan while anti-India rhetoric has grown considerably. How do you view these developments? Are you also concerned about rising extremism?**

**Sheikh Hasina:** Bangladesh's foreign policy has traditionally been guided by Bangabandhu's principle: “Friendship to all, malice toward none.” During our tenure, we sought balanced relations with regional and global partners while safeguarding Bangladesh's national interests.

India shares deep historical ties with Bangladesh because of its role during the Liberation War. At the same time, Bangladesh must maintain constructive and sovereign relations with all countries.

On extremism, our government maintained a zero-tolerance policy. Bangladesh once faced serious militant threats, but through coordinated counterterrorism efforts and institutional reforms, extremist activity was significantly reduced.

Any weakening of those efforts or political tolerance toward extremist groups would pose risks not only to Bangladesh but also to regional security.

**What support are you seeking from the international community to help build an inclusive society in Bangladesh?**

**Sheikh Hasina:** Bangladesh is passing through a difficult political and institutional period. Democratic rights, economic stability, social harmony, and the rule of law must be protected for all citizens.

I urge democratic nations and international organisations to closely observe developments in Bangladesh and support democratic values, human rights, and constitutional governance.

An inclusive Bangladesh must protect political pluralism, minority rights, women's rights, and freedom of expression. These are essential foundations of a democratic society.

My message to the people of Bangladesh is not to lose hope. Democracy has faced challenges before, and the resilience of the Bangladeshi people remains the country's greatest strength.

The writer is an Associate Editor (Foreign Affairs) at *The Pioneer*.



“EVERY GOVERNMENT FACES ECONOMIC CHALLENGES. DURING OUR TENURE, WE DEALT WITH BOTH THE COVID-19 PANDEMIC AND THE GLOBAL ECONOMIC IMPACT OF THE RUSSIA-UKRAINE CONFLICT. WE FOCUSED ON MAINTAINING ECONOMIC STABILITY WHILE PROTECTING VULNERABLE CITIZENS”



## FROM AGENDA COVER

### India's Nordic Turn: PM Modi at Oslo Summit...

This pact, signed earlier and which came into effect on 1st October 2025, commits EFTA to \$100 billion in investments and the creation of 1 million direct jobs in India over 15 years, securing tariff concessions and market access across various sectors. For India, this convergence of trade architecture and strategic partnership offers a uniquely comprehensive template for engagement with these economically advanced countries.

#### On the Greener Side: Climate, Sustainability and Environment

The partners in the summit have a shared conviction on the future of clean technologies. India has already set up massive renewable energy targets and have one of the world's best in class solar installation programmes backed by its objective expressed in the International Solar Alliance (ISA). India, with its massive renewable energy targets and one of the world's largest solar and wind installation programmes, brings unmatched scale only to be matched by Nordic

countries' precision and scientific advancement. The Nordic countries bring technological sophistication with Iceland's mastery of geothermal energy, Denmark's leadership in offshore wind and health technology, and Norway's blue economy innovations, which offer India access to some of the world's most advanced green technologies and above all, these countries offer a veritable social security mechanism for their citizens, which is perhaps unmatched in the world.

The new partnership in the region also have opening in green hydrogen, carbon capture technologies and critical minerals at the base of their cooperation. Cooperation in green hydrogen, carbon capture technologies and critical minerals forms the backbone of the new partnership's environmental agenda. India being a major greenhouse gas emitter and one of the countries most vulnerable to climate change, these partnerships are strategically important. With the Nordic know-how, India's clean energy transition will help build domestic capacity in cutting-edge technologies - not merely as a recipient of technology transfer, but as a co-developer of global climate solutions. As the Indian PM remarked in

Oslo, the partnership seeks to “combine Nordic expertise in sustainability with India's scale to develop trusted global solutions for the future”.

#### Technology, Defence and Digital partnership

The partnership opens new doors in next-generation technology and military cooperation. Sweden's sophistication in advanced manufacturing and defence is especially significant for India, which is actively diversifying its defence supply chains from traditional dependence on a handful of suppliers and is looking for deepening engagement with Western technological and military hardware platforms. Finland's leadership in telecommunications and digital technologies aligns seamlessly with India's ambitions in 5G, advanced cybersecurity and digital public infrastructure. Denmark's capabilities in cybersecurity and health technology complements strengths at a time when data localisation, digital sovereignty and healthcare innovation are national priorities.

The summit also underlined the cooperation in artificial intelligence - a domain where both India and the Nordic countries recognise the

imperative of like-minded democratic nations setting standards and governance frameworks with priority on innovation and less economic control by major business groups, as is being witnessed of late. In terms of the talent that India has in STEM can make it happen with Nordic R & D investment for joint innovation and fair dissemination of AI technologies besides building a people-to-people infrastructure that will outlast any single government.

#### Maritime Security and Arctic Policy

Perhaps the most strategically underappreciated dimension of India-Nordic engagement is the maritime and Arctic frontier. Arctic, termed ‘New Africa’, has a lot to be explored in terms of natural resources and the new transit route. Russia has already allowed India, besides China, to look into the possibility of the Northern Sea Route, which can complement India and Nordic countries in exploring this transit route. Norway has deep expertise in the blue economy, maritime surveillance and Arctic affairs, which opens a conversation that is highly relevant for India's evolving Indo-Pacific strategy and its interest in emerging Arctic shipping lanes. As global warming

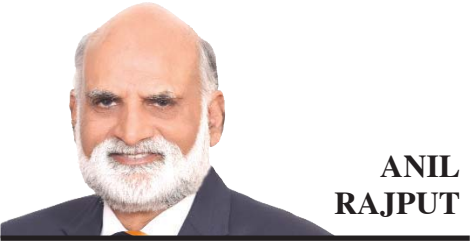
opens new Arctic trade routes - potentially transforming global logistics - India, as a major maritime nation and aspiring Arctic observer with growing stakes in polar research, holding an observer status in the Arctic council, has strong reasons to engage more deeply with Norway and Iceland.

The Nordic countries, though small in population, carry enormous credibility in multilateral institutions, climate diplomacy, and global norm-setting. Their support amplifies India's voice in forums ranging from the UN to the WTO and the emerging architecture of AI and digital governance. As the 3rd India-Nordic Summit concluded in Oslo, both sides expressed confidence that their partnership would serve as “a model of shared prosperity, innovation, and sustainable development.” In a world increasingly defined by the competition between open and closed systems, democratic and authoritarian models, India's deepening Nordic engagement is both a pragmatic and a principled choice.

Dr Amitabh Singh, teaches at the School of International Studies, JNU New Delhi and is a policy analyst specialising in India's Foreign Policy, international relations and geopolitics

“WE ALL LIVE WITH THE OBJECTIVE OF  
BEING HAPPY; OUR LIVES ARE ALL  
DIFFERENT AND YET THE SAME”  
— ANNE FRANK

# Ganga Dussehra: Where sacred waters meet seasonal cuisine



ANIL  
RAJPUT

Ganga Dussehra, also known as Gangavataran, celebrates the descent of the sacred River Ganges from heaven to earth. Normally commemorated over ten days commencing from Dashami (10th day) of the waxing moon in the Hindu month of Jyeshtha, the main rituals are being held on May 25 when the summer sun is at its most intense and the human body instinctively seeks coolness and renewal. The primary ritual is bathing in the Ganges at sunrise in the belief that lifetimes of sins are washed away, as Maa Ganga is revered not merely as a river, but as a purifier, nourisher and civilisational force. Her waters have shaped settlements, pilgrim routes, agricultural lands, rituals, songs, stories and collective memory across generations. To speak of Ganga Dussehra, therefore, is not merely to speak of a sacred observance, but of a living relationship between water, faith and life itself.

The sacred narrative of Ganga Dussehra recounts how King Bhagirath undertook intense tapasya so that the souls of his ancestors might attain liberation. His penance moved the divine order after which Ganga, a purifying force for spiritual cleansing, agreed to descend from heaven. Because her force was too powerful for the earth to withstand, Lord Shiva caught her in his matted locks and released her in gentle streams, allowing her waters to flow across the land. Within this episode lies a profound civilisational insight that grace must be received with humility, and nature must be approached with reverence.

Across places such as Haridwar, Rishikesh, Varanasi, Prayagraj, and other regions touched by the Ganga and her tributaries, devotees gather in devotion, to take a holy dip, chant prayers and perform aarti to seek ablutions for themselves and their ancestors. Flowers, lamps, milk, fruits and sweets become part of the offering, but the mood remains one of humility rather than display. Water, food, fruits, hand fans, umbrellas and cooling drinks are distributed as acts of charity and service. It is within this framework that the cuisine of Ganga Dussehra has been shaped, not as a single fixed menu, but as a living tradition influenced not only by purpose but the season, sattvic discipline, riverine culture and the ethics of sharing.

The food associated with the day often begins with offerings that are simple, pure and cooling. Fruits such as banana, mango, melon, watermelon, cucumber and seasonal produce are placed before Maa Ganga or offered during household worship. In the heat of Jyeshtha, fruit carries the wisdom of the season as it is light on digestion, nourishes and refreshes, and reminds the devotee that sacred food need not always be elaborate. Alongside fruits, many families offer batasha, mishri, peda, small laddoos and portions of halwa or kheer. These foods are first offered, then received as prasad, and only afterwards enjoyed. This sequence is central to the meaning of the festival, because it places gratitude before consumption. From this foundation of prasad, the house-

hold kitchen gradually opens into a fuller festive meal. In many homes of the Ganga belt, sooji halwa or atta halwa is prepared after the morning worship. Sooji halwa is made by slowly roasting semolina in ghee until its fragrance deepens, then cooking it with water or milk and sweetening it with sugar or jaggery. Cardamom, raisins and nuts may be added, though the preparation often remains simple. Atta halwa, made with whole wheat flour, carries a warmer, earthier taste and a denser texture. Both dishes are associated with worship because they transform everyday grain into something sacred through patience, fire, ghee and offering. When served with puri and sometimes kala chana, the meal becomes familiar, comforting and festive without losing its devotional character.

Kheer brings another important sweetness to the day. Chawal ki kheer is prepared by slowly cooking rice in milk until the grains soften and the milk thickens into a creamy consistency. It is sweetened and flavoured with cardamom, and sometimes enriched with saffron, almonds or raisins. In households observing a fasting discipline, makhana kheer or sabudana kheer may be preferred. Makhana is lightly roasted in ghee before being simmered in milk, while soaked sabudana pearls are cooked until they become soft and translucent. They are enjoyed after puja, shared with children and elders, and often served in small portions because their purpose is not indulgence alone, but auspicious nourishment.

The savoury side of the Ganga Dussehra meal usually reflects the tradition of North Indian sacred cooking. Puri is one of the most familiar preparations, made by kneading wheat flour into a firm dough, rolling it into small discs and frying them until they puff up. It is often paired with aloo sabzi cooked without onion and garlic, using cumin, ginger, green chilli, turmeric, tomato and coriander. The potatoes are simmered until they soften and partially break into the gravy, creating a dish that is simple, satisfying and suitable for a post-puja meal. When fasting rules are stricter, regular flour may be replaced by kuttu or singhara flour, and the puris are prepared with boiled potato added to help bind the dough. These are then served with vrat-style aloo sabzi or plain curd.

Alongside aloo, seasonal vegetables bring balance to the plate. Kaddu ki sabzi is wisely suited to festive meals because pumpkin carries a natural sweetness that responds beautifully to cumin, fenugreek, ginger, turmeric, amchur and

a hint of jaggery. It is soft, mildly tangy and comforting, and pairs well with puri or kachori. Lauki, or bottle gourd, brings an entirely different quality. It is cooling, light and gentle on the stomach, which makes it especially appropriate for a summer festival. Lauki may be cooked dry with cumin and green chilli, or prepared in a light gravy with minimal spices. In a meal that also includes fried items and sweets, such vegetables remind us that Indian festive cooking is not only about richness. It is also about balance, digestion and seasonal intelligence.

In some households, the meal becomes more elaborate with kachori, chana and lentil preparations. Moong dal kachori or urad dal kachori is prepared by stuffing spiced lentil paste into dough and frying it until crisp. The filling is usually seasoned with fennel, asafoetida, cumin, coriander and mild spices. It may be served with aloo sabzi or kaddu, creating a festive combination that is enjoyed after worship or offered to guests. Kala chana, soaked overnight and boiled until tender, may be tempered with cumin, ginger and mild spices, then finished with coriander and lemon. Sometimes it is served as part of a prasad-style combination with halwa and puri. In other homes, moong dal khichdi may replace richer foods. Rice and split moong dal are cooked together with turmeric, cumin, ginger and ghee, resulting in a soft, nourishing preparation that reflects simplicity rather than celebration for its own sake.

For those who observe vrat, the cuisine of the day adapts appropriately. Sabudana khichdi is prepared with soaked tapioca pearls, roasted peanuts, cumin, green chilli, boiled potatoes and sendha namak. A squeeze of lemon brings freshness, while coriander adds aroma. Sama rice khichdi, made from barnyard millet, is cooked with potatoes, cumin and mild spices, and often eaten with curd. These foods allow the devotee to remain within the discipline of fasting while still receiving energy during the summer day. Dahi also plays an important role in this seasonal logic. Plain curd, cucumber raita, boondi raita or dahi aloo may accompany the meal. Cucumber raita, made with grated cucumber, curd, roasted cumin and rock salt, is especially suited to Jyeshtha because it cools the body and softens the heaviness of fried foods besides being a natural probiotic.

The sweet foods of the festival extend beyond halwa and kheer into the broader heritage traditions of the Gangetic region.



The significance of this cuisine is therefore not confined to the dining table. It begins at the riverbank, in the offering, in the home

kitchen, in the act of preparing prasad, in the sharing of fruit, in the serving of water, and in the gathering of family after worship. Elders often guide the ritual order, women shape the offerings with care, children help arrange fruits and sweets, and the household meal becomes a continuation of prayer. In pilgrimage towns, the atmosphere is shaped by temple bells, crowded ghats, flower sellers, lamps, chants and the smell of food being prepared for families, pilgrims and those in need. In homes far from the river, the same spirit is recreated with Ganga jal, seasonal food and remembrance.

What makes Ganga Dussehra cuisine meaningful is not the claim that every dish belongs exclusively to this one festival. Its significance lies in the way these foods gather around a sacred idea. The river gives water, the fields give grain, the cow gives milk, the trees give fruit, and the household gives thanks. Food becomes the bridge between ecology and devotion. Central to this way of life, the flowing waters of Maa Ganga symbolizes both physical nourishment and the possibility of inner purification and spirituality.

In our time, Ganga Dussehra also carries a greater responsibility. To revere Maa Ganga cannot mean prayer alone but respect for rivers, water bodies and the natural systems that sustain life. The cuisine of the day teaches us these lessons and asks us to offer before consuming, share before storing, eat according to season, and recognise that nourishment is never produced by human effort alone. I believe that in preserving such festivals and their culinary traditions, we preserve more than recipes. We preserve a civilisational understanding of gratitude. Ganga Dussehra reminds us that when food is prepared with purity, shared with generosity and received with humility, it becomes more than a meal. It becomes a continuation of sacred memory, flowing like the river herself from one generation to the next.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

## The cognitive battlefield: Insights on ‘The Jihad Tech Complex’

*The Jihad-Tech Complex* by Lt Gen Shokin Chauhan (Retd) bridges military doctrine and transnational security policy, offering a blueprint for modern national security

NAVITA SRIKANT

Maj Gen Deepinder Singh (Retd) eloquently opened the launch of *The Jihad-Tech Complex* by Lt Gen Shokin Chauhan (Retd) at the India International Centre on May 15, 2026, marking a critical intervention in contemporary literature. The event brought together distinguished military leaders, veterans, and security analysts to confront a sobering reality: future conflicts will transcend conventional battlefields, morphing into a complex matrix of radicalisation, proxy warfare, cyber capabilities, information manipulation, and asymmetric tactics. Understanding these changing dimensions is essential for preparedness, resilience, and strategic clarity.

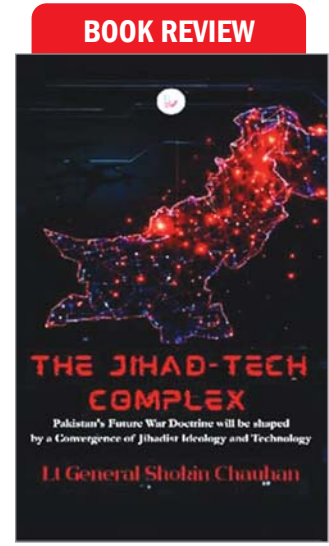
Terror networks no longer depend solely on physical terrain or rugged sanctuaries. Instead, they weaponise encryption, cyber capabilities, and global digital platforms to scale radicalisation, manage logistics, and execute information warfare with precision and speed. Lt Gen Shokin Chauhan's (Retd) work on the convergence of jihadist ideology and technology offers important insights into the future architecture of asymmetric conflict.

The book's themes closely resonated with discussions at the 2022 Special Meeting of the UN Security Council's Counter Terrorism Committee in New Delhi, where I addressed the role of emerging technologies in countering terror financing, as well as at the 15th South Asia Conference under the aegis of MP-IDSA in 2023, where, in my "Special Address", I examined regional instability and cross-border terrorism as major impediments to economic integration in South Asia.

A critical takeaway from the text is that terror infrastructure survives not just through weapons, but through sophisticated financial ecosystems and weak accountability mechanisms. The strategic takeaways from *The Jihad-Tech Complex* took me back nearly 25 years to a mission where I was involved in investigating the diversion of funds to FARC guerrillas in Colombia. Resources

allocated to the Colombian peace process were diverted because ideological ecosystems do not disappear overnight, and financial safeguards proved inadequate to prevent misuse.

Under the garb of humanitarian assistance and sustainability relief, funds often travelled through vul-



**Title:** The Jihad-Tech Complex  
**Author:** Lt General Shokin Chauhan  
**MRP:** ₹1250  
**Publisher:** HAR-ANAND PUBLICATIONS PVT LTD

nerable channels, eventually strengthening networks that thrived on violence and instability. The experience reinforced an enduring lesson: that terror infrastructure survives not only through weapons and ideology, but also through financial ecosystems, influence structures, and weak accountability mechanisms. My shortlisting in 2022 for the UN Security Council's ISIL (Da'esh), Al-Qaeda, and Taliban Sanctions Monitoring Team further deepened my understanding of the nexus between terror financing, ideology, and emerging technologies. This underscores a vital military lesson: kinetic success against individual terror cells is temporary if the grey-zone financial channels feeding them remain intact.

Because technology-enabled ideological warfare respects no physical borders, it frequently expands under the guise of diplomacy, influence, and regional outreach. Consequently, countering state-sponsored terrorism requires shifting national security away from a purely military theatre. It demands unwavering political will backed by a long-term strategy that synchronises state capacity across economic, diplomatic, and technological domains to dismantle the broader ecosystem nurturing state-sponsored terrorism.

In my view, this book is not just

essential military literature, but equally a must-read for the diplomatic cadre. Ideological and technology-enabled warfare today often expands across borders under the garb of diplomacy, influence, and outreach.

As an India-Nepal Relations Observer, I found the book particularly relevant in understanding the intersection of ideology, technology, and regional geopolitical security dynamics in India's neighbourhood. One cannot fight terrorism through a purely military solution alone. Countering state-sponsored terrorism requires unwavering and non-negotiable political will backed by a systematic, long-term strategy across economic, political, diplomatic, technological, and military theatres.

Pakistan's terror infrastructure has evolved through sustained nurturing, financing, ideological conditioning, and technological enablement over decades. Addressing such ecosystems requires far more than tactical responses. It demands coordinated state capacity, financial vigilance, diplomatic clarity, technological preparedness, international cooperation, and resilience against information warfare.

This makes vigilance not merely a military responsibility, but also a diplomatic imperative. India's diplomatic leadership must therefore remain alert to the evolving nature of ideological warfare, influence operations, and technological ecosystems that seek to destabilise national security interests from within and beyond borders.

The challenge is not only to neutralise acts of terrorism, but also to dismantle the networks, narratives, financing channels, and strategic ecosystems that enable and sustain them.

(The book reviewer is a financial, geopolitical, and security analyst, India-Nepal Relations Observer, and former shortlisted candidate for the UN Security Council's ISIL, Al-Qaeda, and Taliban Sanctions Monitoring Team)

## Finding inner balance

SHALINI SRIVASTAVA

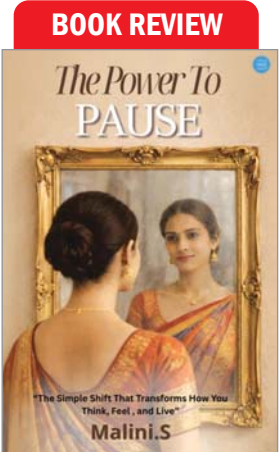
In a world that glorifies speed, reaction, and constant emotional exhaustion, *The Power To Pause* arrives as a gentle yet deeply relevant reminder that transformation often begins in silence. Written by Malini S, an Identity & Self-Worth Leadership Coach, the book explores the emotional patterns many women quietly carry — overthinking, self-doubt, emotional overwhelm, and the pressure to appear “strong” while internally feeling unsettled. Rather than offering loud motivational formulas, the book takes a softer and more introspective route: awareness before action.

What stands out most is the simplicity of the writing. The language is accessible, conversational, and emotionally honest, making the reader feel guided rather than instructed. Malini does not position healing as perfection; instead, she presents it as a gradual process of understanding oneself with compassion. The central idea of “pause” is explored not as avoidance, but as power — the power to observe emotions before reacting, to recognise recurring patterns, and to respond with clarity instead of emotional impulse.

This makes the book particularly relevant for readers navigating anxiety, emotional burnout, relationship stress, or a loss of inner confidence.

The visual presentation of the book also deserves mention. The cover art — featuring a woman looking into her own reflection — beautifully captures the essence of self-awareness and inner rediscovery. It immediately communicates the emotional tone of the book: calm, reflective, and personal. One of the strengths of *The Power To Pause* is that

it avoids sounding overly clinical or overly spiritual. Instead, it sits comfortably between emotional wellness and practical self-leadership. The author's coaching background subtly comes through in the structure of the thoughts and reflections, giving the book a grounded and encouraging voice. At times, readers may wish for deeper real-life exam-



**Title:** The Power To Pause  
**Author:** Malini S  
**MRP:** ₹200  
**Publisher:** Notion Press

ples or more structured exercises, but the simplicity is also part of the book's charm. It feels less like a manual and more like a quiet conversation with someone who understands emotional overwhelm firsthand.

Overall, *The Power To Pause* is a thoughtful and emotionally intelligent read for anyone seeking greater self-awareness, emotional steadiness, and inner clarity. It is especially likely to resonate with women learning to rebuild confidence, redefine self-worth, and reclaim calm in an increasingly noisy world.

(The book reviewer is a Founder of Vizion Beyond consulting)

# Why must we serve?

If you feel guilty or stressed for not finding enough time to serve, or wonder about how much you can serve or achieve on your own, remember one thing. You will never be asked to do what you cannot do. If you are not a doctor, you will not be expected to treat a sick person. Nothing is expected of you that is beyond you

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

The whole world, the entire universe, is one organism, one living being. Each mind is a part of that organism. This is the highest knowledge, and all knowledge must lead to this universal truth.

People suffer when consciousness gets trapped within the boundaries of 'me' and 'mine'. These boundaries are, in fact, mostly a creation of the mind. Examine them closely and you will find they have no real substance. At the most fundamental level of existence, there are no boundaries at all.

When you walk through a city and see someone fall and get hurt, you feel that pain too, even if it is for a moment. That feeling isn't weakness. It is the truest sign of your humanity. If you aren't sensitive to another's pain, even at a small level, something important has become numb inside you.

Every time one feels lonely, one is simply coming in touch with their own boundaries. It is that limitation, that boundary, which is the real cause of your unhappiness. You feel lonely when you seek something from others. This is also the main cause of why we feel depressed. But when you step out from wanting, when you become a giver of happiness to others, how could you be lonely anymore? The whole world will wait to receive your love. Service alone can bring contentment and self-worth.

But the path of service is also not easy. Many people begin seva but stop when they don't receive recognition. They step back when they are humiliated or when they are not given the appropriate position. What they forget is that service without arrogance, love without reason, and knowledge without intellect are what you actually are. When you bring relief or freedom to someone through seva, good vibrations and blessings come to you in abundance. That is the reward, and it arrives before you even look for it. You feel oneness with everyone around you.

There are two types of joy. One is when you receive something. For example, look at kids, how happy they are when they get gifts. This is the infant form of joy. And then, look at your grandparents. They become happy when they give you something.

Your grandmother is so happy to cook for you. This is the second type of joy, the joy of giving, the joy of serving. This is a more mature form of joy.

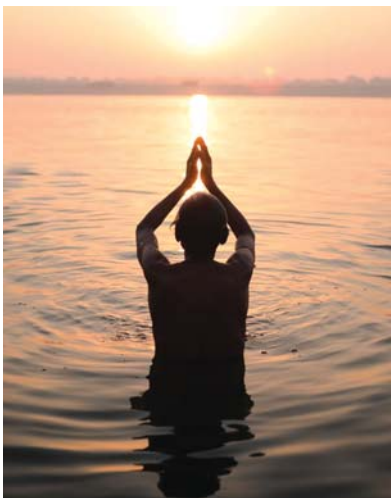
You only need to graduate from the infant joy of receiving to the more mature joy of giving.

What does 'service' really mean? The word 'service' comes from the Sanskrit word 'seva'. Seva means being like the One Divine. When you act like Him, it is called seva. Any faith in God is seva. God doesn't expect anything from serving you. When you do something just for the joy of it, not to get anything out of it, that is seva. God doesn't even want to get joy out of serving the creation. God is joy Himself. The nature of consciousness is joy. Hence, when you are happy with whatever you do, it is an expression of the divinity. So, seva is to do something without expecting anything in return. The more you do, the happier you are. Seeing love inside you is meditation, and seeing God in the person next to you is seva.

Service alone can bring contentment. But service without silence or enough rest tires you. Service without



“SEVA IS TO DO SOMETHING WITHOUT EXPECTING ANYTHING IN RETURN. THE MORE YOU DO, THE HAPPIER YOU ARE” — GURUDEV



GOD DOESN'T EXPECT ANYTHING FROM SERVING YOU. WHEN YOU DO SOMETHING JUST FOR THE JOY OF IT, NOT TO GET ANYTHING OUT OF IT, THAT IS SEVA. GOD DOESN'T EVEN WANT TO GET JOY OUT OF SERVING THE CREATION. GOD IS JOY HIMSELF. THE NATURE OF CONSCIOUSNESS IS JOY. HENCE, WHEN YOU ARE HAPPY WITH WHATEVER YOU DO, IT IS AN EXPRESSION OF THE DIVINITY

spirituality becomes shallow and can't be sustained for long. On the other hand, the deeper your silence and meditative insight, the more dynamic you become outside. Both these elements are essential. They grow together. They are fertiliser for each other. If your meditation is not deep enough, do more seva. Seva brings merit, and merit allows you to go deeper in meditation. Meditation brings back your smile. Meditation offers you the knowledge of the Self. That your innermost source is joy, not sorrow. Sorrow arises only when you forget that. Knowledge

of the Self reverses the tendency to seek love and comfort somewhere outside. When you know that you yourself are love, and that you yourself are light, it is absolutely impossible to be depressed. The way to overcome personal misery is to share in universal misery with knowledge. The way to expand personal joy is to share in universal joy with knowledge. When everyone believes they can contribute something to this world, a divine society begins to emerge.

If you feel guilty or stressed for not finding enough time to serve, or wonder about how much you can serve or achieve on your own, remember one thing. You will never be asked to do what you cannot do. If you are not a doctor, you will not be expected to treat a sick person. Nothing is expected of you that is beyond you. Doing service means only doing what you can do. No one will expect you to be someone you aren't. This realisation itself brings deep rest.

Another way to serve without being tired is to do it without a sense of 'doership'. Work doesn't tire you as much as the sense of doership does. "I" did this. "I" did that. When you carry the weight of being the doer, exhaustion follows quickly. Seva done without that doership is light. It isn't a burden. After doing seva, you feel grateful, not proud. And that gratitude is itself a kind of rest.

Let me share a few practical tips on seva. Make an intention to do public service for even one day a week. Reserve 3 to 4 hours and watch it transform your life. If you think you have done much, you will do very little. If you see that you have done little, you will find yourself doing more. Be grateful for any opportunity to serve. Before age steals your physical abilities, make this breath and body useful to the people around you. If you practise these tips, depression could never bother you.

There is an opportunity for seva wherever you look. Use the awareness cultivated through meditation to see these opportunities and act on them. Authentic seva is guaranteed satisfaction. Not because someone promises it, but because the universe itself is structured that way.

# Gratitude: A Powerful Life Transformer

Every person enjoys success, yet no success is born from the efforts of one individual alone. Behind every achievement stand countless visible and invisible hands. But in the race to claim credit, modern man has forgotten to acknowledge them. Gratitude is the forgotten virtue that heals restless minds, strengthens fragile relationships, and fills empty hearts with contentment. A thankful person spreads warmth in the family, harmony in society, and humanity in the world



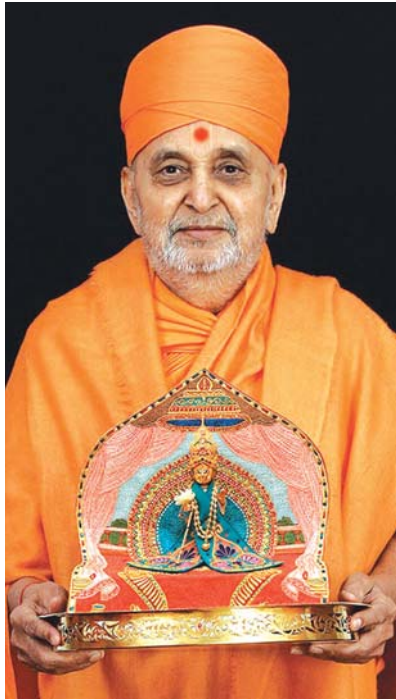
DR SWAMI GYANANANDDAS

On November 6, 2005, the banks of the Yamuna witnessed a moment that entered the cultural history of modern India. The inauguration of Swaminarayan Akshardham, New Delhi, was not merely the opening of a grand Mandir; it was the unveiling of a civilisational dream carved in pink sandstone and white marble. As the evening sky glowed with lights and devotion, distinguished dignitaries from across the nation gathered to honour the occasion. Among those present were the then President of India, APJ Abdul Kalam, PM Manmohan Singh, former Deputy PM Lal Krishna Advani, and the Lieutenant Governor of Delhi. Eminent leaders, diplomats, scholars, sadhus, and thousands of devotees filled the vast assembly grounds. The atmosphere carried both national pride and spiritual reverence.

Speaker after speaker praised the magnificence of Akshardham. Some admired its breathtaking architecture; others marvelled at the organisational excellence behind such a colossal undertaking. Many described it as a modern wonder that had revived the soul of Indian culture. Ultimately, all eyes turned towards Pramukh Swami Maharaj, the quiet and pious guru, whose inspiration, leadership, and relentless sacrifice had transformed an impossible vision into reality.

Yet what followed left the entire gathering deeply moved. When Pramukh Swami Maharaj began to speak, there was no trace of triumph in his words. No sense of personal accomplishment. Standing before one of the grandest Hindu cultural monuments ever built in modern times, he folded his hands with profound humility and offered every ounce of credit to his guru, Yogi Maharaj. With emotion-filled eyes and a voice soaked in gratitude, he said that whatever had happened was solely due to Yogi Maharaj's blessings, prayers, and divine vision.

At that historic moment, the audience witnessed something greater than architecture. They witnessed the feeling of gratitude in Swami's pure eyes. The leaders on the stage appeared visibly touched. The dignitaries who had gathered to celebrate a monument were now witnessing the rare grandeur of



humility itself. In an age where achievement often breeds ego, Pramukh Swami Maharaj transformed praise into gratitude and success into surrender.

Akshardham stood tall in stone, but that evening, an even greater monument arose silently in the hearts of millions: the monument of thankfulness.

Today, we have conquered distances, mastered technology, and built civilisations of extraordinary comfort. Yet, amidst this advancement, one precious virtue, 'gratitude', is quietly disappearing from daily life. Modern society often teaches people to claim credit, highlight personal accomplishments, and place themselves at the centre of success. Yet truly elevated personalities think differently. They recognise the invisible hands behind every achievement; the blessings, guidance, sacrifices, and support that shape one's journey.

Gratitude is not merely saying "thank you". It is a refined vision of life, the noble ability to recognise goodness, acknowledge kindness, and value even the smallest acts of care. A grateful person does not merely live life; he experiences its beauty. Indeed, he walks on the path of true transformation, a transformation that leads from

negativity to positivity, from restlessness to contentment, and from ego to humility.

Surprisingly, the greatest transformations often begin not through grand revolutions, but through small daily acts. A child thanking his mother for preparing food, a husband appreciating his wife's silent sacrifices, a student expressing respect towards his teacher, or a friend acknowledging another's support, these simple expressions create invisible waves of positivity. They soften hearts, dissolve bitterness, and strengthen human bonds.

Human psychology itself confirms this truth. The mind gradually becomes what it repeatedly contemplates. If a person constantly focuses on complaints, shortcomings, and failures, negativity becomes their habitual mental climate. But when one consciously practises gratitude, the direction of thinking changes. The mind slowly shifts from dissatisfaction to contentment, from anxiety to hope, and from scarcity to abundance.

A person who begins the day with thankfulness carries a different energy throughout life. Instead of grumbling over what is absent, he becomes aware of what is already present: the gift of health, family, opportunity, friendship, and existence itself. This awareness generates emotional stability. Even difficulties appear smaller before a thankful mind.

In our daily life, a simple sentence such as "Thank you for always supporting me" can revive affection in relationships that have grown cold. Gratitude acts like oil in the machinery of family life; it reduces friction, prevents emotional wear, and keeps relationships harmonious.

And perhaps that was the deeper message hidden in the emotional eyes of Pramukh Swami Maharaj at the inauguration of Swaminarayan Akshardham. True greatness does not lie merely in achieving great heights; it lies in preserving the depth of humility amidst greatness. Gratitude transforms accomplishment into worship, success into service, and life itself into a celebration of blessings.

(The writer Dr Swami Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)

## Weekly Overview

The week opens under the Leo Moon, bringing confidence, expression and stronger personal assertion. Midweek, Virgo shifts focus toward practical decisions, routines and finer details. By the weekend, Libra brings attention to relationships, balance and thoughtful responses.



**Aries (Mesh):** The week begins with stronger confidence and a natural urge to take charge, making the opening phase useful for personal initiatives or stalled discussions. Midweek asks for practical correction, especially in work matters where details may demand closer attention than expected. Avoid rushing decisions simply because momentum feels favourable. By the weekend, relationships and communication become more important, and balance will matter more than force.



**Taurus (Vrisabha):** The early part of the week may draw your attention toward domestic matters, emotional comfort or practical concerns linked to stability. Midweek brings a noticeably lighter and more constructive tone, supporting creativity, communication and clearer thinking. This can be a useful period for personal expression or organised progress. By the weekend, practical responsibilities return, and routine matters may demand discipline.



**Gemini (Mithun):** The week opens with movement, communication and a stronger exchange of ideas. However, early confidence should not lead to speaking too quickly where sensitivity exists. Midweek shifts attention toward practical concerns, home matters or responsibilities requiring structure. By the weekend, emotional lightness returns, and communication improves again. Social interactions or creative discussions may become more rewarding.

## WEEKLY MOON SIGN FORECAST | 24-30 MAY

### Confidence, Course Correction and the Search for Balance

Dr Shanker Adawal  
Astrologer, Author & Researcher

This forecast is based on your Moon Sign (Janma Rashi), which often reflects day-to-day emotional and instinctive patterns more closely than general Sun-sign readings.



**Cancer (Karka):** Financial awareness and practical judgment may dominate the opening phase of the week. This is a useful time to remain realistic rather than emotional in material decisions. Midweek brings stronger personal focus, with the Moon's movement encouraging greater awareness of your own needs, routines and emotional responses. By the weekend, family matters or relationship expectations may require softer handling. Listening quietly may achieve more than attempting to control the pace of events.



**Leo (Simha):** With the Moon opening the week in your own sign, confidence, visibility and personal presence naturally increase. This can be a productive phase for decisions, leadership or conversations requiring assertiveness. Midweek, however, practical realities may demand greater discipline, particularly around work, finances or commitments. The weekend shifts focus toward communication, meetings and relationship dynamics. Strong presence is useful, but measured expression will bring better outcomes than ego-led reactions.

**Virgo (Kanya):** The opening days may feel quieter, with some matters moving behind the scenes rather than openly. Midweek becomes your stronger phase, as the Moon enters Virgo and brings sharper thinking, practicality and better



organisational clarity. This is the time to correct pending matters or simplify what has become unnecessarily complicated. By the weekend, financial thinking or relationship expectations may require balanced judgment. Avoid overanalysing situations where timing itself is still unfolding.



**Libra (Tula):** The week begins with social movement, discussions or interaction with wider circles, though not every conversation will require equal emotional investment. Midweek becomes more inward, where responsibilities or unresolved concerns may weigh more heavily than expected. Avoid carrying emotional assumptions into practical decisions. By the weekend, the Moon enters Libra, restoring clarity, confidence and emotional balance. This closing phase suits relationship repair, negotiation and thoughtful self-expression.



**Scorpio (Vrischik):** The opening phase may bring attention toward responsibilities, visibility or situations where others expect stronger performance from you. Midweek offers useful support through discussions, planning or perspective-building, making it easier to rethink practical concerns. By the weekend, emotional energy becomes quieter and more reflective. Some matters may require observation rather than immediate action. If something feels unclear, waiting briefly may produce better understanding than forcing conclusions.



**Sagittarius (Dhanu):** The Leo opening supports broader thinking, confidence and movement, making this a constructive time for learning, planning or outward-facing efforts. Midweek shifts attention toward responsibilities, work structure or practical expectations that require steadier discipline.



Avoid impatience with slower-moving matters. By the weekend, relationships and social interactions become more supportive, and perspective improves. Constructive conversations may help clear confusion that seemed heavier earlier in the week.



**Capricorn (Makar):** The week begins with practical seriousness, especially around shared responsibilities, commitments or material concerns requiring realistic judgment. Midweek strengthens professional focus and supports better organisation. This is a useful period for correcting inefficiencies or addressing unfinished matters. By the weekend, visibility increases, but so may emotional sensitivity in interactions. Strong judgment will help, though relationships may respond better to diplomacy than rigid control.



**Aquarius (Kumbh):** Partnerships, communication and interpersonal dynamics may dominate the opening days, requiring patience where others appear emotionally stronger or more expressive. Midweek shifts focus toward practical adjustments, commitments or deeper review of pending matters. This is not a poor phase, but one requiring realism. By the weekend, confidence improves, perspective widens and emotional pressure becomes lighter. A broader outlook will help restore balance.



**Pisces (Meen):** The week begins with routine matters, responsibilities and practical structure demanding stronger attention. Midweek brings clearer personal rhythm, though emotional sensitivity may still colour decisions if left unchecked. By the weekend, emotional depth increases, but so does intuitive clarity. Creative thought and relationship awareness improve during this closing phase. Practical judgment should remain present, but emotional intelligence becomes equally important.